

PRICE \$10.99

THE

OCT. 5, 2026

NEW YORKER



October 5th 2026

- **Goings On**
- **The Talk of the Town**
- **Reporting & Essays**
- **Shouts & Murmurs**
- **Fiction**
- **The Critics**
- **Poems**
- **Cartoons**
- **Puzzles & Games**
- **The Mail**

优质App推荐



英阅阅读器 - 高效阅读英语书! 点击单词即可高效查词(支持自定义mdict词典)、句子翻译、AI学英语、第三方图书源、背单词等一应俱全! [点击下载](#)



语, 带你玩转听说读写! [点击下载](#)

Duolingo - 快乐、高效学外



PDF笔记App, 随时记录你的想法! [点击下载](#)

Notability - 高效、便捷的

Goings On

- [The Sublime Somi Bridges African and Western Jazz](#)
- [Ugly Baby Is Hot but Has a Personality, Too](#)

Goings On

The Sublime Somi Bridges African and Western Jazz

Also: David Greenspan and Lupita Nyong'o onstage, the found-object art of Narcissister, a Hong Kong-born filmmaker's exploration of family history, and more.

By Sheldon Pearce,Shauna Lyon,Dan Stahl,Marina Harss,Jillian Steinhauer,Richard Brody,Ryan Gellis

September 25, 2026

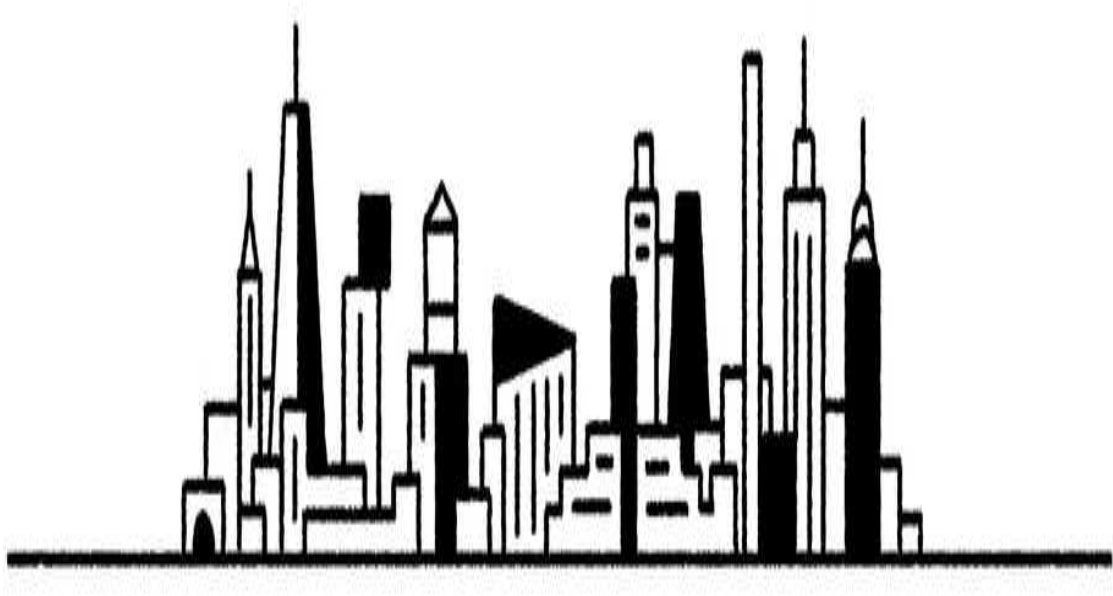


In the past two decades, the singer Laura Kabasomi Kakoma, who performs music mononymously as **Somi**, has become a bridge between Western jazz and the jazz of Africa. An Illinois-born New Yorker of Rwandan and Ugandan descent who grew up in Zambia, she channels her diasporic upbringing into a synergized and singular sound—one anchored by a lovely, fluid voice that is paradoxically both calm and emphatic. She collaborated with the distinguished South African trumpeter Hugh Masekela, helped relaunch Sony's Okeh Records as a jazz label, and released a tribute album for the singer-songwriter and activist Miriam

Makeba. In 2021, Somi became the first African woman nominated in a jazz category at the Grammys.



Somi's work is possessed by its duty to multiple traditions, something the singer has referred to as trying to "tell the truth" of her "dual inheritance." Her songs have a stateliness to them, and yet they are unrestricted in their pursuit of a nuanced pan-African modality, the stories and rhythms at play therein. The 2014 album "The Lagos Music Salon" sought to embody the magic of the titular city, the result of an intracontinental cultural migration. Its 2017 follow-up, "Petite Afrique," was even more ambitious: the song cycle deployed her sublime voice in search of answers for the African immigrants of Harlem as gentrification threatened the community they had built. Somi is also a playwright and actress; she wrote and starred in the Off Broadway musical "Dreaming Zenzile," about Makeba, and starred, on Broadway, in "Jaja's African Hair Braiding." Her new album, "What Does It Take to Bloom?," is a journey inward. Produced with Benjamin James, of the Nigerian highlife band the Cavemen, it is the most poised record of her career, and she brings its songs, and those of her many musical expeditions, [to Sony Hall, on Oct. 1.](#)—*Sheldon Pearce*



About Town

Off Broadway

Marin Ireland's semi-autobiographical play "[Pre-Existing Condition](#)" stars a vivid Lupita Nyong'o as A (the casting will rotate), whose world is reeling with confusion and shame following an incident in which her former boyfriend hit her so hard that she ended up on the floor. (She had tried to slap him a few days before, she offers wanly.) In impressionistic sketches, directed by Maria Dizzia, A struggles through sessions with a therapist (the appealingly forthright Dael Orlandersmith), group counselling (facilitated by the cheeky Sarah Steele and Orlandersmith), a date (Greg Keller, a nuanced charmer), her clueless mother (also Keller). She connects with a guy friend who respects her boundaries—after which, in a fraught meeting with her absentee father, A takes a step in a suddenly clear, positive direction.—*Shauna Lyon (Greenwich House Theatre; through Jan. 8.)*

Off Off Broadway

Tom Stoppard's "**The Invention of Love**" opens with the freshly dead classicist and poet A. E. Housman (a singsongy David Greenspan) reminiscing about his days at Oxford, astir with fin-de-siècle aestheticism and the titillations of his fellow-undergraduate Oscar Wilde (Sam Bolen, transfixing in this role and two others). But the young Housman (Yaron Lotan) took more interest in another student, the strapping Moses Jackson (José Espinosa), for whom his feelings were epitomized by the bond between Achilles and Patroclus, and between other close-knit comrades of antiquity, the field to which he devoted himself. Stoppard's allusiveness is daunting but rewarding—something recognized by the director, Zachary Elkind, whose low-tech but resourceful staging refuses to pander.—*Dan Stahl* ([Theaterlab](#); through Oct. 3.)

Dance



The Gulf of Mexico may not be the first place one thinks of in relation to the ballet choreographers Frederick Ashton and Antony Tudor, and yet the excellent **Sarasota Ballet** has made itself a bastion of the twentieth-century British ballet repertoire. The troupe has also recently taken on several new dancers, including the princely Andrii Ishchuk, lately of American Ballet Theatre. On the program is Tudor's moving portrait of repressed love and

grim marital convention, “Lilac Garden”; the devilishly difficult balcony scene from Ashton’s “Romeo and Juliet,” with lots of tricky hopping on pointe; and the bucolic Peter Wright quartet “Summertime,” set to the shimmering second movement of Mendelssohn’s Second Piano Concerto.—*Marina Harss* ([Joyce Theatre](#); Sept. 29-Oct. 4.)

Pop

The chronically online pop-music fan is obsessive about positioning relative to the market—terms such as “flop era” and “Khia asylum” dominating their conversations about recognition and artistry—and few musicians have been more subject to this discourse than **Slayyyter**. A viral sensation in the halcyon days of Twitter, the singer was on the forefront of a sleaze-pop revival, and her self-titled 2019 mixtape, which found her at the intersection of the dance pop of the mid-two-thousands and the hyperpop still to come, put her on the shortlist of stars-to-be. When that call didn’t arrive, even Slayyyter questioned her career path, and she planned her March album, “Wor\$t Girl in America,” as if it were her last, writing an ode to her iPod. Ironically, in doubling down on herself, she has never been more popular.—*Sheldon Pearce* ([Terminal 5](#); Oct. 3. [Brooklyn Paramount](#); Oct. 4.)

Art

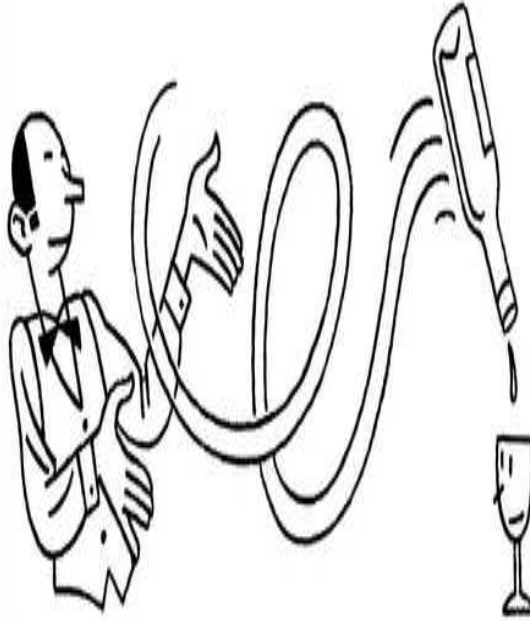


For nearly two decades, the artist **Narcissister** has developed a body of work marked by evocative visual motifs: an idealized feminine face mask, maneuvers involving contortion or sleight of hand, and nudity (her merkin is as common a sight as her mask). Her performances, which mischievously shred expectations of gender and race, have taken place in night clubs and at art museums—and on the TV show “America’s Got Talent.” For this exhibition, she constructed an installation out of found objects which doubles as a Rube Goldberg machine. Amid ropes, barrels, and exercise balls lies the show’s emotional core: seascapes painted by her uncle. She honors them, and a complex family legacy, in her indelibly risqué way, in a handful of performances, during which she wears her aunt’s dresses.—*Jillian Steinhauer* ([Margot Samel](#); through Oct. 10.)

Movies

In “**Palimpsest: The Story of a Name**,” the filmmaker Mary Stephen, a Hong Kong-born, ethnic-Chinese filmmaker, indeed explores the mystery of her own name. Her fascinating, playful quest involves the tangled background of her father, Henry Stephen. After his death, in 1986, she discovered a trove of his diaristic writings and home movies; with these archives she reconstructs his life and her childhood. The film unfolds his

rough-and-tumble youth in Hong Kong; the turmoil of the Second World War; her father's successful career in business; his encounter with the filmmaker's mother, who called herself Hilda; and widespread divisions of class and race. The resulting stories involve surprising intersections of family and politics, of identity and imagination.—*Richard Brody (Streaming on OVID.tv.)*



Bar Tab

Ryan Gellis discovers a beer counter in South Slope.



In sleepy South Slope, a local son in search of a beer bar walked past a familiar, long-shuttered laundromat. He did a double take—the rusting metal window grates were gone, the hulking coin-operated machines nowhere in sight, but an enticing sign had appeared on the awning: “BEER COUNTER.” Inside, people were still dealing in suds, albeit of a different kind. **Mash Inn** had transformed into an airy space, with a blond-wood bar and a forest of potted plants. Sixteen bronze taps stood ready to dispense craft ales, lagers, and a single cider. The patron chose a Cultivar: Cascade, from Wayward Lane Brewing, a hazy pale ale whose tiny bubbles effervesced so vigorously as to mist the upper lip. Two other townies were spotted, and their table was joined. These malt maestros, noting the surrounding mature crowd, wondered about the purported demise of drinking culture while they crunched through a bowl of puffed-rice snacks. The Mash Inn is a relative of the established brewski mecca Gold Star Beer Counter, in Prospect Heights, and has a similarly minimalist menu. In place of a liquor shelf (the establishment sells only beer and cider), there’s a turntable and a library of vinyl—this evening’s up-tempo jazz struggled to compete with the din of a full house. The next round was on the latecomer; a wild ale by the name of Arietta, from Fox Farm Brewery, floral and largely flat, had a pleasing barnyard funk. A Subglitch sour was rechristened “Jolly Rancher light.” It was conceded that the catalogue of brews outmatched the finite power of the liver. Upon decampment, the drowsy drinker is met with

one final chance to imbibe, at the outside window, its sliding partition reminiscent of a Mister Softee's. A growler of stout makes for pleasant company on the walk home.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [Designing the commonplace](#)
- [How Leonard Cohen smelled](#)
- [Victor Garber's life-changing Jesus](#)

The Food Scene

Ugly Baby Is Hot but Has a Personality, Too

The beloved Brooklyn restaurant is back to serve a city in the thrall of Thai spiciness.

By Helen Rosner

September 20, 2026



If you listened carefully, almost two years ago, on the day that the Carroll Gardens Thai restaurant [Ugly Baby](#) announced that it would be closing, you could almost hear a wail of anguish rising up over Brooklyn. The chef, Sirichai Sreparplarn, a Bangkok native, opened Ugly Baby, in 2017, as a place to show off the fruits of years of gastronomic research into Thai cuisine: the fermented, spiced, herbaceous, sour, complex cuisine of the north; the turmeric-stained, shrimp-funked, chili-loaded cooking of the country's south. Sreparplarn's menu was expansive, but diners crammed into the narrow, color-saturated dining room for a few dishes especially, chief among them a duck *laab* and a *kua kling* (a beef dry curry), both obliteratingly spicy. The restaurant became known as not just one of the best

Thai restaurants in town but the most reliable for nuclear detonation—the thinking person’s place to go get your face blasted off.

At the time, Sreparplarn said that he closed Ugly Baby because he just needed a break. The crowds had been relentless, the dining room packed and chaotic at all hours, and he wanted some time and space to regroup, and maybe to write a cookbook. He signed the lease for the space over to some former Ugly Baby employees who, with Sreparplan’s blessing, flipped it into Hungry Thirsty, a very good not-quite-tribute restaurant that specialized in Thai street food, and then he slipped off the stage. And now, almost as suddenly, he’s back: Ugly Baby is born again, in Williamsburg this time, in a window-lined, B.Q.E.-adjacent space more than twice the size of its former digs.

As before, Sreparplarn is in the kitchen, putting together dazzling dishes both familiar and unfamiliar; as before, Ugly Baby is a restaurant in which everything is amplified, not just the Scoville count. The room is again bright and brash, now with a long mirrored bar filling one wall, its bottles glittering in the maximalist space like a Marilyn Minter painting. The music is thumpy, up-tempo, and loud. While there’s more space between tables now—and a lower-level dining room for overspill—this is still not a restaurant built for quietude, or connection. You don’t come to Ugly Baby for conversation, any more than you would a night club; like a night club, it’s a place for (if you’re in the mood) pleasurable overwhelm, or (if you’re not—but then, why are you here?) unbearable sensory chaos.



Sreparplarn's new menu is divided into three categories, in ascending order of smolder: the Laughs, for the soft-palated; the Cries, for the tenuously brave; and the Ugly, which I suppose is for the self-loathing, or the self-indulgent, or the asbestos-tongued. I think of myself as part of the last group—I'm no chili-head, seeking heat above all else, but I do like a little bit of that dopaminergic thrill, which the psychologist Paul Rozin, studying the human drive to burn ourselves with chilies, has described as "benign masochism." So I dived right into the deep end, ordering without fear: a soft stir-fry of ground pork belly, umami-charged with shrimp paste and garnished with slivers of tomato-red hot peppers, whose heat crackled and blossomed against a caramel sweetness in the sauce. A salad of whole strawberries and bird's-eye chilies, in a glaze-like dressing of sugar and fish sauce, was uncannily dessert-like—Would I like this on ice cream? I kept wondering—and yet certainly not a dessert, with all its thunderous layers of sourness and fishy-breathed complexity. I wished that I was in a quieter room when I took a bite of the *pad ped*, a dry curry of hanger steak and slippery tripe: it was rich and deep as nighttime, with a holy-basil brightness swaddled in some of the most violent heat I've ever experienced.

The new Ugly Baby was packed on each of my visits, with hopeful walk-ins circling the bar and clustered on the sidewalk outside. The staff, while friendly, seemed oddly unprepared for the crush. There seemed to be too few

servers, too many hovering hosts urging diners into a quick turnaround, and far too many instances (one!) of forgotten, and sorely needed, additional bowls of heat-muffling white rice. It was clear, from the snippets of conversation that I could catch against the clamor of the sound system, that plenty of folks were having their first Ugly Baby experience, perhaps drawn by the challenge of its most ferocious dishes. But dining as heat-seeking can have a reductive effect. Just look at what happened to Jitlada, in L.A., which catapulted to international fame on the strength of a *kua kling* that the late critic Jonathan Gold declared “may be the spiciest food you can eat in Los Angeles.” Gold wrote that the rest of Jitlada’s menu was marvellous, too, full of dishes subtle and adventurous and spiky and soft, but the rest of his rave was mostly eclipsed by all the talk of spice.



Ugly Baby—both before and now—is more than just a place to show off your oh-so-manly pain tolerance, or to punish your digestive tract. One of my favorite dishes on the new menu (virtually none of which is carried over from Ugly Baby 1.0) is a soup, mild and gentle, in which bob wisps of omelette and soft pork meatballs, and you’d be remiss to breeze past a whole fried fish in the Laughs portion of the menu. A pompano on my visits, it was served with a tarry, sticky relish made up of seemingly every herb and spice and aromatic in the world, except for chilies. There were pumpkin fries, too,

crispy and sweet, and a rich vegan curry of pineapple and eggplant thick with coconut milk, threaded with just a whisper of heat.

But we are, as a city, in the throes of a Thai-spiciness rapture. The owners of Hungry Thirsty expanded earlier this summer, with the opening of Hungry Spicy, in Chelsea; the new outpost is themed entirely around chilies and heat, almost to the point of goofiness, with chili-pepper décor and flame-shaped Mylar balloons floating against the fire-hued walls. I'll admit that all the hype got to me: when I dropped in for dinner recently, I made sure that my purse was stocked with Tums and milky hard candies, to gird myself against flames of a strength I figured I'd never previously known. I shouldn't have worried so much. The food was good, and plenty spicy—if not eyeball-melting, as one critic's description of the *kua kling* as “genuinely unpleasant” had led me to expect—though most dishes felt a little single note, relying on the heat alone to bring the razzle-dazzle.

Helen, Help Me!

[E-mail your questions](#) about dining, eating, and anything food-related, and Helen may respond in a future newsletter.

At Ugly Baby, even if half the room is there to performatively get their sinuses blown out, Sreparplan's use of heat never feels like a gimmick. In a furnace-blasting *kang prik* (a dry red curry) of pork leg and pork rinds, the heat morphs from bite to swallow, blossoming from a distant crackle of fire to a sparking, tear-inducing electrocution. In the intervening seconds, there are other flavors dipping and twirling: the earthy sweetness of galangal and lemongrass, gently sulfuric garlic, vivid slashes of makrut lime. The heat deepens the dish; it doesn't undermine, it doesn't steal the spotlight. It ruins you, and opens you, and readies you for more. ♦



An earlier version of this article misidentified two of the dishes pictured.

The Talk of the Town

- [The President vs. the Press](#)
- [Are Public Spaces Really for the Public?](#)
- [More Sunshine with Joey Arias and Basil Twist](#)
- [Detecting Notes of . . . Citi Field?](#)
- [Cartoon Recession Indicators](#)

Comment

The President vs. the Press

Donald Trump's behavior cannot be called unexpected at this point. What was noteworthy last week, however, was the way that the media responded.

By Jelani Cobb

September 27, 2026



Donald Trump's decision, on September 18th, to summarily revoke White House access from three major news outlets—CNN, *Politico*, and MS NOW—is consistent with the mercurial, paranoid, and inscrutable style that has defined his political career but has been particularly prominent in his second term. Since Trump returned to the Presidency, his Administration has tended to justify its most belligerent actions by claiming national-security concerns or by couching said actions as an attempt to root out fraud. Earlier this year, the *Times* noted that Trump had cited “national security” as justification for acts as disparate as halting the development of wind farms off the East Coast, stripping union rights from federal employees, and continuing the construction of his behemoth ballroom. (He is now making the same argument regarding his colossal arch.) Accusations of fraud have been the reasoning for *doge*'s evisceration of the federal workforce, *ice*'s occupation

of Minneapolis, and, just last week, the removal of three-quarters of a million people from the Affordable Care Act rolls. In a frenzied attempt to retrofit a rationale for Trump's abrupt press ban, the White House turned to some version of both of these arguments.

Last Monday, the three news outlets filed suit, claiming that the ban violated their First Amendment rights. Dozens of other media organizations, including the *Times* and Condé Nast, which owns *The New Yorker*, filed an amicus brief in the case. Other outlets refused to participate in pool coverage of the President's events, in solidarity with their banned peers. On Tuesday, the Department of Justice responded by claiming, in a brief, that the organizations had "threatened national security and spread falsehoods." Further, it asserted that access to the White House is "a privilege," not a right. Embarrassingly, the same day, the White House sent *Politico* a letter citing its reporting on the Iran war, which noted the concerns of an anonymous source, as an example of compromising national security. That source, *Status* reported, was Vice-President J. D. Vance, on a background briefing, highlighting yet another instance in which the right hand was unaware of what the right hand was doing.

In a Truth Social post announcing the ban, Trump had complained that "Media Outlets shouldn't be able to constantly write or report FICTION and LIES when they're covering the President of the United States." This isn't exactly an accusation of defrauding the public, but it pretty clearly charges the banned organizations with, at a minimum, misleading it. That said, even Trump seemed to know that he was on shaky ground, preemptively arguing that the U.S. district judge hearing the case, Timothy J. Kelly, whom Trump himself had appointed, was an unfriendly draw for the Administration's claims.

The ban followed the now familiar path of Trump's potentially illegal or unconstitutional acts. As with his attempts to slap his name on the Kennedy Center and his effort to overrule the language of the Fourteenth Amendment, by curtailing birthright citizenship, that path typically travels from absurd idea to absurd (but nonetheless concerning) act, to a legal response that becomes another case study in which we evaluate the extent to which the judicial system is capable of reining in the arbitrary impulses of an aspiring autocrat.

Trump's concerns about the current case, at least in the short term, proved warranted. Shortly after midnight on Thursday, Kelly imposed a fourteen-day suspension of the ban. That morning, the journalists were still denied entry, so Kelly issued a 12:30 *p.m.* deadline for compliance, and their access was restored. Meanwhile, China's President, Xi Jinping, had arrived in Washington for his first state visit in eleven years. Photographers on the scene reported that Trump joked that China has the "friendliest press corps." (According to Reporters Without Borders, China ranks a hundred and seventy-eighth out of a hundred and eighty nations in press freedom.) That evening, some of the journalists were again denied access.

It's worth recalling the degree to which this debacle typifies Trump's political behavior. During the 2016 election, he withheld campaign-event credentials from Univision, BuzzFeed, the *Washington Post*, and *Politico*. During his first term, he routinely blocked critics and news organizations from his Twitter feed, which resulted in a lawsuit and a district-court ruling that his actions were unconstitutional. In 2018, the Administration denied access to Jim Acosta, then a reporter for CNN. (Kelly also ruled in that case, requiring the White House to restore Acosta's access.) Last year, the White House denied access to the Associated Press, for refusing to defer to Trump's preferred designation for the body of water generally known as the Gulf of Mexico. In that instance, the district judge Trevor N. McFadden, another Trump appointee, ruled that "under the First Amendment, if the Government opens its doors to some journalists . . . it cannot then shut those doors to other journalists because of their viewpoints." He added, "The Constitution requires no less." The President has sued ABC News, the *Wall Street Journal*, CBS News, the Pulitzer Prize Board, the *Washington Post*, and the *Times*, for hundreds of millions of dollars. His behavior cannot be called unexpected at this point. What was noteworthy this time, however, was the way that the press responded.

A month after the 2016 election, Ben Smith, then of BuzzFeed, lamented that few organizations had come to the defense of the outlets blocked during the campaign. *The New Yorker's* Susan B. Glasser, who was then with *Politico*, noted that it would be "a terrible disservice to our democracy to have the President of the United States in the business of banning reporters." A decade later, Trump is in that business, yet it is still not standard for news organizations to come to one another's defense. The A.P. ban didn't elicit

nearly as much reaction. Several organizations sued by Trump opted to settle in cases that they likely could have won. Moreover, the White House Correspondents' Association dinner, the annual gala celebration of the First Amendment, was held in April despite an intimidation campaign directed at some of those correspondents. After the event was disrupted by an armed intruder, the Administration and the association scheduled a July do-over, where Trump delivered a rambling speech indulging seemingly every tangent that sprang to mind, but his contempt remained apparent. The united front that journalists presented last week is significant, even inspiring, but, if history is any predictor, it will not be the last time they will be called on to do so. ♦

In the Streets

Are Public Spaces Really for the Public?

A group of locals is trying to reclaim city spots for the people—including lobbying to turn vacant lots into gardens and fighting the event venue Guastavino’s over a courtyard.

By Parker Henry

September 26, 2026



“In New York City, the streets are your living room,” Jack Espel said the other day, at a coffee shop on East Fifty-ninth Street. Espel, a middle-school history teacher, is part of a group of Midtown East residents who are organizing to transform what they call “derelict parks” into cheery public spaces. That day, they’d met to discuss their goal of turning two dilapidated lots into pocket parks.

Sean Basinski, a semi-retired lawyer who heads the group, was at the center of a recent local kerfuffle: Guastavino’s, a seven-thousand-square-foot event venue situated under the ramp to the Queensboro Bridge, had been treating a

small park out front as its private property—roping it off and shooing away pedestrians. “During *COVID*, I brought some kettlebells over to do a workout, and the guard kicked me out,” Basinski said. Later, he tried to use the plaza as a backdrop to photograph some shoes he was selling on eBay, and was again told to leave. “We had words,” he said.

“I did some digging and found out that the park belongs pretty obviously to the City of New York,” Basinski said. He filed a class-action lawsuit against Guastavino’s, alleging “brazen and illegal seizure of public space” and stating that, on a “nearly daily basis,” Guastavino’s evicts the “general public from a public plaza” by selling and marketing “exclusive access to . . . their ‘private garden.’ ” Guastavino’s swiftly removed the “Private Property” signs.

Parks are few and far between in midtown. “We’re park-starved,” Basinski said.

Justin Nuttall, a data manager who grew up nearby, was at the coffee-shop meeting. He described leaving the neighborhood for the first time as a child: “We went to Brooklyn as a family, and I remember being afraid of the grass because I didn’t know what it was.”

Susan Blackwell, a retired copywriter who lives on Sutton Place, chimed in. “My husband grew up on Fortieth and Third, and they used to walk the dog in Grand Central,” she said. “I don’t think he saw a leaf until he went to camp.”

“It’s so uncool to live here that it’s cool,” Nuttall said. “My wife laughed when I told her I grew up in Midtown East.”

Anna Arima, an event planner who moved from Ukraine, has lived in midtown for twelve years. “I used to work for the mayor in Kyiv, which used to be the greenest city in Ukraine,” she said. “When I moved here, I was looking for a way to beautify the community the way we did in Kyiv.” Her super had told her about Basinski’s group.

Others joined after seeing signs Basinski had posted by vacant lots in the neighborhood. “*DOES THIS LOOK GOOD TO YOU?*” one read, next to

renderings of what the space could become.

Nuttall had done the visuals. “I just messed around with A.I.,” he said.

The group went to look at the space that was on the day’s agenda: two neighboring lots—fenced off and locked—that span Fifty-ninth Street between First and Second Avenues. All that was there was a dirty tennis ball, a few patches of grass, and a crushed beer can. Kevin Eerkes, a member of the group, stopped as he was jogging by. He removed an AirPods. “The pigeons love these lots,” he said. “And we could, too!”

The group members nodded. As for what the lots should become, Nuttall said, “Well, that has to be crowdsourced when the city finally lets us do something.”

“We’re thinking industrial chic!” Blackwell said. Other ideas were floated: a dog run, an outdoor café.

“Literally just some green for people to lounge on,” Basinski said. “The goal is to get the city to spend the money to turn this into something other than a dump.”

Two years ago, Basinski had had a call with a commissioner at the Department of Transportation, which is responsible for one of the lots. (The spot is a vestige of the Queensboro Bridge’s construction. Originally, tenement buildings stood there.) “He acknowledged the city is not using the space well,” Basinski said. Another D.O.T. rep recently claimed that the lot can’t be repurposed for the public at all. Basinski’s group has collected nine hundred signatures to support the cause. The next step is a meeting with the Community Board. “We’re finally on Board 8’s agenda for next month’s meeting,” he said.

The group was buoyed by a recent local success story. “Did you hear about the Hunter students?” Espel asked. He was referring to the college kids who, in July, had lobbied the city to turn a half block of curb space on East Sixty-ninth Street, by Hunter College, into what they called a “vibrant public gathering space.”

“It’s essentially a few parking spots that the city’s going to let them put some chairs on,” Espel said, dismissively.

“Parking spaces are hallowed,” Blackwell reminded him.

The midtown group has its haters. “Some people say that, if the lots are converted, no one’s going to want to sit there,” Basinski said. “It’s right next to the bridge. It’s noisy.” He went on, “But we’re all already here, next to the bridge. I’m breathing this air, hearing this noise. Let’s at least make it nice.” ♦

Twist Again Dept.

More Sunshine with Joey Arias and Basil Twist

The performance artist and the puppeteer are reviving their avant-garde cabaret show, a leggy fantasia beloved by Cyndi Lauper and the late Paul Reubens.

By Sarah Larson

September 28, 2026



Recently, at the *HERE* Arts Center, near SoHo, the puppeteer Basil Twist, the performance artist Joey Arias, and six unseen puppeteers (“They’re wearing black velvet, hood on, like ninjas,” Twist said) were rehearsing the grand finale of “Arias with a Twist,” their cabaret fantasia from 2008. To the zingy “You Gotta Pull Strings,” from “The Great Ziegfeld,” puppet chorus girls in feathers and fish-nets exited the stage, a Mylar curtain opened, and Arias—Bettie Page bangs, sheer top, Adidas pants—entered, sprawled on a Twistian three-layer cake with showgirls’ legs extending from it like flower petals. Mirrors appeared, the music intensified, and King Kong-size showgirl calves stepped in from stage left and stage right. Meanwhile, the

cake wiggled uncertainly. Twist called out, “Can we pause?” He crouched in front of the cake, raising its white fabric frosting. “How can we help?” he asked.

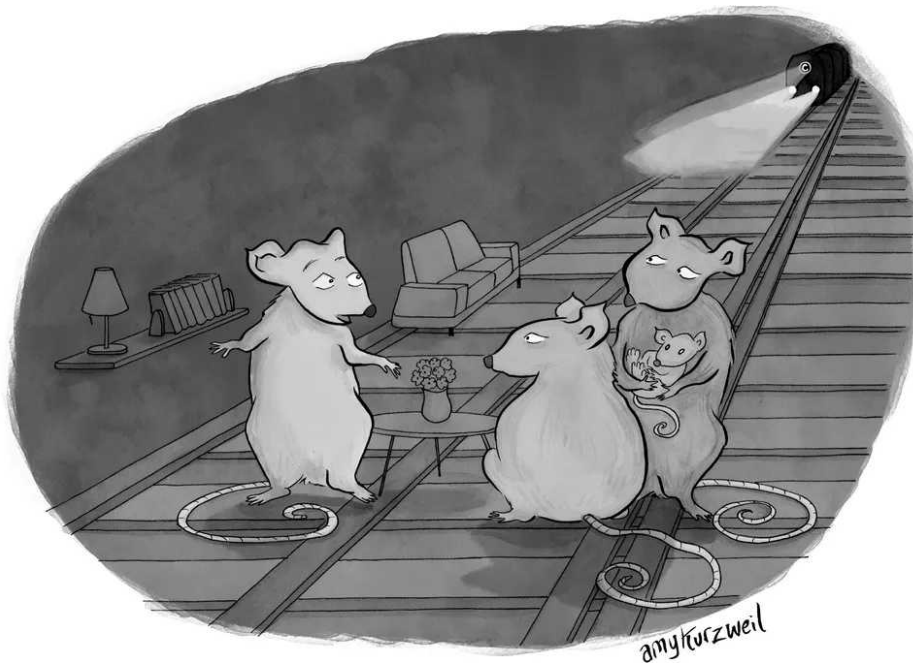
“Hmm,” the cake said. After they chatted, Twist stood. “Let’s take it from the Mylar curtain!” Triumph: the cake spun like a top, its legs high-kicking in unison. Arias, blissful, waved his own legs in the air.

The Center’s theatre, named for Twist’s grandmother Dorothy B. Williams, is underground; upstairs, Twist and Arias talked about the revival. “It feels fantastic,” Arias, who wouldn’t disclose his age (“I like to round up to a hundred”), said. “It’s, like, more sunshine, more happiness. It is never, like, ‘Oh, it’s too much beauty! Too much art!’ ”

Twist, who is fifty-seven, said that they’d written the show quickly, after *HERE*, Twist’s artistic home, had a sudden cancellation. He’d approached Arias, who had just returned from Las Vegas after an eight-year stint starring in Cirque du Soleil’s “Zumanity.” Arias, a fan of Twist’s productions, was game. “Every time I saw Basil, I was, like, ‘Put me in the show!’ ” he said. They wrote it together. “He goes, ‘What do you want to do?’ ” Arias recalled. “I said, ‘Get abducted by aliens, go on an acid trip, and have a Busby Berkeley finale with a big cake!’ ” They riffed on themes for Arias’s return: A desert? Dalíesque Surrealism? Ooh, a jungle?

“We got a whole bunch of donated green fabric, and there was suddenly a jungle,” Twist said. “Corduroy, velvet, cotton, silk.”

The two friends met in the mid-nineties, through Twist’s then boyfriend, whom Arias had met while working at a boutique. “Everybody went to Fiorucci!” Arias said. “This beautiful blond guy—hot pants in the summertime, skating, like, wow!—goes, ‘I’m Bobby Miller. I’m a photographer.’ ” One night, at the club Jackie 60, “Bobby said, ‘I want to introduce you to my boyfriend, Basil Twist.’ ”



Twist said, “Bobby introduced me to a whole world of night life. I had just returned to New York from puppet school in France.” (Twist was the first American to graduate from l’École Nationale Supérieure des Arts de la Marionnette.) He first came to *HERE*, with Miller, for “a gay country-Western cabaret called ‘Y’all.’ Bobby was doing his poetry, and I did a little puppet show,” he said. “Later, I did a bigger project here with Mabou Mines. And the Halloween parade also starts outside these doors! By the way, this year, Joey’s going to be the grand marshal.”

“The daughter of darkness!” Arias said. “I’m representing what the avant-garde, what art, stands for, and that it’s thriving and it’s alive. It’s going to be beautiful.”

Twist and Arias first performed together at a launch party for the fashion publication *MAO MAG*. “I have these marionettes of my grandfather’s on display in the case outside the theatre,” Twist said. His grandfather, a bandleader, had several bandleader puppets—Harry James, Cab Calloway, Paul Whiteman, Arturo Toscanini, and Ted Lewis, each playing an instrument. “I thought, I’ll use these puppets for Joey, because I love him.” On a little stage, “they came alive with Joey flirting with them, playing with them.” The puppets return in the revived “Arias with a Twist,” and the chemistry remains.

Another creative factor was Thierry Mugler, who had designed costumes for “Zumanity” in the early two-thousands. Arias said, “He came with me to see Basil and started to sketch the little nude corset with the little velvet bikini: ‘This is the way you should look.’ ”

The show delighted and astounded many. “Paul Reubens and I were good friends,” Arias said. “He came, and the whole time he was like this”—gobsmacked. “Afterward, he said, ‘Joey, I hate you.’ That meant ‘I love you.’ I said, ‘I know, I hate ya, too. May I introduce you to Basil Twist?’ And immediately he wrapped himself around Basil and the rest of us.” Twist later worked with Reubens on his 2010 Broadway version of “The Pee-wee Herman Show”: Chairry, Globey, and the gang live onstage.

At the revival’s first preview at *HERE*, Twist greeted the audience and pointed out emergency exits, and a New York-accented audience member yelled, “Like a *airplane!*” This turned out to be another Friend of Pee-wee, Cyndi Lauper. After the show, she embraced Arias. “The one and only!” she said. ♦

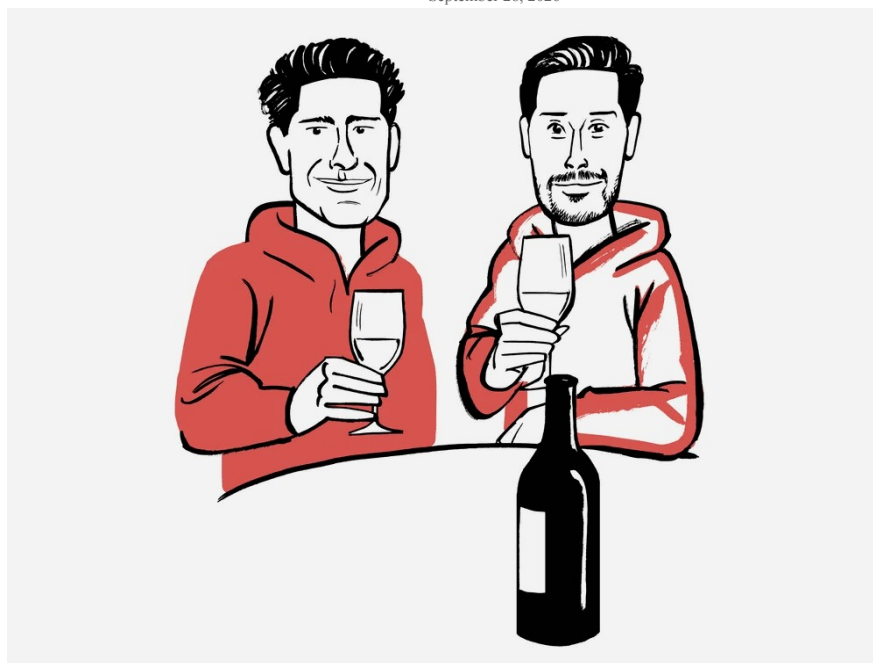
Tasting Dept.

Detecting Notes of . . . Citi Field?

In the parking lot outside a Mets game, the TikTok sommeliers Ryan and Chris Goydos, of SuperVinoBros, crack open a mystery wine and guess its provenance.

By Arthur Holland Michel

September 28, 2026



On a moonless Friday night at Citi Field, Ryan Goydos, one half of the popular social-media account known as SuperVinoBros, stood at a security entrance reserved for staff, press, mascots, players, and eminences, waiting for his fraternal twin brother, Chris, the other half of the bros, to arrive.

Like the Mets, wine is in a rut. Globally, people drank about a billion fewer gallons of it last year than they did in 2007. The industry has not adapted to the social-media era. The SuperVinoBros, who post fun, peppy videos about their drinking adventures, are determined to change that.

The brothers have close to four hundred and fifty thousand followers across Instagram and TikTok, hailing largely from a young demographic that's

often wary of wine and its stuffy traditions. The renowned sommelier Aldo Sohm is a fan. *Wine Enthusiast*, a magazine of the Old Guard, named the bros “Rising Stars” for 2026. Clips of their exploits have been watched tens of millions of times.

At Citi Field, Ryan had already spent two hours filming content. Inside the stadium’s Cadillac Club, he had tried a lobster roll with a Sauvignon Blanc that made him scrunch his nose (off camera). Chris, a surgical resident at a New Jersey hospital who joins his brother on his days off, had been held up performing a right hemicolectomy on a gunshot victim. He had been working since 6 *A.M.*

“Sorry I was late,” Chris said, when he arrived.

“Bro,” his bro replied. “You were saving lives.”

On the concourse, a young man in a black Francisco Lindor jersey dapped the brothers. Their most popular videos are their blind tastings. In traditional blinds, dour sommeliers in waistcoats sniff out the differences between cuvées grown a few miles apart in Burgundy’s Côte d’Or. The brothers usually blind in Chris’s living room, in New Jersey, often while wearing hoodies.

The bros settled into their seats at the bottom of the seventh. They filmed their first blind in 2024. “We always talked about whether it would be easy or not,” Chris said.

It was not easy. That first time, Ryan broke the cork, and Chris guessed way off.

“I was, like, ‘Oh, we shouldn’t post this,’ ” Ryan recalled, sipping an Allagash White. “And Chris was, like, ‘Dude, no. We should absolutely post it.’ ”

The video did well. “It started a very fruitful losing streak,” Chris, who was also drinking beer, said.

The brothers have since filmed around seventy-five blinds. Naturally, they keep score. Ryan has nailed it three times. Chris has clocked either the

region or the variety (“half points”) eight times.

The game ended—Mets 2, Marlins 5. The bros headed to the parking lot. They had hoped to shoot a blind in the clubhouse, or in a box. Absolutely not, they had been told. Instead, they set up in the red glow of the tail-lights of a Lexus hybrid owned by Chris’s wife, Akanksha. “We’re at Citi Field right now, blind tasting,” Ryan said into his phone.

He popped the bottle, which was tucked into a lime-green athletic sock, and poured red wine into two plastic cups.

“Oh, shit—it’s the cops,” Chris said. A squad car pulled up, then rolled on. The brothers’ faces caught a blue flicker.

Scientists believe that the hundreds of olfactory receptors in a human nose can discern more than a trillion distinct scents. “It’s got this blueberry, raspberry, light-berry vibe to it,” Chris said, sniffing thoughtfully.

Out of frame, Ryan’s girlfriend, Carolina Mahedy, a former sommelier at Le Bernardin, nosed a glass. “Blinding is like walking down a hallway where all the doors are open,” she had said earlier.

To a novice taster, sipping out of a plastic Mets carafe, the wine smelled like dry grass and very ripe blackberries. Syrah, perhaps?

Mahedy closed her eyes. “This is Cabernet Franc,” she whispered.

Chris sucked air through his teeth. “If it was gonna be a French red, I’d call it a Cab Franc from the Loire Valley.” A 7 train rattled by. He sipped again. “It could be, like, a California Pinot.” He shone his phone’s light through the cup to check for the brown tinge of a Nebbiolo. “Nah, that’s pretty red,” he said. “So I will call this a Pinot Noir from California.”

Ryan handed his brother the bottle. “So, this is—”

Chris yanked off the sock and blinked at the label.

“—a Cab Franc from the Loire Valley!”

Mahedy nodded.

“Fuck! Fuuuck!” Chris looked at his brother. If he had stuck with his original guess, he’d have hit his first homer.

“You were really close!” Ryan said. He cackled.

“Call it the yips,” Chris said.

As the lot emptied, the brothers stuck around to savor the wine. Ryan had just returned from a trip to Bordeaux with Jimmy Butler, the Golden State Warriors’ wine-obsessed forward (record: half a point on one blind). They had put up shots on a hoop at Cos d’Estournel. But blinding out of plastic in Queens, Ryan thought, was just as special.

“Wine is the ultimate social medium,” Chris observed. Everyone nodded.

It was nearing midnight. Chris had to be back at the hospital in six hours. The bottle was almost finished. The bros were drinking to the lees. ♦

Sketchpad

Cartoon Recession Indicators

Is your life savings a single moth? Are you afflicted with moola eyes? It might be a sign we're in a downturn.

By Ali Fitzgerald

September 28, 2026



CARTOON RECESSION INDICATORS

YOU "AMOOGA" AFTER SEEING YOUR FRIEND'S RENT-CONTROLLED APARTMENT.



YOUR BUSTED OLD BOOT IS CONSTANTLY CRITIQUING YOUR SPENDING DECISIONS.



AT THE GAS STATION, YOUR SPEECH BUBBLES ARE MOSTLY FILLED WITH POUND SIGNS AND EXCLAMATION MARKS.



YOU SUMMON A DARK MIRASMA ABOVE YOUR HEAD WHENEVER YOU THINK OF THE FUTURE.



YOU'RE AFFECTED BY "MOOLA EYES," MAKING YOU AN EASY TARGET FOR SCAMMERS.



Reporting & Essays

- [Hockey Dads and Hockey Sons](#)
- [How Paweł Pawlikowski Learned to Film Europe's Fractures](#)
- [Should I Stay or Should I Go?](#)
- [Why Doesn't Anyone Want to Fix One of America's Scariest Roads?](#)

Personal History

Hockey Dads and Hockey Sons

Parenting is a practice. You learn from your mistakes and then repeat them anyway.

By Nick Paumgarten

September 28, 2026



We walked single file through the snow to Lasker Rink, escorted by the coaches. Central Park at night, 1977: in the swirl of a storm, the Park was desolate and pristine. I was eight and had been invited to start skating with the older boys at school. I'd had hockey on the brain for a year, and yet had never really gone to a hockey practice. The Zamboni did a quick dry sweep while we suited up, and then we spilled through the gate onto the ice. Someone dumped out a milk crate full of pucks. I'd never seen such abundance—they may as well have been gold ingots. We scooted and stickhandled around one another, the clatter of our sticks and the rip of our blades muffled by the storm. Whatever anxiety I'd felt about getting out there with the older kids gave way to a saucer-eyed vigilance, the air as bracing as a hit of smelling salts.

Mr. Mila was the hockey coach. His full name was Miloslav Pospisil. He'd been in the Czechoslovak Army and had played on the Czech national hockey and soccer teams. The story we were told was this: One day on the street, in 1968, after the Soviet invasion in response to the Prague Spring, he saw a Soviet soldier shoot a woman who had refused to remove a flower pinned to her overcoat—a rose, the unofficial Czechoslovak national flower. Mila rushed home and told his wife to pack up, and they made their way to the border, then on to Montreal and, later, to New York.

Mila had a military crewcut and a perpetual look of disdain for us kids. We knew him from gym class and were terrified of him. If you horsed around, he pulled you out of the herd and lifted you up by the hair and skin behind your ear. He called this Depozit. He had hoisted boys clear off the ground, sneakers dangling. On the ice, he wore red sweatpants and old skates, and used a stick with a straight blade, no curve at all. He had big thighs and took powerful strides and barked at us with a Slavic severity that we associated with Russian movie villains. An undercurrent of irony, of playacting, went over our heads.

I was the only third grader on the team. A month into the season, I was asked to join the other kids at a peewee tournament upstate. Peewees were eleven and twelve years old. Clearly, they needed bodies. This would be my first-ever organized hockey game. The day before the tournament, at practice, an older kid caught me with a wrist shot to the front of the ankle. It could not have been very hard—we were young and not strong—but a puck, when it hits you right, can leave a welt. That night, the ankle swelled up, and, abuzz with worry and excitement, I hardly slept.

We left the city before dawn. Ninety minutes later, in the locker room, I was having trouble tying my skates. The top of the laces, where you tugged them tight, was right on the bruise. My father gave it a go, hauling on the laces, and I yelped. I was young, I was tired, I was crushed, I was soft. And so I began to cry. Mr. Mila came over and watched me for a while. “You are crybaby!” he said. He told me to take off my skates and get out of the locker room: “You no play.”

Who was more humiliated, my father or me? He took me up to the lounge, overlooking center ice, where a woman offered me a doughnut. He kept his

distance in such a way that I sensed his disappointment, in spite of his words of reassurance and some grumbling about Mila. No one likes a crybaby. With the other parents, my face a mess of powdered sugar and dried tears, I watched the first round through a layer of glass and a scrim of shame, and I didn't get back into the lineup that day. I'd have to wait a while to play my first hockey game.

Ice was scarce in the city. We didn't have frozen ponds or back-yard rinks. No lawns to flood and obsess over in the Canadian-dad way. There wasn't much artificial ice, either, at least considering the size of the town and the number of inhabitants. Skating was a novelty, a birthday-party gimmick, like bowling. Once or twice a year, you might find yourself clomping around on crappy rental blades at Rockefeller Center, mesmerized by girls in wool leggings.

Now and then on weekends and vacations, our parents sneaked my brother, Xander, and me onto a brackish Long Island pond, my father in faded flared jeans, a red sweater, and a down vest—a tall man even taller on skates. His were brown leather hockey skates, their steel blades speckled with rust: the hockey equivalent of a leather football helmet. I was transfixed by them, as if they were a pair of pistols.



There was also street hockey, roller hockey, floor hockey. Floor hockey was played at school, in gym class, with plastic sticks and a lightweight orange plastic puck. The walls were padded, allowing for bloodless contact. Mr. Mila presided, severe and disapproving. It was a rare treat in gym to get floor hockey instead of dodgeball or gymnastics. Even now, if I picture the nets and the rolling laundry bin of sticks, I feel a little trill of excitement, like a memory of a circus or an ice-cream truck.

After school, we played street hockey in our shoes, with a ball for a puck, on the uneven paving stones of the plaza where East Eighty-sixth Street comes to an end in Carl Schurz Park. One on one, two on two, five on five: to get a pass off the wall at one end we called out “M.J.!” for Michael Jackson, after the album “Off the Wall” came out.

Sometimes on weekends, my father played with us. One morning, two older kids on banana-seat bikes cornered a few of us playing street hockey in the park. One of them grabbed our ball and threw it into a fenced lot, which led to a flimsy standoff:

“That’s our ball!”

“Yeah?”

“Go get it!”

“You gonna make me?”

And so on. We had hockey sticks, and so had the means to make them, but that calibre of action—any kind of real bloodshed—was beyond our reckoning or appetite.

I saw my father striding our way with a stick in hand. The big kids, perched on their banana seats, had their backs to him. I gave the bigger one a shove that failed to knock him off his bike. He rebalanced and wound up to throw a punch, but my father caught him by his hoodie and yanked him down to the pavement. He made the kid scale the fence and fetch our ball. It was good to have an enforcer in the family.

You might say we were cake-eaters. That's what the working-class hockey kids in Minnesota and Michigan call the prep-school swells. I was reared on the Upper East Side of Manhattan. Co-op apartment, private school, Wall Street dad: very cake-y. One can, and I often do, parse how much I was of it and not of it. I indulge in the narcissism of small differences. The euphemism of the era was "upper middle class." My parents had come to New York from Philadelphia the year before I was born, so, privileged as they were, and connected by birth and education to people of influence and means, they didn't feel like gilded New Yorkers. The high-society rituals—benefits, dancing schools, clubs—weren't theirs or mine. Not yet, anyway.

During the week, my father travelled to the heartland to advise regional banks on their mergers with other regional banks. He came back with regional-bank swag, the pencils and rulers I used to do my homework. Around town, people sometimes mistook him for a movie star, and he liked that. Out on the street, after we'd seen "Greystoke" at the Ziegfeld, another moviegoer pointed at him and said, "Yo! It's Tarzan!" His firm took out an ad in the *Times* with a full-length photograph, shot by Richard Avedon, of my father in a suit. Afterward, his office phone lit up with inquiries from women across the country in need of some corporate finance.

I was, in many ways, a sensitive kid, a good boy. Yet there was something ornery in me, some cussed streak. I'm not sure where it came from, but it was hockey that touched it off, starting around the age of ten. Nothing else made me so assertive, combative, or self-righteous, or brought me so much animal joy. It was an altered state, a kind of goblin mode. I wanted the puck, or the ball or roll of electric tape or whatever doodad was standing in for a puck. I was almost frightened by my hunger to have it and to do things with it, and by the sense of swagger that swept over me when I managed to do the things with it that I wanted to, and by the frustration that coursed through me when I did not.



There was something, perhaps, about the geometry of the game, about finding order amid chaos. And, then, there was another kind of order, a whole alternate ethos that consumed me, an idea of fairness and reprisal. “Do that again and I’ll—” I didn’t know what I’d do, or even what I wanted to do, but an urge to redress certain wrongs took hold. One day, during a street-hockey game, a kid from down the block started pushing my brother around, and I knocked him to the ground and stood over him, poised to throw a punch. I’d surprised myself as much as I had him. With a hockey stick in hand, I could be both artist and vigilante, ace and goon.

Two years after he called me a crybaby, Mr. Mila decided that he no longer wanted to coach the games. My father took over. To the rest of the team, he became, and would ever remain, Coach P. He had played a bit of hockey growing up. The lore is scant: One time, as a boy, he played in a game in Philadelphia. He was wearing figure skates, which in itself seems disqualifying. Grace Kelly—local girl, movie star, now a princess—was in the stands. My father, at some point, found himself on a breakaway. Just him, in open ice, bearing down on the goalie. He caught the serrated point of the figure-skating blade on the ice and fell on his face. Toe pick. We hoard our childhood humiliations and dispense them with care. He played in prep school but quit after three years. He hated having to shovel the rink.

Coach P. paced the bench in a double-breasted navy overcoat over a down vest with brown wide-wale corduroys, hiking boots, ski gloves. The other boys were afraid of him, perhaps in a playful way. If you floated around, he called you a “drifter,” or worse. It must have been something for Mr. Utsch to hear Coach P. yell out to his eleven-year-old son, “Utsch, you’re a pussy!” Xander and I knew that his fits of anger were fearsome but harmless, as did the others who’d spent time around our family. Behind the bench, the hard-assery was more gag than threat. The Great Santini with a touch of Chevy Chase.

He didn’t know much about the game’s finer points. He was not, as they say, an X’s and O’s guy. He said, “Forecheck, back-check, paycheck” and “My way or the highway.” His coinages, we thought. His highest compliment, the opposite of a drifter, was “hustler.” I endeavored to be one.

He wrote out the lineup in his left-handed script, in blue ink, on swatches of graph paper. He carried it around the days before our games and showed it to my brother and me. Here was a grownup—a man’s man, who came home at night from an office tower wearing a tailored suit and invited us into his walk-in closet, which held his executive clothes, his leather belt and English-leather lace-ups, the cedar shoe trees and horsehair brushes and jars of cordovan polish—caring so sincerely about, and devoting so much time to, an undertaking that, although it meant the world to me, even then I knew to be utterly trivial. It struck me that he knew my friends’ tendencies, that he had a sense of our hierarchies and skills, that he thought more of the better players and less of the weaker. I pictured him at his desk on Wall Street folding a sheet of graph paper into four quarters and writing out the names of eleven-year-old kids. It was flattering and unnatural, and it provided a first shudder in my perception of him as an infallible giant.

In the summer of 1982, I aged out of Coach P.’s squad. Eighth grade, thirteen: bantams. I signed up for a house league in the Bronx, rostering with a team from Pelham, just over the county line. We wore purple and yellow, like the Marcel Dionne Los Angeles Kings. I knew no one. Here was my first locker room rife with talk of jerking off and getting laid. I kept quiet, off and on the ice. Puberty hadn’t hit me yet. Jerking off, to say nothing of getting laid, was as yet a rumor. My shifts on the ice came and went, rarely with any consequence. The games were rougher than I was used to. I shied

away from trouble and became a perimeter player. My father came home early from work to drive me to the Bronx and back. He watched from the corner. I could sense the disappointment, the boredom, his reassessing the worthiness of the sacrifice. I saw myself through his eyes and didn't like what I saw.

About halfway through the season, I tried to avoid a check and got clipped in the leg, knee on knee. The knee swelled and stiffened. By the time it got better, the schedule was all but done. I doubt the coach missed me.

There wasn't any burning preconception that our two boys would play hockey, or, for that matter, become anything in particular. My wife, Siv, and I were open to whatever might come, or so we told ourselves. We weren't yet, and would probably never fully be, aware of the expectations and received ambitions that we projected onto the boys. The older one was Oli, pronounced with a long "O," like the Finnish player Olli Jokinen. On his third birthday, in the fall, we gave him his first pair of skates, Bauers no bigger than my fists.

"Do you know what day it is?" his mother asked.

"Hockey!" he said.

And so it was that he spent many days that winter at public sessions and on frozen ponds, puttering around with a chair or a held hand, and this may be proof that I was, and am, not being honest with myself. To call the pull of the ice gravitational would be an abrogation of agency. I wielded the magnet, whether I meant to or not. I was the one who saw something edifying in it all, who imbued playing a game with the making of a man. I was the one who made arguments on behalf of pushing through exhaustion and pain, of showing up even when you didn't feel like it.

It wasn't that I believed myself to be so staunch; I wasn't a marine or a monk or even an athlete of any distinction. I'd quit in high school, fed up with playing for other men—the coaches, my father. Or so I imagined. I was on to and into other things, whatever the opposite of sports was. Books, music, pot—a demented life of the mind. In time, I came back to hockey. It was a relapse, of a kind. Roller hockey, intramural hockey, men's league.

The boy coached by his father was now the father coaching his sons. I knew, as much from failure as from absorption, that if hockey was good for anything it was for its lessons of forbearance. Maybe my boys, if I handled them right, would turn out sturdier than me.

When Oli turned five, we got him the full kit. I went to Cosby's, the bedraggled hockey store next to Madison Square Garden, and bought the smallest pads I could find. In the apartment, I helped him tug on gear and tighten straps with the brisk tenderness of a veterinarian tending to a sedated pet. His excitement, visible behind the lattice of the face mask, was intoxicating, the pride of a novice. The extent to which even this kind of innocent dress-up is a means of indoctrination—the knottiness of this early gender programming—is leavened or perhaps obscured by its adorableness. He bumped around the house, proud and almost delirious with his transformation, and with the cognizance that he might be pleasing his father. The armor both emboldened him and somehow sapped him of strength, as though the plastic exoskeleton had drawn starch from his bones. After a few minutes, he lay on the floor with arms out and legs splayed, and looked up at the ceiling, daydreaming of who knows what. Every frozen pond has one, a drowsy child squinting into the sky, making angels of the ice shavings. Here, in the one-and-a-half-bedroom apartment, was ours.

I signed Oli up for a local hockey program called the Mighty Mites, coached by a guy I played beer-league hockey with. Oli showed up a few times, bumped around on the ice with the other kids, but then one day in the locker room, perhaps cowed by the bluster and chatter of the dads, he refused to get ready for practice. I pleaded, he held fast. In a panic, I called my wife. She said to let him be.

“But he made a commitment,” I said.

“He did not make a commitment,” she said. “He is five.”

That was it for the Mighty Mites. But he took up hockey again the following year, as a kindergartner at a new school, the one I'd attended. His class practiced on Friday afternoons at Lasker. I volunteered as an assistant coach, which meant being out there as an errand boy and horsing around with the kids. It was as casual as could be, a romper room on ice. More than half the

kindergarten class had joined the program. Most of them couldn't even get dressed in the gear, much less skate. Some came with their mothers, very few with their fathers, and a lot of them with nannies, South Asians and West Indians, who lugged or wheeled their charges' bags of gear. I roamed the locker room and helped with the pads and the laces. To see, or try to see, these little princelings through their babysitters' eyes made the whole thing seem a bit ridiculous, if not insidious. The idea was to toughen up the kids, teach them some self-reliance, yet here they were, attended by their handmaids.

Before practice, as the Zamboni made its rounds, the boys piled up behind the door to the ice, jostling for position. After a moment—the sanctified fermata of waiting for the new layer of water to freeze—a coach unlatched the door and they tumbled onto the ice, not one remaining on his skates. The pads, the helmets, the sticks, the bounded ring: it was all a pretext for roughhousing. No one discouraged it.

I was happy that my boy was skating and enjoying it, and was immediately eager for him to do it more. Where did this come from? Was it keeping up with the Joneses or meeting some idea of an athletic standard instilled by my father? Was it a resurrection of my thwarted ambitions for myself? Which is to say, was I living through my child? Of course I was.

It wasn't long before Oli joined a travel-hockey program. Day One was at a rink in a mall up the pike, in New Rochelle. This was mini-mites, five- and six-year-olds, mostly, the smallest of the small. We drove up at daybreak, Oli in back, still in a booster seat. When we got to the rink and he started dressing, I could see the trepidation and doubt in his eyes. Older kids strutted around in their pads. Their dads made a caffeinated ruckus. I tried, in Oli's presence, to convert the boisterousness and swagger of the others into cheerfulness, but I could sense that he knew I was forcing a mood. This never worked with him. Something gave way, some dismay set off by the jersey he was given or the number he'd chosen or the bravado of the other children or the merrymaking of the parents or the nervous exhilaration of his dad—those first-day heebie-jeebies, one's own memory of which persists deep in the bones. He refused to go on the ice, and he wept. My moonfaced boy, wrecked somehow by a disconnect between what he'd wanted and what this was, dug in. Other dads sidled up and tried to coax and reassure him,

but, if I couldn't, they didn't stand a chance. We sat awhile. Limbo. My heart ached for the boy, yet the task at hand was to get him onto the ice and into the program. The striving, the striving. He sat on a bench, his tiny legs not even reaching the floor. I left him alone for a while and stood at the glass watching the session, my soul a twist of sympathy, frustration, embarrassment, and even something like fear—that he might be too sensitive for this world, too *soft*—and the realization that I might feel this way about sensitivity, about the proper mettle in a boy, made me ashamed, too, so the brain, the self-justifying cortex, whichever lobe that is, got to work formulating arguments on behalf of my impatience and stipulations, to override the shame.

The mood passed, and he eventually stood up and skated out onto the ice and made his fleeting impression and got sorted into a group that wasn't the top group.

Once you spent some time on the ice with the younger kids, you realized quickly that maybe one out of three of them had the ability to cultivate a sense of strategy and structure. There were those who just chased the puck and those who ignored it. You had your blinded bulls and your daisy sniffers, your Ratóns and your Ferdinands. It was hard enough for a lot of the kids to stand in line, maintain eye contact, keep from crying. The capacity for abstraction and awareness didn't necessarily align with intelligence or skill. Spatial awareness, hockey sense—maybe it was a cast of mind.

Still, parents had a hard time letting go of the idea that their tyros were miniature professionals. A year later, I began helping coach the mini-mites, who now included my younger son, James. The head coach, from Calgary, Alberta, had been a star college player and had had a couple of stints in the American Hockey League, the best of the minor leagues. Now retired and starting a career in finance, he was more or less a volunteer, and the seriousness of the parents at this paltry level of ours astonished and amused him. But, with that western-Canadian knack for self-possession, he revealed none of this to the constituents. The day after Halloween, he arrived a half hour late for a 7 *A.M.* Saturday practice and stepped onto the ice reeking of booze, with smeared lipstick on his collar and white Dracula face paint on

his neck. I fetched a towel and tidied him up—what else are assistant coaches for?

A Sunday game in Queens, at dawn, Dracula and me behind the bench: Our mini-mites wobbled around a full sheet of ice like grapeshot on a dinner plate. There were lines painted under the ice—blue, red—but none of the kids had any idea what they signified. Once the referee dropped the puck, the parents in the stands shouted at their kids. *Go! Skate! Get it! Shoot!*

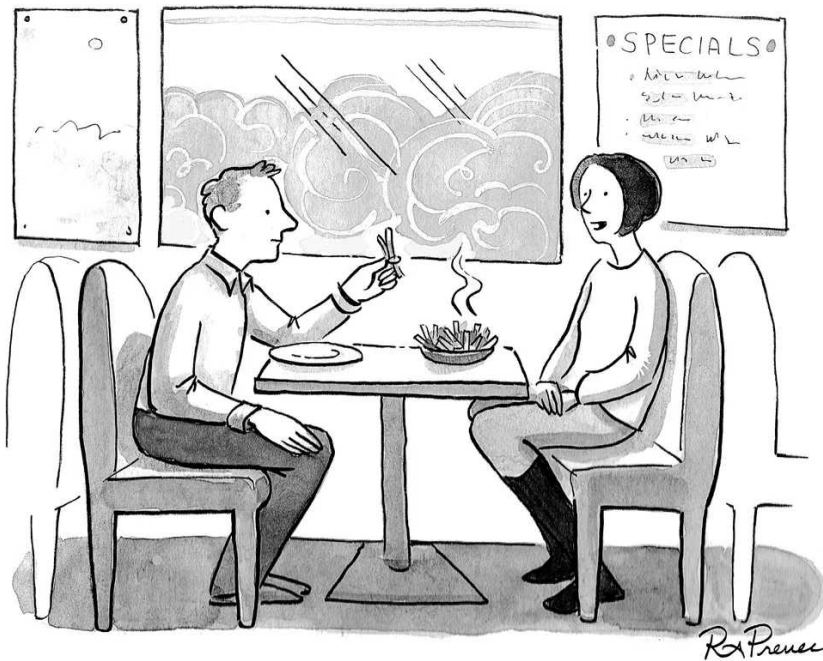
After the game—a loss, according to the scoreboard—a father came up to me to complain that our players seemed not to have a grasp of proper positioning on the breakout. I was new enough to it all, and I understood that this was preposterous. But it wouldn't be long before I would forget and be tricked into expecting too much. Something came awake in me, an incubus of ambition—a desire for excellence, obviously of a shine that would reflect back on me. The vanity of parenthood took hold.

I hadn't set out to coach my sons. The earliest impulse was to be on the ice with them. If I was going to go to the rink, I might as well get to skate. I wanted to play with them, not teach them to play, much less to play for me. Still, it was pride, of a kind, that drew me to the bench. A sense that I knew something about the game, that I could be a nurturing or at least an entertaining adjunct to the professional coaching staff. Most of the coaches were Czech, a new generation of Mr. Milas. My father, when he took over, had embodied a sense of hockey—and life!—as lark, not just as proving ground. But eventually a dad's tutelage sets in motion the familiar cycle of expectation and disappointment.

The weekends teemed with hockey, each boy with as many as five engagements over the forty-eight hours. Two or three games and a couple of practices at a web of rinks, back and forth across toll bridges and state lines. Siv maintained a color-coded hockey calendar that, if you looked at it too long, induced an epileptic fit. She and the other moms had a car pool for the weekday practices, and she was often with one boy when I was with the other, although I strove to be everywhere, to see every shift, and often took her leg of the weekday car pool, since I was supposed to be on the ice coaching anyway. Still, she watched more hockey and huffed more Zamboni

fumes and developed more nuanced opinions about it all than she would ever have imagined.

My participation, as driver, dad, coach, manager, crank, and fan, sucked the strength out of me, like going overboard in a wintry sea. The rank refrigerated air, the burnt coffee, the Tastykakes, the cross-chop of excitement and stress and boredom and disgruntlement. By Monday, I was saturated by it all, sallow and hoarse.



On the weeknights, it was my turn to play, on whatever team in whatever league. One night, my father, after a business dinner nearby, dropped by the rink to watch. Beer league means never playing in front of your parents, or anybody at all. So this was an oddity. I experienced a little flutter at the first sight of him, standing in the corner up against the glass. Coach P., in the overcoat. A teammate nudged me on the bench: “Is that your dad?”

It had been a lifetime since he’d appraised me on the ice: a skinny longhaired kid in Pelham purple lost amid the carnage of a bantam game in the Bronx. Now about the age he’d been then, and attuned to his presence, I skated harder than usual. But, when the third period began, I noticed he was gone.

The next morning, I waited for his report. He called in the afternoon. “What did you think?” I asked.

“You guys are terrible!” he said.

I was cocksure enough to find this pronouncement more inaccurate than unkind, needy enough to find it hurtful, and man enough to see the sense in it.

A Sunday 7 *A.M.* game at the Playland Ice Casino, in Westchester, versus the Rye Rangers. The kids arrived in darkness and began warming up in the parking lot. The younger you are, the earlier you play. Perhaps it’s to weed out the faint of heart. The kids who learn to wake up at 5:30 *A.M.* to play hockey are the same ones who in thirty years will have the fortitude to skate at midnight.

One of my beer-league teammates, a master rigger of industrial cranes, and I were assistant coaches. His son J. and my boy James were teammates and friends as mites. J. was tiny, with long curly hair and goggles like Kareem Abdul-Jabbar’s, and he treated James—who was eight, a year older, tall and wiry, with a blond bowl cut and a volatile streak—as the big brother he didn’t have. The head coach was Lada, a former Czech junior player fresh in town from Kopřivnice. He spoke very little English. He led skating clinics for the kids, designing convoluted edge-work drills that he couldn’t explain. He had J.’s dad and me demonstrate the sequences, then barked at us, half facetiously, when we got it wrong, endearing him to the kids. When James lost his temper on the ice, which was often, Lada bellowed, “Red eyes!,” his term for hot temper, and benched James for several shifts, the son seething while his father, pretending to be objective, tried to ignore him.

That Sunday, it wasn’t yet 8 *A.M.* when a Rye player shoved James from behind into the boards. James went down awkwardly and stayed prone a moment, then leaped up and, with an implausible ferocity, cross-checked the other kid in the ear. The Rye boy collapsed to the ice, and the other kids poured in and began grappling with one another, while parents shouted and pointed. Soon there was a pile of mites, with the two referees pulling players off and flinging them aside like puppies. Through the windows, you could see that the sun had risen over the Long Island Sound. I thought of my son’s

fellow second graders back in the city, likely still asleep or watching cartoons in their pajamas or getting dressed for church or whatever the unrinked got up to on weekend mornings, but here at Playland my boy had instigated a munchkin brawl.

On the bench, I kept my cool. It can be a matter of pride among hockey men—coaches, executives, scouts—to maintain a poker face when hell breaks loose on the ice. Cross your arms, chew your gum. Act like you’ve seen it before. But inside I was all twisted up. From a certain remove, the mayhem amused me, but I worried, with a dad’s fierce, selfish concern, about James’s well-being—his head, ribs, neck, shoulders—and muttered justifications to myself for the retaliatory stick to the ear. “Kid had it coming,” my inner hockey man said. Yet I also worried about that Rye boy and felt the rustlings of embarrassment, guilt, or even outrage. The refs kicked James out of the game and gave Rye a five-minute power play. They scored twice. It cost us the game.

By then, James was hiccupping back tears alone in the locker room. After a nod from me, a dad in the stands went to look in on him. This man no doubt held me in some way responsible, as both father and coach, for the violence and loss of self-control. I could see it in his expression, in the mixture of sympathy and scorn. I absorbed his judgment, and even though, on entering the locker room, I immediately checked in on James to ask about his head and spine and give his shoulder a surreptitious squeeze—what he really needed was a hug—on the car ride home I began to criticize him for losing his cool, for attempting to hurt another player, and also for putting his team down a player and depriving it of his services. “You can’t keep doing this,” I said. “We need you out there.”

I knew it was bad to talk to James about the game, or really to say anything at all besides “Let’s get some pancakes,” but, because I was wound up myself, or because I felt that I needed to impart some kind of lesson, as a father and as a coach, or because there was some childish part of me that needed to spill my own disquiet onto someone else, I persisted. Sometimes I savored the sweetness of driving to and from the rink with one or the other son in back; other times, I felt like little more than a chauffeur. Today, I was a cop, with a perp in back, behind a scrim of parental expectation as impenetrable as bulletproof glass.

James said nothing. In the rearview mirror, I could see him in his black compression shirt, his hair a sweaty mess, his face red and eyes puffy and cheeks rimed with the salt of his tears. The mood in the car was sour. I had a headache from too little sleep and too much coffee, plus all the griping and yelling—mine and everyone else's. My coaching jacket smelled like a dead mouse. I took an absent-minded inventory of the right pocket's contents: whistle, pack of gum, wad of used hockey tape, and my triplicate copy, as team manager, of the score sheet from the game, on which I knew it was written that No. 19, in green, had incurred a major penalty, for cross-checking, and a game misconduct. I wondered about the rules and whether he would be suspended, and then about the possibility that he might welcome the time off. I worked up the grace to suggest that we stop somewhere for breakfast.

One strives to be better. Parenting is a practice. You learn from your mistakes and then repeat them anyway. My father, watching my boys and their teammates from the stands, often criticized the plays they made, or failed to make, and so I felt compelled to defend them, even though those plays and failures often irked me, too.

A couple of years later, James, now ten, was the captain of the team and the top dog on defense. I was coaching the defensemen; I was coaching my son. I stood at their end of the bench, worked the door, called out the pairings, kept an eye on the matchups and the length of the shifts, and chatted with the boys. Sometimes my delivery was playful, jesting, even conspiratorial. (I've since been told that it is hurtful to be sarcastic with children.) Other times, I was keen, instructive, even scolding. James, of whom I expected the most, sometimes bore the brunt.

Somehow the tournament semifinal game went to overtime. Sudden death: next goal wins. Early in the overtime, my son and his partner botched a retrieval behind our net, which led to a turnover and a goal. Game over, tournament over. Our boys, dejected, drifted back toward the bench. James's body language suggested that he blamed his partner. So I pointed at James as he came to the bench, and said, not playfully or jestingly or even conspiratorially, "That was on *you*. That was *your* fault." I couldn't take it back. He looked at me with something like disgust, both because he didn't

agree and because he knew that what I'd said was harsh and uncalled for, an instance of an adult betrayal of dignity and comportment.

The following week, I agreed to quit working the bench. I wouldn't coach James again. It may be that this was when, if perhaps not why, James began to lose interest in the game. He still played, often eagerly and very well, but he had come to resent hockey's monopolization of his time, and, perhaps, the yoke of expectation. Also, he had discovered basketball: pickup with friends, then the team at school. Basketball! Sacrilege. Out on the hardwood, as an energy guy off the bench, he bounced around with the avidity and glee of a parolee. I took it as a delicious rebuke. Another dad exclaimed, "James is the happiest basketball player on the planet!" ♦

This is drawn from "[The Intangibles](#)."

Profiles

How Paweł Pawlikowski Learned to Film Europe's Fractures

The Polish director has made a career out of examining the mysteries of borders, both spiritual and political.

By Anthony Lane

September 28, 2026



The first thing you notice about the film director Paweł Pawlikowski is that he looks like a movie star. This is an unusual state of affairs. As a rule, if you happen to be—as Pawlikowski is—demonstrably tall, dark, and handsome, with a flexible sense of humor, a yen for cinema, and industrial quantities of charisma, your rightful spot is smack dab in front of the camera. So why go and lurk behind it? Why didn't Pawlikowski become an actor? "Oh, no, I'm a terrible actor," he says. "I never know what to do with my eyebrows."

These days, having recently turned sixty-nine, Pawlikowski has a dusting of gray in his hair and his stubble—the annoying effect of which is to render

him more, not less, like the very model of a leading man. It made complete sense, as we walked together down a street in Sarajevo, in Bosnia, when a young woman in a white dress ran ahead of us, turned around, explained that she was an actress at the National Theatre, and professed her adoration for Pawlikowski's work. He smiled, thanked her graciously, and moved on. That kind of thing must happen all the time to Keanu Reeves, but few directors—especially middle-aged Polish directors—can be guaranteed the same treatment.

We were in Sarajevo, in the middle of August, because Pawlikowski's latest movie, "Fatherland," was opening the city's annual film festival. On the first evening, it showed in multiple venues. The screening times were staggered, allowing Pawlikowski to hurry from one place to the next and introduce his film. I caught it outside, at the refreshingly named Coca-Cola Open Air Cinema, after night fell. Arriving onstage, in a white shirt and jeans, Pawlikowski bade welcome to "the people in the balcony over there," who were watching for free from nearby apartments. He told us that "Fatherland" is "about history, how it repeats itself, about family, love, betrayal, and so on. And the good thing is, it's not very long." Eighty-two minutes, to be exact. These days, when a visit to the cinema can be an endurance test, such brevity puts "Fatherland" ahead of the pack before it's even begun.

The family that Pawlikowski had in mind is the family of Mann—the novelist and Nobel laureate Thomas Mann (Hanns Zischler), that is, who, in 1949, heads back to his native Germany from the United States, where he has spent the wartime years. One reason for his return is the bicentenary of the birth of Goethe, on whom Mann has been invited to lecture. Now in his seventies, he is accompanied throughout the trip by his eldest daughter, Erika. (She is played by Sandra Hüller, whom American audiences last saw in "Project Hail Mary," a movie almost twice as long as "Fatherland.") She shaves her father in the morning, picks out his clothes, and drives him around in a stately Buick, as black and as gleaming as a hearse. Starting in West Germany, in Frankfurt, they cross to the Communist East, making for Goethe's home town of Weimar. Wherever he goes, Mann is exhorted to pledge his allegiance. The choice confronting him is voiced, with sardonic fatigue, by his son Klaus (August Diehl), during a phone call with Erika, near the start of the film: "Stalin or Mickey Mouse?"

“Fatherland,” which opens in America on October 23rd, is the third in a triptych of works in which Pawlikowski has explored the mystery of borders, geographical and spiritual, like a doctor tenderly probing an unhealed wound. Before “Fatherland” came “Cold War” (2018), and before that was “Ida” (2014). All three films last less than an hour and a half. All three are in black-and-white, and shot in the Academy ratio—a squarish format that tightens the action and pulls it about as far from *IMAX* as you can get. And all three make minimal use of a moving camera; one of Pawlikowski’s inspirations for “Ida,” he told me, was his family photograph albums, five of which he has borne with him throughout a peripatetic existence. Lives can be distilled into stills.

“Cold War,” like “Fatherland,” sets off in 1949. It traces the progress of a lengthy love affair, difficult and torn, from Poland to Berlin, Paris, and Yugoslavia, before circling back to Poland. The film earned Pawlikowski the prize for Best Director at the Cannes Film Festival, and was nominated for three Academy Awards, including Best Foreign Film. By then, it’s fair to say, he was getting full value from his tuxedo. “Ida,” the all-consuming tale of a Polish novice nun who discovers, before taking her vows, that her heritage is Jewish, and who travels in search of her past in the company of her formidable aunt, had been nominated for the same Oscar four years before. On the big night, February 22, 2015, “Ida” struck gold. Pawlikowski accepted his statuette from Chiwetel Ejiofor and Nicole Kidman, wiped his brow, and addressed the shining throng. “Oh, God, how did I get here?” he said. Good question.

Pawlikowski was born in Warsaw in 1957. His mother, Zula, was a ballet dancer from a Catholic background. As he told me, “All my Christmases, everything with my mother’s family, was very old-fashioned, high bourgeoisie.” Later, Zula became a lecturer in English at the University of Warsaw. His father, Wiktor, was a doctor, “funny guy, very witty,” and, to all appearances, entirely secular. “I didn’t have a clue my father was actually Jewish,” Pawlikowski said. Not until he was in his teens did he learn that his father’s mother had died in Auschwitz. Apart from one relative who later moved to Israel, he told me, “they were all wiped out in the war.”

To judge by photographs of Zula and Wiktor in the Pawlikowski family albums, they made a radiant couple. In one formal portrait, they pose

together in sunlight, lifting their bronzed faces to the rays. As befits the only child of such deities, the young Paweł, glimpsed in a series of snapshots, is all smiles. This, you tell yourself, is not someone who grew up with no handle on happiness. Some of the films that he went on to create, as an adult, may be dark to behold, and shaded with desolation, but the darkness is never willful or worked up. At the same time, you get the sense that only a fool would not expect paradise to get lost.

Part of the paradise was onscreen. “I was obsessed with movies when I was a kid. Every time we went skiing”—playing hooky—“I went to see movies. In Communist times, in Poland, there were screenings from ten o’clock in the morning, for the late-shift working classes,” Pawlikowski said. “Poland had a really good distribution of Western cinema—a unique country in the Communist bloc.” To reap the full benefits of this blessing, you had to schlep. “I remember, there was a cinema in the distant suburbs of Warsaw showing ‘The Fall of the Roman Empire’ ”—the 1964 epic with Alec Guinness and Sophia Loren. Taking a tram, as a much loved boy, to revel in ancient battles: there are far worse ways to grow up.

Another source of rapture was music. As an English teacher, Pawlikowski’s mother was permitted to travel to the U.K., and she would return with treasures for her son. One was the Beatles’ “All My Loving” (with “Money” on the B-side), plus, he says, “a wet-look jacket.” Memory is not so much a flow, sometimes, as a series of bumps and scrapes. “In winter 1965 we went to see ‘A Hard Day’s Night’ at our local cinema, Moskwa. We queued for hours,” Pawlikowski told me, in an e-mail. “When we finally got the tickets and had time to kill, I went sliding on ice with other kids in front of the cinema. I fell and cut my head and watched the film with a bandage on my head.” Fifty-three years later, when asked by Criterion to name his favorite movies, Pawlikowski put “A Hard Day’s Night” at the top of the list. Pain and pleasure are wrapped up tight.



I first met Pawlikowski early this summer, in London, where we ate lunch and went to an exhibition of paintings by the seventeenth-century Spanish painter Francisco de Zurbarán: a strange environment in which to contemplate Poland in the nineteen-sixties. Pawlikowski feels he was lucky to be raised then, “when Communism went a bit softer.” In the air of his parents’ generation, he claimed, “there was so much poetic wit.” The writings of the period were “subtle, funny, ironic, with a sense of paradox,” and some of that pliability left its mark. Infusing almost every Pawlikowski film is a strain of gloomy relish. “People say to me, ‘What’s your Polish influence? Is it Polish cinema of the fifties and stuff?’ No, it’s more that kind of humor—humor with a kind of melancholy, you know?” The implication being that, in his words, “we’re all fucked anyway.”

Proof of that principle came in early 1968, when Władysław Gomułka, the leader of the Communist Party in Poland, was losing his grip on power. A scapegoat was required. In March, he gave a televised speech in which he split the country’s Jews into three categories. There were “patriotic Jews,” who were firmly embedded in Polish society, “Zionists,” and “cosmopolitans”—the slyest of anti-Jewish slurs. (Which group Gomułka’s wife, who was Jewish, fell into was not clear.) “Basically, the antisemitic Party campaign was a distraction from the student demonstrations,” Pawlikowski told me. Tear gas must have been deployed against the crowds,

because he remembers “some gassed students of my mother’s seeking refuge in our flat.” He used to be sent to buy newspapers at a kiosk, but his father now told him not to go, saying, “*Prasa kłamie*”—the press lies.

One upshot of Gomułka’s initiative was a purge of Jewish citizens from what he called “responsible and high positions.” Another was a mass departure of Polish Jews, among them Wiktor Pawlikowski, who left in 1969. The rift was traumatizing; in the words of his son, “He truly suffered in exile.” Nothing was ever quite the same again. Wiktor and Zula divorced. She married an Englishman and, in 1971, she, too, left Poland behind, moving to England with the bewildered Paweł, who had never been there. “Me not speaking English, being into rock and roll, not having the right gear and the language—that was my main drama,” Pawlikowski told me. “I was fourteen, when you’re kind of already formed, so you can’t be molded into something completely different.”

Zula found a job at a department store in London. Pawlikowski, whose immersion in English culture had hitherto been largely musical—“Beatles, Stones, Kinks”—was packed off to “a school for Polish expatriates, called Divine Mercy College, in Henley-on-Thames. Mass every morning.” The experiment did not succeed. “The more they tried to reeducate me, the more I hated it,” Pawlikowski told me. “Then they taught me how to use a telephone, as if I’d never used a telephone in Poland: that kind of shit. Poland back then was seen by the Polish in England as a Communist nightmare, one big Gulag, whereas I had had a normal childhood.” As he recalled, there wasn’t enough to eat at the school. Worse still, “I was told to play cricket, and nobody explained to me what the fuck it was.” (He was not the first to hit that wall.) All in all, Pawlikowski said, “My problem was not with my Jewish heritage. My problem was being *Polish*, in the West. That was bad enough.”

Having faltered academically, the teen-age Paweł was thrown out of Divine Mercy and sent to a boarding school in Kent. He had to leave that place, too, after which the story line of his life—it’s too fragmentary and misshapen to call it a plot—was folded back on itself. He moved to Wuppertal, in northwest Germany, where his father had settled. What’s more, Zula later joined them, and the family was, for a while, reconstituted. Pawlikowski stayed in Germany for five years, from 1972 to 1977, dug in deep, and

passed his exams. Wuppertal was, among other things, the home base of the Pina Bausch dance company, to which Wiktor introduced his son. “I loved her shows, though I had no idea what was going on,” Pawlikowski remembered. “When a rhinoceros appeared onstage, my father turned to me and explained that this meant the arrival of Fascism.” It made for a change from cricket.

And so the rhythm persisted: migrate, remigrate, and take it from there. Pawlikowski returned to London for a degree at Westfield College. He then went to Oxford and began to study for a Ph.D. on the Austrian Expressionist poet Georg Trakl, who died young, in 1914. That plan was interrupted by a “defection,” as Pawlikowski calls it: he fled to Turin, partly for the sake of a woman he had met but mainly, he told me, as “a way of getting away from Oxford and my ball and chain of a thesis.” The unshackling was worth it: “I ended up having the best year of my life.” It also allowed him to add to his heap of languages. By my count, Pawlikowski now speaks Polish, English, French, German, Italian, Spanish, and Russian. If he ever switches to sci-fi movies, he could probably get by in Martian.

Back in England, Pawlikowski realized that he didn’t want to be an academic or a full-time writer and that, despite his musical hunger, he was unlikely to cut it as a musician. (He played piano, “imitating Chick Corea and Keith Jarrett.”) He signed up for a course at a local filmmaking workshop, unconnected with the university. This remains his only practical training in the craft. As he said to the audience at a master class in Sarajevo, “Here was a medium in which I could combine all my failures.” There, you might say, is the authentic tone of Mitteleuropa—amused, highly inquisitive, lightly despairing, and unimaginable on the lips of anyone applying, for instance, to film school at U.C.L.A. What Pawlikowski needed was somewhere eccentric enough to accommodate his ambitions, whatever they might be. So it was that, in 1986, after much drifting, and approaching thirty, he washed up on the shores of the BBC.

For the many moviegoers who became conscious of Pawlikowski only at the time of “*Ida*,” the range of films that preceded it may come as a surprise. Not that it’s easy to get hold of the damn things, even with the aid of Vimeo and YouTube. A few remain elusive, including “*Václav Havel: A Czech Drama*” (1989), which is not a drama but a documentary, made in what was

then Czechoslovakia before the Communist regime caved in. In short, we could use a full retrospective to plug the gaps.

True to form, Pawlikowski is modest about some of his efforts as a tyro. “Of all the directors I worked with, he was the most talented and the most self-questioning.” So says Nigel Williams, a British novelist and playwright who was a producer on “Bookmark,” a BBC documentary series that ran from 1983 to 1999. Did Pawlikowski simply come knocking on his door? “The door was never closed,” Williams told me, in late August, over lunch in London. “He just turned up in the office one day. And he’d made a film about satanism.” (Correct. It’s a short documentary called “Lucifer Over Lancashire.”) “I said, ‘I’m not really into satanism, but let’s take a look at it.’ I liked him instantly.”

Pawlikowski began as a *TAP*—a trainee assistant producer. “The BBC in those days was an amazing place,” Williams said. “There was total freedom.” Pawlikowski, who refers to it as “a real mensch situation,” took maximum and, it appears, nerveless advantage of such liberty. “He has complete balls, that guy,” Williams said. He remembers asking how the footage for the Havel film was going to be smuggled out of Czechoslovakia. Pawlikowski had the solution: “I’ll put it down my trousers.” One detail that you spot in all this early work is that he is credited as “Paul Pawlikowski.” Not until 2000 did he revert to “Paweł.” According to Williams, we shouldn’t read too much into this slippage of identity: “He didn’t give a shit.”



The roster of “Bookmark” films shows you the kinds of story that Pawlikowski felt impelled to tell. There was “In the Blood” (1987), set in Northern Ireland; “Palace Life” (1988), about a banned dissident Polish writer named Tadeusz Konwicki, which marked the director’s return to his native land; and “Extraordinary Adventures: The Life of Vladimir Voinovich” (1989), about a brazen Russian satirist. Then came a trio of mini-masterpieces: “From Moscow to Pietushki: A Journey with Benedict Yerofeyev” (1990), “Dostoevsky’s Travels” (1991), and “Serbian Epics” (1992). All three, as their titles suggest, confirmed the tenacity of Pawlikowski’s eastward gaze.

Yerofeyev was a hell of a creature: not just a drunkard and a writer but a visionary writer *about* drinking, whose headlong and scabrous prose poem, “From Moscow to Pietushki,” circulated in typescript for years before it was finally published, in 1989. “It was a cult book between me and my father,” Pawlikowski told me. In his tribute, he reconstructs the train journey described in its pages and, to the viewer’s amazement, tracks down the reclusive author not long before his death. (With a voice wrecked by throat cancer, Yerofeyev speaks through a laryngophone.) The film finds lyrical scraps at the damp and tattered edges of society, listening to a boozier on a park bench as he fondly recites the recipe for a Yerofeyev cocktail: “Anti-

dandruff shampoo and cologne. Add a hundred grams of vodka. Stir it with a honeysuckle twig and drink it up, in God's name."

As for "Dostoevsky's Travels," it originated when Pawlikowski rang Williams late at night from a phone booth in St. Petersburg. "I've just been bitten by a stray dog," he said, adding that he had met a man who claimed to be Dostoevsky's great-grandson. And so it proved. The film follows Dmitri Dostoevsky, a humble tram driver, as he journeys to Western Europe, now open to visitors from former Communist lands. The whole expedition turns on a delectable irony: those who host Dmitri, in Germany and elsewhere, want him to pronounce on the consciousness of modern man, as enshrined in his great-grandfather's fiction, whereas the one thing that *he* wants, more than anything, is a Mercedes.

In case you were wondering, the Mercedes functions as "an object of both symbolic and monetary value." That's how it was analyzed, at any rate, in "ReFocus: The Films of Paweł Pawlikowski," an academic study published last year. Pawlikowski has not been able to bring himself to read it, although he does like the cover. (Rightly so; it makes him look like the Terminator, striding along in shades.) One oddity of the book is that, despite its inquiries into the director's interrogation of "hegemonic national discourses," not once does it observe how funny those interrogations can be. In person, Pawlikowski is wry and convivial, with a taste for good food and for absurdities both fleeting and profound, and his geniality carries over into even his most wounded works. The hapless hero of "Dostoevsky's Travels" is savored rather than roasted by the movie, and this grants him a certain shrewd dignity. That difficult balance is sustained, under far more testing conditions, in "Serbian Epics."

Not many literary documentaries are set in an active war zone. In the case of "Serbian Epics," however, literature was the way in—or, as Pawlikowski has said, a Trojan horse. A major character in the film is the Bosnian Serb leader Radovan Karadžić, who is introduced with an onscreen title: "Poet and Psychiatrist." He solemnly sits in front of the camera playing the gusla, a bowed musical instrument that makes a noise like a baritone bee, and singing along: "There were thirty chieftains drinking wine /Among the vast crags of the Romanija Mountain." Karadžić, in his own eyes, is upholding the oral tradition of his people, whose territorial claims, mythologized in

verse and blessed by the Church, must, if necessary, be defended in blood; where better to unfold such grandeur than to a BBC program called “Bookmark”?

The access that Pawlikowski managed to get, on this basis, is dumbfounding. He sits in on a meeting of the Serbian war cabinet, chaired by Karadžić, who points at a map of the conflict, on which thick black lines show the areas claimed by the Serbs—geopolitics by Sharpie. “It’s not right that Croatia should have all the coast and we have none,” he proclaims, as if a coastline were cake at a children’s birthday party. We hear no commentary in this or any other scene; forsaking voice-overs, Pawlikowski lets his camera do all the moral work. Bathos is not hard to come by. Up on a hill overlooking Sarajevo, Karadžić, the proud champion of his nation, huddles inside a little red pod, formerly part of a cable car, trying to make a phone call to his wife while petting a puppy that larks around at his feet.

On a hot Saturday, Pawlikowski and I revisited those heights—the slopes from which, for almost four years, starting in the spring of 1992, Serbian artillery pounded Sarajevo, which lies vulnerably cupped in the valley below. We had coffee at Sunnyland, a playground with a gentle roller coaster and a giant swing. “Adventure Awaits You,” a poster announced. Around us, other customers were enjoying the weekend at their leisure, including many Muslim families, the women in head scarves. “It’s Karadžić’s nightmare!” Pawlikowski said, with visible delight.

Nearby was the city’s Jewish graveyard, where the tombs are laid out around a steep flight of steps. There, in the early nineties, the living fought fiercely among the dead. One of the combatants was a poet. “He didn’t know the war had started, because he was hungover or drunk or something,” Pawlikowski told me. “So the first thing he did was try to flee to his home town of Han Pijesak to stay with his mother. He hid there, then he was dragged out by the Serb military police as a deserter—because he was a Serb, he should be fighting. And they threw his battalion straight into the Jewish cemetery, which was like a killing field.” (Pawlikowski recalled the poet’s mordant report: “There’s a layer of dead Jews, and dead Bosnians, Muslims, and then us.”) The tale took a twist: “Two military police turned up and dragged him away, so he was convinced he was going to be shot.” Another twist: “He got dragged to the press office of this colleague of his, who then nominated him

as second-in-command for P.R. And this guy was totally useless, alcoholic. His hands were trembling.” Having been rescued from the teeth of death, the poet had a new complaint: “Oh, it’s so boring without the Muslims.”

Even before “Serbian Epics” was shown on TV, it caused “a huge scandal,” according to Pawlikowski. A motion in the House of Commons in December, 1992, expressed dismay at the film, or, to be precise, at a *listing* of the film in the BBC schedule, which hinted at pro-Serb sympathies. To anyone who had actually seen the documentary, with its droll depiction of collective self-aggrandizement, this was hogwash. What the movie thrives on is the farcical and, all too often, horrendous reach of human error; surreal episodes are not cooked up but happened upon or stumbled over. As Pawlikowski said to me, in Sarajevo, “I was being anthropological.” As we walked around the city—which, as he says, “has always had its own urban identity, accent, the way they drink, the way they celebrate”—he kept summoning up incidents and individuals from more than thirty years before. One block of buildings, opposite a soccer stadium, close to what used to be the front line, touched off a particular memory: “There was a sniper woman, a mother of three, who every day went up to the top floor somewhere and sniped. A Serbian woman, very nice. She was picking people off, you know, in Sniper’s Alley.”

Like the poet in the cemetery, the sniper mother is still fresh in Pawlikowski’s mind. So is Nikola Koljević, “a scholar in Shakespeare studies at Sarajevo University, but he was part of this Serbian government besieging his own university.” When a world gets turned upside down, the people inside follow suit. Rarely, it seems to me, has Pawlikowski been roused by themes or issues or arguments. Rather, it is characters who have muscled their way to the forefront of his imagination. The question naturally arises: Why not make them up?

Defining the line where nonfiction fades and drama dawns is a challenge. For Pawlikowski, it was yet another border to cross. He admired Ken Loach’s “Kes” (1969)—“documentary texture, nonprofessional actors, good faces, good landscape, small story that goes a long way,” as he told me. He could be describing “Twoockers” (1998), which he made for the BBC in collaboration with a friend, Ian Duncan, and which tells of a kid and his mates, in a depleted community in the North of England, who break into

cars and houses. A singsong dialect binds them together; they don't steal a TV, they steal a "teggy-veggy."

Put like that, "Twoockers" sounds like a burst of indignant social realism—hardly uncommon in British cinema in the period of Margaret Thatcher's dominance and its long aftermath. The plots of Pawlikowski's next two films, "Last Resort" (2000) and "My Summer of Love" (2004), would seem to be singing a comparable tune. The first is about a Russian woman and her son, newly arrived in England and confined by immigration authorities to a scruffy seaside town, where her sole chance of employment is to perform in online porn; the second tells of a relationship between two young women, one working class and the other (played by Emily Blunt, in her first starring role) more educated, and gilded with the languor of wealth. This being England, their love is doomed by the gulf of the social divide.

If you watch these movies, however, you feel more haunted than hectored. It's true that Pawlikowski, himself an immigrant, is instinctively drawn to the lost and the marooned. ("Britain is very good for being able to stay an outsider, for not having to fit in too much," he told me.) On the other hand, he's not seeking to persuade us of anything, politically or otherwise; he is passing on visions, which bloom in unlikely terrain. The eye of a dead man, whose home has been burgled by a couple of lads, in "Twoockers," is filmed from inches away, with a fly crawling over the sightless orb; "My Summer of Love" kicks off with an eye being drawn on a wall, swiftly followed by two other eyes in closeup—one of a human, who is lying in grass, and the other of a horse.



Fans of Pawlikowski, inspecting his filmography, will be struck by the hiatus that opened up between “My Summer of Love” and its successor, “The Woman in the Fifth” (2011). Lord knows, there are many reasons—funding, casting, development hell—that movies fail to get made. For Pawlikowski, though, the troubles that put his professional life on hold were more private, and immeasurably sadder. In 1989, he had married a Russian pianist, Irina. They met in London, though she hailed from the Caucasus. (“She knew ‘From Moscow to Pietushki’ by heart,” he told me. “It was a sign.”) They were together for seventeen years, and had two children, Wiktor and Maria. Irina died in 2006, and Pawlikowski paused his filmmaking career to raise the children on his own.

To learn that “The Woman in the Fifth” was made by a man who had, not long before, passed through the valley of the shadow of grief doesn’t explain the movie, yet it comes as little surprise. The atmosphere is desperate and stunned. Pawlikowski, at the master class in Sarajevo, referred to the film as “well directed, if I say so myself, but it didn’t really work.” The plot, very loosely adapted from a book by Douglas Kennedy, concerns Tom (Ethan Hawke), an American novelist who gets stranded in Paris, broke, with a gluey case of writer’s block. The most piercing verdict on his predicament is made by the enigmatic Margit (Kristin Scott Thomas), whom he encounters

at a party. “You needed a good disaster to get you started,” she says. “A real tragedy, if you play your cards right.”

In what ways the life of a creative artist, and the deaths that inevitably scar it, can leak into the ensuing work—through the cracks of a poem, or a movie, or a song—is, let’s face it, a conundrum that has been worried into exhaustion. But you can’t help raising it if you warm to Pawlikowski’s films, because they are so question-strewn, and so clearly indebted to the histories, grand and minor, of his time.

As a graduate student, for example, he met Helena Wolińska-Brus, the elderly Jewish wife of an Oxford professor. Years later, it was revealed that she had been a Polish military prosecutor, at whose bidding a number of former anti-Nazi freedom fighters had been arrested and tried; one hero of the wartime resistance, who refused to work with the postwar Communist administration, was executed. For that reason, the Polish government requested Wolińska-Brus’s extradition from Britain, though in vain. Pawlikowski hoped to interview her about her life. “She said no, and then she died,” he told me. Yet that was not the end of the affair. “I just kept her in my back pocket, as an idea.”

Maybe that’s what separates the born storytellers of this world from the rest of us: they have deeper back pockets. What Pawlikowski plucked out, in due course, was Wanda Gruz (Agata Kulesza), the heroine’s aunt in “*Ida*,” and a strong candidate for the most dauntingly memorable character in twenty-first-century cinema. As Pawlikowski is at pains to emphasize, Wanda is “not a portrait” of Wolińska-Brus. Without that living spark, though, would the invented woman have caught fire? Wanda—“Red Wanda, that’s me” she says, with a twinge of acerbic pride—is a former state prosecutor, Stalinist in her rigor, who sent people to their deaths. Now a judge, suavely dressed and robed in self-contempt, she drinks to excess and sleeps around as if to eradicate any threat of love. One morning, she sprinkles sugar on her bread and chomps like a starving child; has a bath and a smoke; then, to the calmativ strain of Mozart’s “Jupiter” Symphony, stubs out her last cigarette and leaps from an open window. Watching that sequence in a movie theatre was a drama in itself. I sensed the audience rear back in their seats, as if hit by a shock wave. Horror films, you could say, throw a similar punch, but

jump scares tend to be relieved by laughs. With “Ida,” there was no such release.

For someone so vivacious, Pawlikowski is an expert purveyor of mortal facts. At the end of “Cold War,” the couple who have tried and failed to live without each other come to a tranquil understanding: they will die together instead. In the broken shell of a chapel, near a remote crossroads in Poland—the same location had been used in “Ida”—Zula (Joanna Kulig) and Wiktor (Tomasz Kot) swallow a handful of pills and make their vows, as if they were getting married. They sit on a bench. “Let’s go to the other side,” she says. “The view will be better there.” They stand up and walk out of the frame. And that’s it. The words “For my parents” appear onscreen, and the circle is complete. Pawlikowski’s mother and father, also named Zula and Wiktor, whose unmanageable love had kept them tangled and disentangled for decades, took their own lives in 1989, as the Cold War that had cast its chill upon their time was beginning to thaw.

There is a suicide in “Fatherland,” too, although we don’t witness it. All that we see is Erika Mann, as she hears the mournful news. Like Ingmar Bergman—and “Fatherland” owes something to Bergman’s “Wild Strawberries” (1957), another bitter and reflective pilgrimage—Pawlikowski is given to measuring events by their impact on the human face. At the start of “Twockers,” as a kid is urged to stop loafing around and get a job, it’s him we see, and not his adult adviser. Likewise, in “Ida,” when the heroine (Agata Trzebuchowska) is told, “You’re a Jew,” we get a half-length shot of her in her nun’s habit, holding steady, with her dark, unblinking eyes, as she absorbs this tumultuous information. Those eyes! I asked Pawlikowski about them. “Contact lenses,” he replied.

Ida’s stillness is shared by the whole film, which seems more confidently rooted than anything in Pawlikowski’s previous endeavors. “For the first time, I was really on firm ground with what I wanted,” he said. He was back on home turf, in Poland, with a narrow budget, discarding inessentials. “When you limit the elements and actors and locations and props, then you can drill in,” he told me. “Limit yourself, and that frees you up.” Objects become loaded with intent; a skull is unearthed and bundled inside a silk scarf. Pawlikowski describes all this as “a big breakthrough,” though it sounds more like an epiphany. “I also had this moment of rejection of

cinema, you know? I said, ‘Fuck cinema.’ ” Part of the rejecting was what he calls “this radical decision not to move the camera, and to frame things in a very amateurish way, with a lot of headroom.” The aim was “to make things happen within the shot.”

To anyone viewing the result, the heavy, looming space above the characters feels like the pressure of their intolerable thoughts; to Ryszard Lenczewski, however, the director of photography on “Ida,” it was all askew, and he quit the project. Pawlikowski asked the camera operator, a young guy named Łukasz Żal, to take over temporarily. “In two days, a weight was lifted from my shoulders,” the director says. He and Żal have worked together ever since.



So determined are “Ida,” “Cold War,” and “Fatherland,” in their careful dramatic momentum, that you assume they must all be *predetermined*. Not so. “I don’t like this business of writing at a desk,” Pawlikowski said to me. In recent times, he has worked in Greece, on the island of Hydra, where he has a place. But the best lines, he believes, are produced “spontaneously, in situ.” Collaborations can help, “sometimes with a co-writer. Then I do it with actors, and then I do it while I’m location scouting and rehearsing and shooting.” In other words, “the filmmaking is part of the writing.”

A case in point: there is a scene in “Fatherland” in which Thomas Mann is greeted by two young men at a reception. In the script, he asks, “How is your mother?”—“*ihre Mutter*,” in German. On set, however, Hanns Zischler, playing Mann, suggested changing the words to “*ihre Frau Mutter*”—“your good lady mother,” let’s say, stiffened with old-fashioned courtesy. The tweak stayed in, and one can see why. The youths are, in fact, grandsons of Wagner, and their mother is the composer’s daughter-in-law; they request that Mann assist in reviving Wagner’s reputation, which has been sullied by the Nazis’ eager embrace of his music. Polite to a fault, not raising his voice, Mann responds, “Bayreuth should be razed to the ground, and your mother should be on trial.”

The role of Mann fits Zischler like a handmade suit. He is the veteran of two notable films set along the fault lines of his country—Wim Wenders’s “Kings of the Road” (1976) and Jean-Luc Godard’s “Germany Year 90 Nine Zero” (1991). Moreover, he is not only an actor but an author, steeped in Goethe, and he wrote a deeply researched book on the moviegoing habits of Franz Kafka. (It’s hard to picture the writer of “The Trial” watching Chaplin’s “The Kid,” in 1922, but he did, twice.) Indeed, so erudite is Zischler that, in the midst of shooting “Fatherland,” Pawlikowski advised him, “Don’t think too much about what you know.”

I talked to Zischler, the soul of geniality, over tea and cakes in his apartment, in a peaceful western patch of Berlin. Pawlikowski, he told me, had issued an ominous warning before filming commenced: “He said, ‘I’m going to be cruel to you.’ But he was never cruel.” It was more a matter of being resolute. As Zischler puts it, “He knows very well what he wants.” The rapport between Pawlikowski and Żal? “Osmotic.” And that tricky space above the actors’ heads? “It’s a narration in itself.” Pay attention, Zischler proposed, to all the doors that open and close in the film—the entrances and exits that mark the progress of the tale. “It’s like turning the pages of an album,” he said. I thought of the family photograph albums, so close to Pawlikowski’s heart.

There is an extraordinary travelling shot, early in “Fatherland,” that sets the ruined scene. From inside the car, with Erika at the wheel, and a motorcyclist leading onward like a herald, we see the streets of Frankfurt passing by, still gutted by wartime bombs. Nowhere in modern Germany, it

seems, was sufficiently ramshackle; Lower Silesia, in Poland, had to play the part. A related problem arose with the human backdrop. Pawlikowski told me that he and his casting assistants spent five months looking for extras, just to find the right faces for the period. Back then, “people didn’t *know* how they looked. That’s one reason I stopped making documentaries,” he said. Nowadays, “everyone photographs themselves all the time, so they know what photography does to them.”

“Fatherland” also plays with the puzzle of history. In reality, it was Mann’s wife, not Erika, who went with him to Germany in 1949. Pawlikowski reconfigured the journey—the emotional dynamic—to his satisfaction, and it’s hard to cavil at the outcome. Consider Erika, in Weimar, walking out of a lecture hall, unable to bear yet another speech by her famous father. Pawlikowski, surveying the city, came across a graveyard that was adorned with old statues, worn by lichen and time; and that is where Erika strolls, seeking refuge, on a bright day. Unexpectedly, like a dancer, the camera stirs and glides. Why now? Zischler has a theory: “Erika wants to prevent Thomas becoming a monument.”

It’s a fine and persuasive reading of the sequence, and, I would say, of the entire film. As Erika wisely perceives, Mann is being both honored and used, passing through a land on which he is expected to pronounce but where he no longer feels at ease. “Where is home?” he is asked by an American journalist at a press conference. “My home now is in California,” he says. “But where my *Heimat* is, where I belong, is a much more difficult question.”

That question has nagged at Pawlikowski’s output, from his earliest documentaries to the present day. Stand back, and you see a pattern emerge: a continual, delicate dialogue between fixity and flux. Think of Dmitri Dostoevsky, roaming the used-car dealerships of Germany in search of his motorized dream; of the frontiers that are tussled over in “Serbian Epics,” in the cause of ethnic bullying; of the Russian woman and her son in “Last Resort,” stuck in an England that doesn’t want them, pleading first to stay and then to leave; and, in “Cold War,” of the Polish consular official, in Paris, who says to the lovelorn hero, “You’re not French, and you’re not a Pole, either. As far as we’re concerned, you don’t exist.”

“Fatherland” is supported by twin pillars: not just Thomas Mann but also Goethe, whose house Mann visits, in awkward reverence, and whose death mask is shown in closeup, gleaming as white as bone. It was Goethe—Germany incarnate—who declared, in a letter of 1799, “The fatherland of the man who thinks without prejudice, who can rise above his time, is nowhere and everywhere.” Whether that’s a promise or a cautionary tale is up to you.

And what of Pawlikowski himself? Where is his home of homes? These days, he spends time on Hydra, with his second wife, Malgorzata Bela, whom he married in 2017; last year, he made a short film with her there, titled “Muse.” When in Warsaw, he lives on the street where he grew up; he also makes frequent trips to London, where he sees his children and stays with an old friend, Alfonso Cuarón, the director of “Gravity” and “Roma.” A master of stillness, Paweł Pawlikowski is still on the move. The little boy from Warsaw is running free. Sitting in a café in Sarajevo, he said to me, “Every film has to be a roof over my head for three years.” It’s not such a bad place to live. ♦

Should I Stay or Should I Go?

The quandary faced by government lawyers who think that the Trump Administration is subverting justice.

By Eyal Press

September 28, 2026



On March 7, 2025, Celia Cohen, a prosecutor in the U.S. Attorney's office for the Southern District of New York, was finishing up a meeting at 26 Federal Plaza, in lower Manhattan, when she learned that a federal marshal had arrived on the premises and wanted to see her. She was soon led to a conference room where the marshal served her with a letter from Todd Blanche, then the Deputy Attorney General, informing her that she and Andrew Rohrbach, another prosecutor at the S.D.N.Y., were being investigated and placed on administrative leave. After Cohen collected her personal belongings, the marshal escorted her out of the building.

Cohen, who has a reserved bearing, was deeply embarrassed. By the time she was back home, in Westchester County, her shock had settled into despair. Prosecutors at the S.D.N.Y., the nation's most prestigious federal

trial court, typically stay for five to seven years before moving on to jobs at private law firms, where they can earn vastly higher salaries. Cohen had no such plans. Since her early twenties, when she'd spent a year working as a paralegal at the Department of Justice, she'd dreamed of becoming a prosecutor. A few years after she graduated from law school, mentors at the Manhattan law firm where she was working encouraged her to apply to become an Assistant U.S. Attorney at the S.D.N.Y. When Preet Bharara, who was then running the office, called to offer her a job, she exclaimed, "This is the best day of my life!"

Cohen joined the S.D.N.Y. on the Monday after the 2016 Presidential election. She started out at the General Crimes Unit before moving to Violent Organizations and Crime, and then to Public Corruption. Although the hours were long and the salary was relatively modest, she loved the job and planned to spend the rest of her career in the office.

Shortly after Donald Trump was inaugurated for a second term as President, Emil Bove, the acting Deputy Attorney General, summoned S.D.N.Y. leaders to a meeting in Washington to discuss the pending trial of Eric Adams, the mayor of New York. In September, 2024, Adams had been indicted for soliciting illegal campaign contributions and for accepting bribes from Turkish officials. (He has denied any wrongdoing.) Cohen had been a prosecutor on the case. At the meeting in Washington, which she didn't attend but soon learned about, Adams's attorneys pressed for the case to be dropped, claiming that it was interfering with the Mayor's ability to enforce Trump's immigration policies. Ten days later, Bove issued a memorandum ordering the S.D.N.Y. to dismiss the charges. The problem was not the evidence, which, he acknowledged, the Justice Department had not reevaluated; rather, the case was impeding Adams's ability "to devote full attention and resources to the illegal immigration and violent crime that escalated under the policies of the prior Administration." The memo demanded that the charges be dismissed without prejudice—meaning that they could later be reinstated. This would give the White House immense leverage over Adams.

Two days later, Danielle Sassoon, the interim U.S. Attorney at the S.D.N.Y., outlined her objections to Bove's order in a letter to Pam Bondi, then the Attorney General. The appeal made by Adams's lawyers, Sassoon wrote,

“should be called out for what it is: an improper offer of immigration enforcement assistance in exchange for a dismissal of his case.” If the directive wasn’t reconsidered, she added, “I am prepared to offer my resignation.”

Like many of Sassoon’s peers, Cohen hoped that the letter would persuade the D.O.J. to change course. Sassoon was a member of the conservative Federalist Society, had clerked for the late Supreme Court Justice Antonin Scalia, and had been appointed to her position by Trump. One might have thought that these credentials would bolster her credibility with the White House. But Bove not only accepted Sassoon’s resignation; he scolded her for “suggesting that you retain discretion to interpret the Constitution in a manner inconsistent with the policies of a democratically elected President.” He soon transferred responsibility for the Adams case from New York to the D.O.J.’s headquarters, in Washington, D.C.

Cohen was dismayed by these developments, but she didn’t resign. The S.D.N.Y. still had hundreds of other important cases on its docket. The best way to continue serving the public, she believed, was by remaining in her job. Six weeks after she and Rohrbach were put on leave, the D.O.J. informed them that they could indeed return, but only if they and other members of the S.D.N.Y. team apologized, declaring that they had acted wrongfully in prosecuting Adams and in failing to comply with the directive to dismiss the charges. Once she learned of these demands, Cohen knew that her career as a federal prosecutor was over. A few days later, she resigned.

In 1970, Harvard University Press published “Exit, Voice, and Loyalty,” by a German-born economist named Albert Hirschman. The book examined the ways that social actors can respond to dysfunction and decline in organizations, from businesses to political parties and governments. One option is to protest from within—to exercise “voice.” Another is to vote with one’s feet and “exit” the situation. A third response is “loyalty”—to stick around in the hope of preserving what remains of the organization’s core values.

Hirschman’s book appeared a few years after President Lyndon B. Johnson dramatically escalated America’s involvement in Vietnam, a decision that Hirschman clearly wished had prompted more of Johnson’s advisers to

resign. Exit from government had become “deplorably infrequent” in Washington, Hirschman wrote, attributing this reluctance to spinelessness and to a “member-of-the-team trap” that led insiders to overestimate their ability to exert a correcting influence. Yet elsewhere in the book Hirschman acknowledged that breaking from the team, however courageous, can have perverse consequences, especially in organizations responsible for the provision of public goods like education and crime prevention. The output of such organizations affects everyone, and a conscientious official may reasonably fear that exiting in a crisis will only accelerate it. Hirschman posited that the member of a deteriorating organization will compare “the disutility, discomfort, and shame of remaining a member to the prospective damage which would be inflicted on him as a nonmember and on society at large by the additional deterioration that would occur if he were to get out.” The worse the situation becomes, he added, the stronger the conviction an employee may have “that one has to stay on.”

The predicament described in Hirschman’s book is now playing out for many civil servants and federal workers in the Trump era. Should they exit if ordered to do something illegal or unconscionable by their superiors? Or should they display loyalist behavior, not least to avoid being replaced by sycophants or opportunists who will do whatever their bosses tell them? In no agency have the stakes of this quandary been higher than in the Department of Justice, whose mission is to uphold the rule of law. In May, the *Times* published an analysis of federal-employment data which found that one in five government lawyers had left their job since the start of 2025. The largest numerical decline was in the Justice Department, where more than four thousand have left—a reduction of roughly thirty per cent.

Stacey Young, an attorney in the department’s Civil Rights Division, exited almost immediately after Trump was inaugurated. Unlike some of her peers, Young took Trump at his word when he promised to use his power to exact revenge on his enemies should he be reelected. She’d also read Project 2025, a blueprint issued by the right-wing Heritage Foundation which called for reclassifying civil servants as at-will employees—thus making it easier to replace them with politically aligned subordinates—and for rooting out “progressive ideology” in the federal bureaucracy. In 2016, she’d founded a group within the D.O.J. to address gender disparities and sexual misconduct.

After quitting, Young started Justice Connection, a nonprofit to assist current and former D.O.J. employees who, like her, had been thrust into ethical and professional crises by the actions of the Trump Administration. The group was launched with support from the Government Accountability Project, a nonprofit that advocates for whistle-blowers. Justice Connection has helped hundreds of D.O.J. attorneys secure everything from legal counsel to mental-health services. Its website features an archive of resignation letters submitted by lawyers who have chosen to leave. One states, “I can’t with a clean conscience defend actions by our clients that I cannot square with even the most tortured reading of the U.S. Code and Constitution.” Another affirms, “I will not . . . serve this current incarnation of the Department. It defines ‘justice’ in a way that I do not recognize.”

Over coffee in Washington recently, Young, who has thick silver hair and steely green eyes, praised the courage of such litigators. Among them were six federal prosecutors in Minnesota who’d resigned after reportedly being pressured to investigate the widow of Renée Good, a U.S. citizen who was killed by an *ICE* agent on January 7th. “They could have tried saying, ‘I want to get off this case—put me on other cases,’ ” Young told me. “They sacrificed their jobs and, possibly, their careers to do the right thing.” These actions were especially notable because, contrary to what Trump has claimed, the people resigning weren’t partisan members of the “deep state.” Young noted, “The typical D.O.J. lawyer is fairly apolitical. They’re law nerds.”

Celia Cohen told me that, for most of the time that she’d worked at the U.S. Attorney’s office, she hadn’t even known the political views of her colleagues. “That just wasn’t a topic of conversation,” she said. Before joining the S.D.N.Y., she clerked for Alison Nathan, a federal judge who had been appointed by President Barack Obama, but Cohen was hardly a left-wing ideologue. “I’m allergic to extremes,” she told me. We were outside her local library on a chilly spring day, and she was wearing a cream-colored scarf and a matching crew-neck sweater. She’d grown up in New Jersey, she said, in a household where debates about current events often took place at the dinner table; her mother, a journalist, would encourage her to participate. Cohen recalled, “There was always point-counterpoint, which teaches you the danger of staking out extreme positions that are hard to defend.” One

thing that attracted her to the law was that it facilitates a “peaceful reconciliation of differences.”

Cohen accepts that policy priorities shift when a new Administration takes power. If Trump had pardoned Eric Adams, she told me, she wouldn’t have objected, because doing so was a Presidential prerogative. “That’s a very different path than instructing *us* to execute a political decision,” she said. Resigning, she went on, was both the hardest and the easiest thing she’d ever done. It was easy because the correct choice was so clear to her. On the same day she was placed on leave, the Justice Department made a filing in federal court laying out why the charges against Adams should be dismissed. One reason it cited was the supposed misconduct of the prosecutors who had brought the case. This departed from what Emil Bove himself had written in his memo to Danielle Sassoon, which explicitly noted that the order to drop the charges “in no way calls into question the integrity and efforts” of the prosecutors.



To accede to Bove’s demand would have required her to become an apparatchik, Cohen told me, which was a non-starter. Even so, the decision to quit had been wrenching. She mournfully recalled something that Preet Bharara would say to prosecutors at the S.D.N.Y.: “Every day is Thanksgiving.” As he liked to put it, and as she came to feel, they should all

be grateful to have a job with only one requirement—“to do the right thing, the right way, for the right reason.”

In a new book, “The Department of Revenge,” Devlin Barrett, a reporter at the *Times*, catalogues the damage that the Trump Administration’s weaponization of the Justice Department has caused. Numerous attorneys have been pushed out or fired after refusing to prosecute such Trump enemies as the former F.B.I. director James Comey and the New York attorney general Letitia James. When these vindictive prosecutions eventually fell under scrutiny in courtrooms, they didn’t fare well. It is extremely rare for grand juries to dismiss charges brought by federal prosecutors, but the case against James, who was accused of committing mortgage fraud, has been rejected twice. Indictments of James and Comey were initially secured by Lindsey Halligan, a lawyer and a former beauty-pageant contestant whom Trump had appointed as the U.S. Attorney for the Eastern District of Virginia, even though she’d had no experience as a prosecutor. But a magistrate judge subsequently reprimanded her for a “disturbing pattern of profound investigative missteps,” including repeatedly misstating the law to grand jurors. Another judge then dismissed both cases, ruling that Halligan had been appointed unlawfully. “Trump’s quest for revenge was ending careers, destroying reputations, forcing an exodus of legal experience, and killing the credibility of the Justice Department,” Barrett concludes. “In many instances, the people whose reputations it was tarnishing were not Trump’s intended targets, but rather those willing to carry out his angry orders.”

Several people who have exited the D.O.J. told me that any lawyer of integrity who can afford to stop working there should do so. “Can you work for justice in an unjust department?” one asked, adding that his “reservoir of grace” for those who remained had “run dry.” Alexander Kristofcak, a former Assistant U.S. Attorney in the Civil Division of the S.D.N.Y., shares this sentiment. In March, 2025, Kristofcak posted on LinkedIn a copy of a letter that Ed Martin, whom Trump appointed as the interim U.S. Attorney for the District of Columbia, had sent to the dean of Georgetown Law School. Martin had threatened that his office would refuse to hire Georgetown students and graduates unless the university ended its diversity-equity-and-inclusion programs. The letter was “a grotesque abuse of power” and “an astonishing admission of viewpoint discrimination,” Kristofcak

wrote on LinkedIn. (The D.C. Bar has since opened disciplinary proceedings against Martin.) Afterward, Kristofcak received many private notes from people thanking him for his comments. But on March 7, 2025—the same day the federal marshal came to Celia Cohen’s office—he also got a letter from Todd Blanche informing him that he’d been placed on leave.

Kristofcak, in fact, had already decided to quit. He grew up in Czechoslovakia, which was ruled by a Communist dictatorship until 1989. When Trump was reelected, Kristofcak reread “The Power of the Powerless,” by Václav Havel, the playwright and dissident who’d helped topple the Communist regime. Kristofcak was struck by a passage in which Havel describes a grocer who places a sign bearing the slogan “Workers of the World, Unite!” in his shop window, not because he believes in Communism but because he’s afraid of the authorities and hopes to mollify them. History was now repeating itself in the United States, Kristofcak thought. Kristofcak, who is gay, had been startled when a group called DOJ Pride—which was established in 1994 to advocate for L.G.B.T.Q.+ employees—voluntarily ceased operations after Trump was reelected. This echoed the kind of preëemptive, fear-driven compliance that Havel had described. Kristofcak has come to the conclusion that lawyers at the D.O.J. should resign en masse. “I don’t feel like staying there is making a difference,” he told me. “I believe that the department now often acts like a criminal organization—and being part of it is just helping it achieve its aims.”

One risk of staying in the current D.O.J., various people told me, was that your work could inadvertently give a veneer of legitimacy to Administration misconduct. Indeed, this was among the few reasons that senior officials still seemed to value having career attorneys around.

A striking example of this phenomenon occurred on June 12th, when the Justice Department’s Antitrust Division announced that it was closing its review of Paramount Skydance’s proposed merger with Warner Bros. Discovery, clearing the deal to move forward. The press release cited a “rigorous eight-month investigation led by the Division’s career staff,” who had solicited more than two million documents before determining that the merger would actually “increase competition across the media and

entertainment ecosystem, with benefits for American consumers and workers.”

A lawyer who has worked in the Antitrust Division was aghast, telling me that the press release had glossed over a key fact: that the team of career staff reviewing this material had serious concerns about the merger. They were pleading for more time, so that they could decide whether to recommend challenging the proposal, when the investigation was abruptly closed. “Staff didn’t want the result that ultimately happened, and their work was used to justify an ending that they thought was unwise,” the lawyer said. “We had been used as dumb pawns.”

Jack Smith—the former special counsel who oversaw the criminal investigations into Trump’s role in the January 6th attack on the U.S. Capitol and into his alleged mishandling of classified documents—resigned shortly before the President returned to office. Yet, in an interview this summer on MS NOW, Smith praised D.O.J. prosecutors who’d stayed at the agency. “What I tell friends who are still in the department is ‘Serve as long as you can,’ ” he said. “Our country needs the Justice Department to do its job.”

Shortly after Smith’s interview aired, I spoke to a federal prosecutor who’d needed no convincing to stay put. Every time the Trump Administration did something corrupt or morally problematic, it made the prosecutor want to “dig my heels in *more*.” The prosecutor was aware that some people viewed career officials who had remained at the Justice Department as comparable to the bureaucrats who had dutifully followed orders in Nazi Germany. This made the prosecutor livid, particularly when the judgment came from former peers who’d left for the private sector and were now keeping silent—perhaps so that they could return to public service when Trump was no longer around.

The prosecutor acknowledged that staying in the job was difficult but told me that “some abstract general objection to being associated with it isn’t reason enough to just abandon the mission and the people who we’re supposed to be fighting for.” Every day, the prosecutor said, D.O.J. lawyers were performing vital functions, from convicting sex traffickers to handling sensitive national-security cases. Moreover, when troubling directives were issued, career officials could still find ways to limit the damage. Some have

done so, the prosecutor explained, by slow-walking directives of dubious merit, such as orders to investigate voter fraud by noncitizens—a phenomenon that Trump has falsely claimed is rampant. (In fact, it is exceedingly rare.) “You have these meetings, you hear them out, you nod and say, ‘We’ll look into it,’ ” the prosecutor explained. “And then at some point you have another meeting and gently tell them why they’re fucking insane and wrong.” Half the time, the prosecutor said, “they say you’re right, because they’re distracted by the next thing.” Career officials who witness corruption could also create a paper trail so that the people responsible may one day be held accountable. “Eventually, all of this will be looked into, and there are going to be consequences,” the prosecutor said.

The prosecutor agreed that officials who were ordered to cross an ethical line should stand their ground, as the attorneys in the Eric Adams case had. (This is also the view of Smith, who told MS NOW, “Obviously, if you’re asked to do something that you know is wrong, then your number’s up.”) But, the prosecutor said, “*make* them fire you.” Too many people had quit well before this juncture, which only abetted the Administration’s efforts to dismantle the federal bureaucracy.

The prosecutor brought up a recent book, “Making a Career in Dictatorship,” by the political scientists Adam Scharpf and Christian Glässel, which examines the junta that ruled Argentina in the nineteen-seventies and eighties, during the so-called Dirty War, when as many as thirty thousand people were killed or disappeared. The secret police was filled with loyalists, most of whom were low-performing officers who’d fared poorly at military academies but had been promoted into leadership positions because they would do whatever the junta asked, including torture. To the prosecutor, this dynamic was reminiscent of what is unfolding in the U.S. Justice Department, where attorneys with no prior management experience have been handed leadership positions because of their willingness to advance the Administration’s political priorities. Prominent appointments have gone to figures such as Jason Reding Quiñones, a prosecutor who reportedly received low scores on performance evaluations while working at the Southern District of Florida. Last year, Trump appointed him to run the Florida office, and Quiñones is now overseeing an investigation into whether a cabal of “deep state” actors, including the former C.I.A. director John Brennan, conspired to violate Trump’s rights.

In other countries that have recently experienced democratic backsliding, such as Turkey and Hungary, installing loyalists in the judiciary and in government agencies has played a key role in helping autocrats consolidate power. This underscored the importance of staying at one's job, the prosecutor felt: "I have some level of resentment toward people who are just quitting without coming close to a red line and putting themselves out as being heroic for doing so and being praised as heroic for doing so. To me, it feels like abandonment—and selfish."

In May, the *Times* columnist Michelle Goldberg asked, of the Justice Department, "How long can decent people continue to work for such a corrupted institution?" Many decent people still *did* work there, Stacey Young, of Justice Connection, told me. "There are some extraordinarily brave people on the inside who are taking enormous risks to do the right thing," she said. The bravest, she thought, were those trying to hold the line in units, such as the Civil Rights Division, where the corruption and the pressure to conform are most intense: "The real heroes are the ones who do terrible work and make sure they do it as ethically as possible."

Such individuals face increasing risk. On September 1st, Matthew Evans, an Assistant U.S. Attorney in Minnesota, sent an e-mail to the attorneys of Julio Cesar Sosa-Celis, a Venezuelan migrant who'd been shot in the leg, in January, by an *ICE* agent during Operation Metro Surge, the Trump Administration's crackdown on illegal immigration in Minneapolis. Sosa-Celis, who was unarmed, was shot through his front door, a seemingly clear-cut example of unwarranted aggression. Evans informed the attorneys that the Justice Department was planning to charge the *ICE* officer only with making false statements about the circumstances that had led to the shooting—the officer claimed that he'd acted in self-defense—and not with violating Sosa-Celis's civil rights, a far more serious crime. "I objected in the strongest possible terms," Evans explained in the e-mail, which was first reported by *ProPublica*. "It wasn't enough." The next day, he was fired. In a chilling development, Evans is now under criminal investigation for allegedly leaking details of the case. If charged and convicted, he could be jailed or disbarred.

The investigation of Evans was overshadowed in most press accounts, which focussed on the fact that the *ICE* agent, Christian Castro, was the first

federal officer deployed to Minneapolis during Operation Metro Surge to be prosecuted for any crime. (Castro has pleaded not guilty to all charges.) But Evans's fate alarmed a D.O.J. attorney I spoke to in early September. "They're not just going to get rid of us—they're going to *prosecute* us," the attorney said.

One D.O.J. lawyer who's been preparing for the possibility of being prosecuted is Zachary Phillips, who lives in Morrison, Colorado, outside Denver. Phillips is fifty-nine, with a shaved head and prominent tattoos on his forearms. He could easily be mistaken for a cop, which is what he was before he decided to go to law school. In 2008, he became an Assistant U.S. Attorney for the District of Colorado. Being a federal prosecutor, Phillips told me, "was the best job in the world." In 2022, he began going to Washington to help investigate and prosecute the January 6th assault on the Capitol. He was supposed to work on the detail for six months; he ended up staying for three years. During that time, he watched endless footage of the insurrection. "The amount of violence that took place that day is mind-numbing," he said. The most vicious assaults, he added, had targeted police officers. "I'm a very, *very* pro-law-enforcement guy," he said. "I've been shot at. I know what it's like to be in life-and-death situations. Those officers are heroes."

When Trump was reelected, Phillips expected him to keep a campaign promise to pardon many of the January 6th rioters. Nonetheless, he was gutted when a near-blanket pardon was issued. "It's pretty jarring to have more than fifteen hundred cases you've worked on all of a sudden just go away," he said. Fearing retribution, he contacted a lawyer to discuss what he should do if the federal prosecutors who'd investigated January 6th cases were prosecuted themselves—a step that some January 6th defendants have publicly called for.

After Trump pardoned the rioters, Phillips had to stay on the detail and help file the paperwork to dismiss the cases. He eventually asked to work on something removed from criminal prosecutions, and his office obliged. In April, 2025, he was assigned to asset forfeiture and returned to the District of Colorado office. He liked the job, but his mood darkened. He no longer took pride in telling people that he worked for the Justice Department. Soon after Pam Bondi became Attorney General, she issued a memo instructing

attorneys in the Justice Department to “zealously advance” the Administration’s policies; anyone who didn’t would be “subject to discipline and potentially termination.” Phillips was appalled by the memo’s implication that D.O.J. attorneys were President Trump’s lawyers. Then came the fatal shootings of U.S. citizens by *ICE* agents in Minneapolis, which the Justice Department has neglected to prosecute. Denver, like Minneapolis, has been called a sanctuary city. “Are we next?” Phillips asked himself. He also wondered if, by training younger colleagues, he might be passing along skills and experience that would be used to *subvert* the rule of law. Even doing something innocuous like asset forfeiture started to make him feel complicit, since filling this role might enable the Administration to hire someone else to perform another, more nefarious function.

In April, Phillips left the Justice Department. He recalled that, when he told his wife, “it was amazing how good I immediately felt.” The decision didn’t come without costs. Phillips was less than three years away from being able to retire with a full pension, but, he told me, some things were more important than money. At his home, in the room where we were sitting, he’d mounted a poster. Titled “Insurrection Maze,” it was a detailed rendering of the siege on the Capitol, showing rioters smashing windows and wielding bats, sticks, pepper spray, and stun guns. A “Seditious Scumbag Checklist” revealed the names of the insurrectionists in the drawing. Phillips had helped bring some of these people to justice.

In July, I met with Dena Robinson in Washington, D.C. Robinson joined the Justice Department’s Civil Rights Division in 2020. This unit, which was created in 1957, has long been regarded as the D.O.J.’s crown jewel. It is supposed to enforce anti-discrimination laws in housing, voting, education, and other sectors, to help fulfill the promise that all Americans are granted equal protection under the law.

Robinson, a queer Black woman with flowing locs and an easygoing manner, was thrilled to begin working at the division, not long after graduating from the University of Maryland’s law school. At the time, the division had some four hundred attorneys. Today, there are roughly two hundred. Under the leadership of Harmeet Dhillon, a fierce critic of what the Administration calls “woke ideology,” the division has shifted its focus to combatting diversity initiatives that allegedly violate the rights of white

people, fighting supposed anti-Christian bias, and defending gun rights. Dhillon made the decision not to investigate the killing of Renée Good; instead, she launched an investigation into Brandon Johnson, the mayor of Chicago, for allegedly engaging in discriminatory hiring practices, after he highlighted the fact that many Black officials are serving in his administration. The division's attorneys have investigated universities that allegedly failed to protect Jewish students on campuses where protests erupted over the Gaza war. One of these universities was Brown, where, according to a whistle-blower complaint filed recently by former Civil Rights Division attorneys, investigators found no evidence that the school had violated Title VI of the Civil Rights Act, which bars discrimination on the basis of race or national origin. Despite this, the whistle-blowers claimed, senior government officials refused to send a "notice of no violation" to the school, and instead secured a settlement that required Brown to pay fifty million dollars to local organizations in order to end the investigation and have its federal research grants restored.

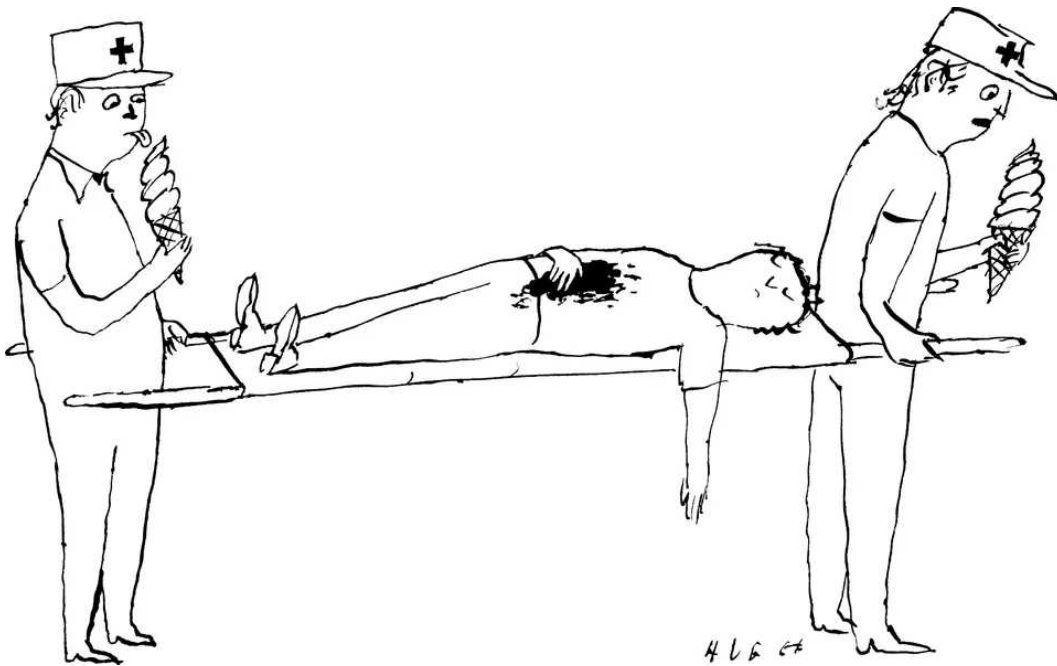
In early 2025, several senior leaders from the Civil Rights Division were transferred to a newly created Sanctuary Cities Enforcement Working Group, which turned out to be a "rubber room"—a holding tank where employees were given nothing of substance to do. It was clear that the Administration wanted these employees to quit; the D.O.J. also launched a buyout program. But Robinson urged her co-workers to resist. "I was Team Hold the Line," she said. She'd made it known that there were certain things she would refuse to do because they were inconsistent with the section's previous enforcement work and her personal values. For example, she would have nothing to do with what she called "anti-trans investigations." (One of her best friends is a trans man.) Yet she still felt an obligation to stay. "One of the things we talked about was the importance of bearing witness to all the ways this Administration might contravene established policies," she said. "Documentation is so important in the federal government, including for the people who will eventually come back to rebuild."

However committed Robinson was to staying, the emotional experience was excruciating. "What is going on with you?" her mother would ask her when they spoke on the phone, telling her that she never sounded happy or excited anymore. Robinson's loctician told her that there was a heaviness about her, "like you're being followed by a dark cloud." One morning, while Robinson

was on the train to work, the conductor announced that a small mechanical fire had broken out. Robinson said to herself, “I wish the fire would come into *this* car, so I wouldn’t have to go into that building.” A few weeks later, she learned that nearly all the managers in her section, who had served as a buffer between the Administration and the staff attorneys, were resigning. She started sobbing, fearing that the entire section would collapse. On May 30, 2025, Robinson walked out of her building for the last time. Seven co-workers also exited that day.

Alyssa Lareau, who left the Civil Rights Division’s Federal Coordination and Compliance Section last year after concluding that anti-discrimination laws such as Title VI were no longer being faithfully enforced, was similarly torn. “Doing a workday felt like an assault,” Lareau recalled. “And then I would finish, and the toll of it, the wrestling with it, would hit me—am I enabling a fascist regime, or is there great power in being a bureaucrat? Leaving was the hardest decision I’ve ever made.” Her entire section departed collectively in May. Among the reasons: a memo from Dhillon that described her section’s mission as enforcing such Trump priorities as “Defending Women from Gender Ideology Extremism” and “Keeping Men Out of Women’s Sports.” Workers from other sections gathered in the building’s lobby and clapped as Lareau and her colleagues walked out. Lareau is at peace with her decision, she told me, feeling that they had to leave to avoid being used “as tools for evil.” But, as they filed out, the mood was “funereal,” she said.

Samantha Trepel, a former prosecutor at the Civil Rights Division, led the investigation into the death of George Floyd, which resulted in the conviction of four Minneapolis police officers, in 2022. Trepel ultimately came to believe that staying in her job served little purpose. “Cases were getting dismissed, people were being removed,” she said. Within a few months, for example, the Civil Rights Division abruptly closed lawsuits or investigations related to eight police departments that the D.O.J. had previously determined were engaging in discriminatory policing and using unconstitutional force. “The conclusion I was coming to was that I was not going to be very effective in my priorities—to protect the work, to protect the people under me, and to protect the institution,” Trepel said. “The D.O.J. left me. I didn’t leave the D.O.J.”



Trepel also believed that her legal skills could be put to better use outside the department. She is now a program director at the States United Democracy Center, a nonprofit that aims to safeguard elections and defend the rule of law from federal overreach. In her final months at the D.O.J., everything she did felt “defensive,” she told me, as her section tried to keep Title VI and environmental-justice investigations from being dismissed. Now she is actively assisting states that are seeking protection from federal investigations that she considers baseless, and from unlawful deployments of federal law enforcement. “That felt so much better to me,” she said.

Robinson, too, now works at a nonprofit, as a senior staff attorney at the A.C.L.U. She is currently focussing on litigation intended to protect L.G.B.T.Q.+ Americans against discriminatory statutes. Among them is a law passed by the Kansas legislature which retroactively invalidated the driver’s licenses of trans people and prohibited them from using rest rooms that align with their gender identity. The job is clearly more in synch with Robinson’s values, but she nevertheless wakes up some mornings feeling grief and guilt. “I really enjoy the work that I’m doing now,” she said. “At the same time, I do sometimes wish that I was inside, fighting. Every time I talk to someone on the inside and I hear about what’s going on or just the stress they’re facing, there is a part of me that wishes I was there with

them.” (A spokesperson for the D.O.J. insisted that the Civil Rights Division “enforces federal civil-rights laws even-handedly.”)

Ironically, Robinson and other former Justice Department lawyers may be better positioned than their peers on the inside to engage in another form of protest that Albert Hirschman described in his book: voice. In Hirschman’s account, voice is presented as an alternative to exit, one exercised mainly by insiders who “kick up a fuss” from within, through mechanisms such as “individual or collective petition to the management” or an “appeal to a higher authority with the intention of forcing a change in management.”

Some Justice Department attorneys have tried to lodge internal protests. On March 14, 2025, a D.O.J. official named Erez Reuveni attended a meeting at which Emil Bove allegedly told lawyers that they might have to say “Fuck you” to the courts if they blocked the Trump Administration from using the Alien Enemies Act, a rarely invoked wartime law, to deport Venezuelan migrants to El Salvador. (Bove has claimed that he doesn’t recall saying this and denies advising D.O.J. attorneys to violate court orders.) A judge soon issued an injunction halting the deportations, but this didn’t stop the removals. Reuveni, who had been promoted to serve as the acting deputy director for the Office of Immigration Litigation, warned his superiors that the government might be in violation of the court order. At a hearing three weeks later, he told a federal judge that the deportation of one of the migrants, Kilmar Abrego Garcia, had been a mistake. In response, Reuveni’s superior ordered him to sign a brief describing Abrego Garcia as a terrorist. The records Reuveni had been shown contained no evidence of this, and he refused to comply. (“I didn’t sign up to lie,” he told his boss.) The same day, Reuveni was put on leave, in part for his “failure to follow a directive” from a superior.

Less than a week later, he was fired. Reuveni then filed a whistle-blower complaint with the Justice Department’s Office of the Inspector General. It stated that high-level government officials “willfully defied court orders, directed their subordinate attorneys to make misrepresentations to courts, and engaged in a scheme to withhold relevant information from the court to advance the Administration’s priority of deporting noncitizens.” The office responded a day later by informing him that the issues he had raised “do not warrant an investigation.” Reuveni’s lawyers also sent his complaint to

Charles Grassley, a Republican senator from Iowa and a longtime champion of whistle-blowers; Grassley was unmoved, dismissing the complaint as a mere “political strike.”

This unresponsiveness has not entirely stopped D.O.J. attorneys from reporting wrongdoing. Some have taken to relaying information to reporters. In June, Justice Connection and Protect Democracy, another nonprofit group, published a six-page guide titled “Speaking Up from Within the Government,” which offers federal workers advice on how to engage with the press in a way that protects them and respects the law. Disclosing information that constitutes an abuse of authority or other gross misconduct is legally protected, with only narrow exceptions—classified and grand-jury information can’t be revealed, for example.

Nevertheless, D.O.J. attorneys know that talking to the press can now get them fired, or worse. Their former colleagues who have left may feel less constrained. Indeed, Hirschman noted in his book that officials who resign from institutions that produce public goods may be emboldened to exercise what he called “voice from without”—speaking out *after* one’s exit to cast light on “mistaken policies.”

Some former Justice Department lawyers have joined organizations such as the Washington Litigation Group, a nonprofit that has been drawing attention to the Trump Administration’s assault on the rule of law by suing it. One of the attorneys now working there is Alexander Kristofcak, the former Assistant U.S. Attorney who was dismissed from the D.O.J. for posting a critical comment about Ed Martin on LinkedIn. More recently, Kristofcak served as the lead counsel in a lawsuit challenging the Department of the Interior’s removal of a Pride flag from Stonewall National Monument, in New York City. In April, under a settlement, the flag was put back in place.

Other former officials have spoken publicly about the unethical things they were instructed to do. This past May, Brian Driscoll, a decorated law-enforcement agent who became the F.B.I.’s acting director at the start of Trump’s second term, told CNN that he had been ordered to provide the Trump Administration with a list of agents who investigated January 6th cases so that they could be purged. He refused, a decision that soon led the

F.B.I. director, Kash Patel, to fire him. In the interview, Driscoll said that he'd known he would be punished but needed to be able to tell his family, "I didn't compromise what I knew was right."

Until we met last spring, Celia Cohen hadn't spoken publicly about the Eric Adams case and the circumstances that led her to leave her job. She had, however, exercised voice. On the day she resigned, she and her colleagues sent a letter to Todd Blanche. It was co-signed by Andrew Rohrbach, the prosecutor who had also been placed on leave, and by Derek Wikstrom, another Assistant U.S. Attorney at the S.D.N.Y. who'd worked on the Adams prosecution. "We will not confess wrongdoing when there was none," they wrote in response to the Justice Department's demand that they apologize for prosecuting Adams and failing to comply with orders. "We have served under Presidents of both parties, advancing their priorities while pursuing justice without fear or favor. . . . Now, the Department has decided that obedience supersedes all else, requiring us to abdicate our legal and ethical obligations in favor of directions from Washington. That is wrong."

The letter, which was three paragraphs long, took little time to write. But it took considerable courage to send. A few weeks after federal marshals escorted Cohen out of 26 Federal Plaza, other marshals were dispatched to deliver a letter to Liz Oyer, a pardon attorney at the Justice Department who'd been fired after she refused to recommend restoring gun rights to Mel Gibson, a prominent Trump supporter. (The D.O.J. denied that this was the cause of her firing.) The letter cautioned her about participating in an upcoming congressional hearing. Oyer's son was at home without her, and she and a former colleague had to make panicked pleas to get the marshals called off. (An attorney for Oyer described this stunt as a use of "the Department's security resources to intimidate a former employee.") Cohen had two young kids. Could something like that happen to her? "It was a time when it felt like there were no rules," she said. "It was very scary."

Cohen, an intensely private person, knew that the resignation letter would circulate among her peers and could, at some point, become public. When it did, she hoped that it would help highlight the apolitical basis of her team's decision—and the danger of weakening norms that protect prosecutors from political reprisal. But the letter aroused only fleeting press attention. For a

while, Cohen told me, “I felt a bit defeatist about what we’d done, looking at all the damage that happened afterward. It didn’t stop.”

Cohen’s feelings changed when she later read the resignation letters of other Justice Department lawyers—letters that often contained strikingly similar language to hers. But this did not diminish the grief she felt about the Justice Department. One thing she loved about her former job was the respect accorded to federal prosecutors for being honest brokers. She said, “We were not treated like any other litigant, because the courts trusted that, when an attorney for the government stood up and said something, there was a *weight* behind it—a truth behind it—that wasn’t expected of other counsel.”

This trust, known as the presumption of regularity, has been shattered, and a growing number of judges have expressed frustration and alarm. Mary S. McElroy, a federal district judge in Rhode Island, recently discovered that the government had lied by claiming that a hospital had stopped responding to its requests for records on gender-transition care for youths. “D.O.J. has proven unworthy of this trust at every point in this case,” McElroy declared. “This reckless disregard for the duty of candor owed to a federal court is appalling.” In Chicago, April Perry, a U.S. district judge in northern Illinois, expressed similar dismay after finding out that, in a prosecution of *ICE* protesters, federal attorneys had, among other things, removed grand jurors who expressed skepticism about the case after reviewing initial evidence—and then tried to hide this maneuver by redacting the grand-jury transcripts. This conduct left Perry “incredibly shocked.”

For decades, few jobs in the legal profession were more prestigious or competitive than being a federal prosecutor. But in recent months the Justice Department has begun offering twenty-five-thousand-dollar bonuses to recruit lawyers to work in certain offices—a sign of the shortage of attorneys willing to carry out its current priorities, which include suing states to obtain sensitive voter-roll information. (Harmeet Dhillon has filed dozens of lawsuits to secure such data; judges in at least twenty-three states have rejected her demands, affirming that there are no grounds for turning this information over. Dhillon is appealing many of these rulings.) The struggle to fill these openings appears to be causing a staffing shortage that may hamper the Trump Administration’s ability to advance its agenda.

Even after Trump is gone, it is by no means clear that young lawyers will want to pursue careers as federal prosecutors. Who can assure these attorneys that, in some future Administration, they won't be told to disregard court orders? Or that a loyalist won't be appointed to run their office and then fire all their supervisors? Dena Robinson told me that, if she were graduating from law school today, she wouldn't set her sights on joining the Civil Rights Division. "I would be scared," she said. This fear is especially warranted for Black women, who have been pushed out of government jobs in outsized numbers during Trump's second term.

Cohen now works at a private law firm, and she told me that she's enjoying her new position. But working at the S.D.N.Y. wasn't just a job for her. After the marshal's visit, she recalled walking through the woods near her house, feeling bereft. "There were a lot of tears," she said. "It was a loss of a huge component of my identity—who I was, what I had planned to dedicate my life to." ♦

Letter from Colorado

Why Doesn't Anyone Want to Fix One of America's Scariest Roads?

The Million Dollar Highway, prone to rockfall and avalanches, is the site of horrific crashes and courageous rescues.

By Peter Hessler

September 28, 2026



In the valley where I live, along a quiet stretch of the Uncompahgre River, in southwestern Colorado, there is only one paved road, and, like most people around here, I don't drive it south without a good reason. In that direction, the road—U.S. Highway 550—passes through the small mountain town of Ouray, and then it climbs more than two thousand feet in the span of six miles. This section of the two-lane road has been carved directly into the red-quartzite cliffs of the Uncompahgre Gorge, and almost none of it has a shoulder; in some places, the highway is only twenty-three feet wide. The speed limit is twenty-five miles an hour, and one way to identify locals is that they often drive faster than that. This is because they worry about what can happen above the road. Rockfalls are common, and so are avalanches. There are more than sixty named slide routes along this part of the highway, and residents refer to them in personal terms, like bad neighbors who are always home: Riley Boy, Mother Cline, Slippery Jim. Highway 550 is the most avalanche-prone road that's open year-round in the United States.

Visitors are more likely to be concerned with what lies below. Many sections of the road have a sheer drop of more than four hundred feet, and there are no guardrails, because of the need to push snow off after avalanches. When the route was constructed, in the eighteen-eighties, it was considered one of the greatest achievements in road engineering in the American West. Its purpose was to serve the silver and gold mines of the San Juan Mountains, but almost immediately the road also began to attract tourists. At some point in the early twentieth century, for reasons that are now obscure, the section above Ouray became known as the Million Dollar Highway.

In 2013, *USA Today* featured the Million Dollar Highway; the Death Road, in Bolivia; the Highway of Death, in Iraq; and nine other infamous routes in an article titled "World's Most Dangerous Roads." Less than a year later, the paper's "10 Best Bucket-List Road Trips" also included the Million Dollar Highway. Strictly speaking, there's nothing contradictory about the same road appearing on both lists, although it helps explain why the Ouray County coroner used the phrase "attractive nuisance" when we talked about the road recently. People can behave erratically on the Million Dollar Highway. There has been at least one instance in which a driver got into a heated argument with her passengers, pulled over, kicked them out, and then, in full view of everybody, accelerated straight off the edge, to her death. One man travelled all the way from the Netherlands just to propel

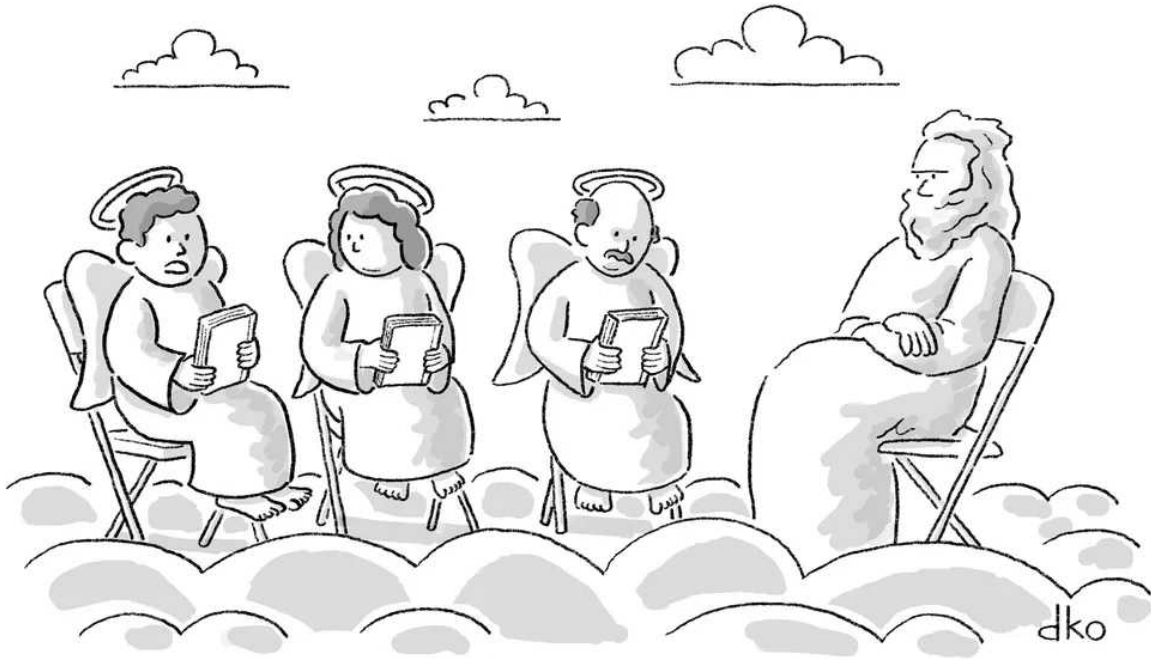
himself off the road. The G.P.S. data on the Dutchman's phone showed that he had driven repeatedly up and down the highway before choosing one of the most dramatic drop-offs.

Occasionally, a vehicle seems to vanish. Last year, early on the morning of August 5th, a tourist from Oregon named Adam Hynes was approaching one of the most treacherous sections of the gorge when he looked ahead and saw a silver Honda Civic moving in reverse. Hynes found it strange that somebody would be driving backward in such a spot, but then his view was obscured as he went around a sharp bend. By the time Hynes came out of the turn, the Honda was gone.

Hynes dropped a pin on his phone. There was no signal, so he continued down the highway until he was able to call 911. Then he circled back and parked at a pullout not far from the pin. The gorge was so precipitous that Hynes couldn't see the bottom, but he had a DJI Mavic 3 drone. He set the machine aloft, and its camera captured the Honda, which had fallen three hundred and twenty feet—about the height of a thirty-story building. The silver vehicle lay upside down in the Uncompahgre River, crumpled like an aluminum can.

When an accident occurs on a steep part of the road, police and emergency services wait until skilled climbers arrive. On that morning, a call went out to the Ouray Mountain Rescue Team, a local volunteer organization that is staffed with many expert climbers. Two members, Jeff Skoloda and Tim Pasek, arrived and strapped into harnesses and helmets. They climbed down a rope that led to a Tyrolean traverse, a fixed cable that runs over the river to the other side of the gorge. After that, they installed a rope on the far cliff wall and rappelled down to the Honda. It took them about twenty minutes to reach the wreckage.

As Skoloda approached, he couldn't tell how many people were inside. He is in his fifties, a successful sculptor and metalworker who owns a large workshop in Ouray. Since joining Ouray Mountain Rescue, in 2000, he has helped recover more than a hundred bodies, often in treacherous terrain. Many have been climbers, skiers, or other recreationalists, but some were found in vehicles that tumbled off the Million Dollar Highway. When Skoloda kneeled beside the Honda, he heard a scream.



Until then, the men had assumed that they were involved in a recovery operation. Now they tried to open the doors, but the Honda was too damaged; a handle broke off in Skoloda's hand. The screaming sounded like a young girl, but the voice was muffled and hard to hear above the rushing river. They couldn't see her face, because that side of the car had landed against a large boulder. But there was a small gap in the broken window on the other side, and Pasek reached in and touched a bare foot.

"Can you feel that?" he asked.

"Yes."

"Are you hurt?"

"Yes!"

Pasek used his emergency radio to tell rescue services on the road above that there was a survivor. They asked him to estimate how old she was, in order to figure out what size equipment might be necessary. The tumbling vehicle had left a long trail of debris across the sheer cliff—shoes, clothes, books, papers, luggage. Near the end of the trail, a children's book was lying in the dirt. Pasek picked it up: "A to Z Mysteries: The Zombie Zone." He has two

children of his own. He looked at a page and made a guess—"I think she's probably about ten."

In 2008, the public-school district of Ridgway, a town north of Ouray, donated a decommissioned school bus to Ouray Mountain Rescue. The team transported the bus to the Million Dollar Highway, where they shifted it into neutral and tied the steering wheel so that it wouldn't turn. Then they positioned a loader behind the bus and pushed it off a curve in the road.

Skoloda attended that training exercise, and he still has vivid memories of the school bus flying through the void and then sticking into the side of the mountain. "It kind of lawn-darted into place," he told me recently. After the vehicle came to rest, the rescue team helped twenty volunteers climb down and position themselves inside the bus. The volunteers wore moulage makeup that resembled blunt-force injuries, and each of them had a script to follow. Two mannequins were also placed inside—fatalities. For the next two hours, the rescue team practiced cutting into the bus with extrication tools, and they made triage and evacuation decisions based on the role-played injuries of the volunteers. A temporary morgue was set up on the Million Dollar Highway.

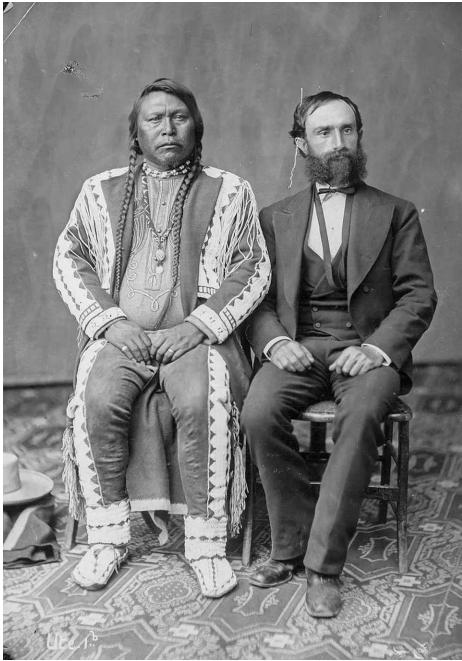
That particular training has not been repeated, but people still think a lot about school buses and children on the highway. A mass-casualty event would overwhelm the resources of a rural community. I coach the high-school track team in Ridgway, and on two occasions I've driven a busful of teen-agers to a meet via the Million Dollar Highway. The school has strict rules: If I'm driving a fourteen-passenger bus and the weather is good, I can take the highway. But, if we're in a larger bus or the forecast is bad, we're required to follow a longer route, to the west, that avoids steep drop-offs. The middle school used to take field trips south, in order to visit historical sites, but that stopped a few years ago, after bus drivers expressed concern. Nowadays, all field trips head in other directions. In essence, many residents live with their backs to the steepest sections of the highway.

The orientation was the opposite in the old days, when all attention was directed to the highlands. In 1882, major silver deposits were discovered in the Red Mountain Mining District, south of Ouray. Government surveyors had declared that it was impossible to build a road through the gorge, and

Ouray had tried twice without success. Another settlement, Silverton, lay on the far side of Red Mountain, and the communities vied to see which could become the main transport hub. In 1883, *La Plata Miner*, a Silverton newspaper, mocked the competitor's ambitions: "The people of Ouray say they will build a road to Red Mountain. How absurd and ridiculous."

That summer, Ouray contracted with a man whose nicknames included "Hebrew Pathfinder of the New West" and "Moses Who Piloted San Juan out of the Wilderness." Otto Mears was born in Russia, to Jewish parents, in 1840; his mother came from what is now Latvia, and his father was English. Both parents died before Mears was three, and he was passed off among relatives who didn't want to care for him. At the age of nine, he was shipped on a lumber freighter from Russia to England; a year later, he was sent to the United States. He received almost no formal education, and he worked full time from age eleven, eventually finding odd jobs in California mining towns. He observed that miners and prospectors were usually poor, whereas people involved in transport and merchandise thrived.

During the Civil War, Mears enlisted with the Union Army, which sent him to the Southwest. At the end of his service, he received an assignment to bake bread for soldiers, which allowed him to profit from the leftover flour. After saving some money, Mears opened the first sawmill in southwestern Colorado, along with a flour mill, both of which supplied the military. He was a genius at figuring out frontier businesses that complemented one another. He helped found towns in southern Colorado, and he started newspapers that promoted those towns; sometimes he also acquired government contracts to build their roads and deliver their mail. The Ute Indians were the dominant tribe in the region, and Mears was one of the few whites who learned to speak their language fluently. He served as the federal government's translator in treaty negotiations, and he became a close friend of Chief Ouray, the tribe's most important leader.



Mears's greatest talent was for road-building. In Colorado, which didn't become a state until 1876, there was little public money for infrastructure, and entrepreneurs could pay a few dollars to the local government for the right to build a toll road. In the course of two decades, Mears created a network of almost four hundred and fifty miles of roads. He had no engineering background, but he often laid out routes himself. South of Ouray, many sections had to be blasted out of eight-hundred-foot cliffs. Workers were suspended by ropes: they drilled holes in the quartzite, packed the holes with dynamite, lit long fuses, and gave a signal to be yanked up to safety as quickly as possible. According to "The Road That Silver Built," a history of the highway's early years, there were reports that five of Mears's workers died.

The road was open for traffic in less than six months. Mears set up a tollgate, charging a dollar for a horse and rider and five dollars for a team and wagon. He reportedly collected more than a hundred thousand dollars from his roads in a single year, and Ouray boomed. After Silverton lost the race to Red Mountain, local officials contracted with Mears, who then built their road, too. For good measure, he purchased stock in a silver mine near the pass where the two routes came together; for a spell, the mine paid an annual dividend of forty-five per cent. After four years of operating the Ouray road, he sold it to the town.

Mears was, by all accounts, unsentimental about his origins. When dictating his autobiography, he covered his childhood—the dying parents in Russia, the orphan shipped off to England and America—in fifteen sentences. He became heavily involved in Colorado politics but usually behind the scenes, and he seemed to hold no high ideals or scruples. He often paid bribes, and he did everything possible to resist organized labor. When most of the Utes were inevitably driven out of Colorado—after every treaty had been broken by the Americans and violence had ensued—Mears helped negotiate the terms of their departure. As the Army escorted the Utes out, Mears charged them tolls for using his roads. He also acquired contracts that allowed him to profit from developing a supply chain that served the Utes' new home, in a part of Utah so desolate that even the Mormons didn't want to live there.

In 1911, a motorcar drove up to Red Mountain Pass. The dealership that sponsored the journey described it as “one of the most remarkable, perilous, and daring trips ever undertaken by an automobile on the American continent.” By the following decade, people had started using the phrase “Million Dollar Highway.” This didn't refer to the cost of Mears's original project, which had been about a hundred and forty thousand dollars. In the nineteen-twenties, a series of road improvements were made for a total of about a million dollars, which may have been the source of the name, although some maintain that it came from the spectacular views. Mears died at the age of ninety-one, and the end of his life seems to have been as unsentimental as its beginning. According to the biography “Otto Mears and the San Juans,” there were conflicting stories about where his ashes were scattered. Some reports claimed that they were tossed onto the road near the site of his former toll booth.

From the moment that emergency services arrived in response to the wrecked Honda, it was nearly two hours until rescuers saw the girl's face. Climbers had to assist two firefighters carrying extrication equipment into the gorge, and then Pasek, who is also a member of the Ouray volunteer fire department, used the tools to tear off the driver's door. He and Skoloda removed the body of a middle-aged man, who had been driving. Then Pasek took off a back door. “As I pried it open, we could see the girl,” he recalled. “Her skin looked good. She wasn't pale. She was just looking at us.”



She said her name was Rachelle, and she was eleven. She complained of being cold; the river had soaked her legs and jacket. She had found herself upside down, suspended by her seat belt. Even after unclipping the belt, she could hardly move, because she was crammed atop the body of her great-grandmother. As Pasek and Skoloda carefully extricated the girl, they could tell that she had sustained serious injuries to her pelvis and to one arm. They placed her on a vacuum mattress beside the river and covered her with blankets and the firefighters' jackets.

They weren't equipped to check for internal bleeding and other major injuries, but Rachelle's vital signs seemed good. She told Skoloda that she had never lost consciousness. "It was shocking how clear she seemed," he said later. Rachelle explained that she had been on vacation with her father and her great-grandmother, and they had been returning to their home in New Mexico when her father had suddenly decided to stop and drive in reverse. Rachelle described in detail the way that the Honda had backed off the cliff, flipping multiple times.

On the highway, Mike Gibbs, a Ouray Mountain Rescue member, was figuring out how to get the girl out of the gorge. The hillside was too treacherous for anybody to carry a litter up it, and a helicopter couldn't descend in such a narrow airspace. Rachelle needed to be transported along

two axes: first, straight up, to a height that would clear the entire cliff. Then she would have to be moved horizontally to the roadway. The rescuers needed to construct something that functioned like a four-hundred-foot crane.

Gibbs runs a company called Rigging for Rescue. He has a large climbing wall and warehouse in Ouray, where he often hosts trainings. He also travels around the world to work with mountain-rescue teams, specialized military units, and others who need technical rope skills, including windmill installers, and bridge and skyscraper builders.

On the cliff, Gibbs decided that the best solution was to construct a complicated series of tensioned ropes known as a Kootenay Highline System with a Norwegian reeve. This consists of horizontal tag lines that transport a series of pulleys, which, after moving into the proper position, can descend straight down to receive a load. For more than twenty years, Gibbs had been teaching people how to build a Norwegian reeve, but he had never before used one for an actual rescue.

The first step was to find a large tree next to the highway that could serve as an anchor. Then, with a pair of binoculars, Gibbs spotted a similar tree on the opposite side of the gorge, four hundred feet away. One team member was a sharpshooter, and he aimed a line-throwing device that was shaped like a rifle. It used a .308 cartridge to fire a projectile connected to a monofilament line. Other climbers scrambled up the far side of the gorge and secured the line. The monofilament was slightly heavier than a fishing line, and it was strong enough to pull a light cord across the gorge. Then the cord dragged heavier lines that were capable of supporting large loads. The ropes moved across one by one, and every time somebody tied a knot, it had to be double-checked by another person, according to team protocol. It took about three hours to build the network of tensioned ropes.

Far below, Skoloda, Pasek, and another team member tried to keep Rachelle comfortable. Skoloda talked with her about family and school; she said that she liked reading and that the book on the cliffside had been a new one. She referred to the driver of the Honda as Dad, although later the rescuers learned that he was an uncle who had become the girl's legal guardian. Periodically, Rachelle asked whether her dad was alive. Skoloda and Pasek

had been careful to cover the bodies and keep them out of sight. Each time Rachelle inquired, Skoloda gently evaded the question. “You know, we’re just going to worry about you right now,” he said, and changed the subject. Finally, Rachelle stopped asking.

The month after the accident, Skoloda drove me to the site in his Dodge pickup, pointing out locations along the Million Dollar Highway. “This right here is where people will do it intentionally,” he said, passing the Ruby Walls, a section of cliffs that were purple-red in the afternoon light. “A few years ago, a woman committed suicide right here. She had a seat belt on. But she had a suicide note in her pocket. Her husband had shot and killed a police officer in Montrose. I think she was in a pretty hard spiral.”

People who die by suicide on the Million Dollar Highway often wear seat belts. Glenn Boyd, the county coroner, told me his theory is that they don’t want to be annoyed by a dinging sound in their final moments. Occasionally, the suicide seems to be spur of the moment; a depressed person sees a high section without a guardrail and goes over. Skoloda drove higher into the gorge, where every bend seemed to trigger a memory. “Just around this corner, we had a young man who was racing his vehicle and just totally misjudged a corner,” he said. “He survived the crash. He went a long, long ways down. I don’t know what happened to him after. Severe head trauma. Multiple-system trauma. Wasn’t much left of his vehicle. We do spend a lot of time up here.”

Skoloda parked at one of the few pullouts. Traffic was light, and we walked onto the road. Originally from Wisconsin, he is a tall man whose build has been shaped by decades of grabbing metal and rock: big hands, Popeye forearms. His wife, Nicole, has also volunteered with the rescue team, and they have two teen-age daughters. Other team members told me that they like having Skoloda interact with victims, because his calm air puts people at ease. Now he stopped at a series of white scrapes on the edge of the pavement. “This is the undercarriage marks from where they left the road,” he said. Just beyond the marks, the abyss fell away for hundreds of feet. We didn’t stand there long.

Skoloda loaned me a helmet and a harness, and we scrambled down a fixed rope to the Tyrolean traverse. We clipped in and swung across the river. The

water was mineral orange and flowing fast. “It feels wild in here,” Skoloda said, after we reached the other side. We clambered over some boulders; above us were a couple of gnarled limber pines, which are famously long-lived. Skoloda noted that they could be more than a thousand years old. He pointed at a dark tangle of trees across the gorge. “Right in there is a nineteen-eighties-era Subaru,” he said. “It’s got snow tires on it. It’s wrapped around a tree.”

Nowadays, crashed vehicles are removed promptly, in accordance with the law, but there are still some leftovers from when this wasn’t always the practice. Travellers sometimes spot them and call 911. One year, two rescue-team members hiked through the gorge with cans of orange spray paint, drawing a large “X” on every vehicle they found.

Skoloda climbed to a ledge directly above where the Honda had come to rest. “Here is a real good place to envision which way it fell,” he said.

He pointed across to the debris field, which was still scattered across the steep slope. Pieces of metal and plastic glistened in the sunlight; otherwise, there were no signs of civilization. The road wasn’t visible, and if any cars were passing by I couldn’t hear them over the river.

The San Juans are among the most impenetrable mountains in the West. Spanish explorers likely named the region after John the Baptist, because he wandered in the wilderness. Even in modern times, this quality has captured the imagination of outsiders. In the nineteen-fifties, the author Ayn Rand spent time in Ouray, during a move from Hollywood to New York City. Like Otto Mears, Rand was a Jewish Russian émigré with a distaste for organized labor, and she turned Ouray into a fictional location called Galt’s Gulch in her polemical 1957 novel, “Atlas Shrugged.” In the novel, the industrialist John Galt and other magnates have retreated to the hidden mountain town out of disgust with labor strikes and overregulation in a dystopian America. “We have no laws in this valley, no rules, no formal organization of any kind,” Galt proudly tells the novel’s heroine when she visits the alt-Ouray. “So I’ll warn you now that there is one word which is forbidden in this valley: the word ‘give.’ ” Above town, on a granite pillar, citizens have erected a three-foot-tall dollar sign of solid gold. The Million Dollar

Highway, however, was written out of Rand's fictional landscape, probably because she wanted Galt's Gulch to be as inaccessible as possible.

Self-reliance and personal responsibility have always been prominent local values. It's rare for residents to complain about the highway's lack of guardrails or other safety measures; the general idea is that you need to adjust your behavior according to the risks of weather and geography. Dack Klein, a lead worker for the Colorado Department of Transportation who lives in Ouray, pointed out that the vast majority of incidents on the road involve only one vehicle. "Most accidents are because the driver wasn't paying attention or did something wrong," he told me. Klein, who has a large tattoo of the words "We the People" on his arm, dismissed the idea of building guardrails. "A guardrail makes you feel warm and fuzzy, but there's not a lot of room up there for it," he said.

On the day the Honda went over, Klein was one of more than thirty people from various government agencies who worked on the scene. He was there from 8 *A.M.* until after midnight, and, like Skoloda and others, he had many stories connected to specific parts of the road. Matt Hepp, an engineer and a climber who volunteers with Ouray Mountain Rescue, created a reference map that notes mile markers and some of the most notorious sections. Tuffy's Corner, named for a local undertaker, is a frequent accident site, and Harley Corner is a reducing-radius turn that sometimes catches motorcyclists off guard. Part of the problem with Harley Corner is that bikers start the curve in front of a spectacular mountain backdrop. "They come around the turn, they look at the view, and then the radius hits them," Hepp told me. "And the pegs catch and they go right over." The drop-off there is only about forty feet, and bikers usually survive with non-catastrophic injuries. They tend to land in the same spot, as if the road were engineered to deposit them there. "We had a joke that we should drag a queen-size mattress over there," Hepp said. Despite the repeated accidents, nobody has erected a motorcycle-specific warning sign on the road.

Another section is known as Miracle Gully. In February, 2005, a man named Joe Sullivan was returning home to Montrose, a town north of Ridgway, after watching his daughter play in a high-school basketball game on the other side of the San Juans. Sullivan was driving a Pontiac Montana minivan carrying his wife, son, and daughter, along with one of his daughter's

teammates and her father. By the time they crossed the eleven-thousand-foot pass on Red Mountain, it was snowing. On the steep descent, Sullivan slowed to ten miles per hour. As he approached a sharp curve on one of the high cliffs, the vehicle lost all traction. A high-school wrestling match was playing on the radio. The car was moving so slowly that everybody had plenty of time to see what was happening. The last thing that Sullivan said, in a voice that was surprisingly calm, was “I’m sorry, we’re going off.”

The minivan tumbled off the cliff and rolled multiple times, falling more than four hundred feet. When it came to a halt, Sullivan found himself alive, with snow inside the car up to his chest. The only person who needed medical attention was his wife, who later received a few staples on the back of her head. Everybody else walked out of the gorge under their own power, following a rope line that had been set up by Ouray Mountain Rescue. Initially, when the rescue team fielded the call, they worried that they didn’t have enough body bags in stock.

The following week, Katie Couric interviewed the Sullivans for the “Today” show. In the years since, two other vehicles have gone off at the same spot, and, each time, everybody has survived with minor injuries. Once, a driver went over in a box truck loaded with Toyota parts, flipped multiple times, fell a total of four hundred feet, and walked away with a broken pinkie. These accidents have always occurred in winter, and Skoloda told me that Miracle Gully is shaped in such a way that it cushions the descent in heavy snow. When the Sullivans crashed, their Pontiac’s airbags never even deployed.

Sullivan was cited for unsafe mountain driving, and he travelled twice to the Ouray courthouse in order to fight the charge. The second time, he was joined by the state highway patrolman who had issued the ticket and by a Catholic priest who had been on the road that night and testified that conditions had been treacherous. The judge retreated to his chambers after telling the three of them to work it out. With the priest officiating, the patrolman offered a reduced charge of unsafe tires, which Sullivan accepted. He paid a fifteen-dollar fine, but no points were added to his license. When we met recently, at his home in Montrose, he said that fighting the ticket had been important to him back then because he’d come so close to having his

family destroyed. “You have an accident like that, you don’t want to be guilty,” he told me.

His son, Tyrel, who was seventeen at the time, had been sitting directly behind his father in the Pontiac. Today, Tyrel is a thirty-eight-year-old architect in Montrose, with a young family of his own. He told me that he couldn’t remember the last time he had driven the Million Dollar Highway, and his wife refused to travel on it. For many years after the accident, Tyrel had nightmares. But these dreams never involved falling or crashing. Instead, it was always the same scenario: something unexpected had come up, and now Tyrel had no choice but to drive past Ouray. It was a San Juan version of the exam-anxiety dream, with the Million Dollar Highway representing a test that he wasn’t prepared to take.

After the rescue team had constructed the highline ropes with the Norwegian reeve, Pasek ascended it with Rachelle. The girl was strapped into a litter, which was roped into the reeve’s pulleys. The pulleys allowed for a load to be lifted with less force, and the pace of ascent was controlled by a capstan, a motorized drum that pulled in rope from the road. It took about ten minutes to raise Pasek and Rachelle more than three hundred vertical feet. To keep her calm, Pasek described what they were doing, step by step. It had been five and a half hours since the Honda went off the road, but the child remained lucid. Partway through the ascent, she asked, “Is there a chance we could fall?”

“No,” Pasek said.

At the top, he clipped into a carriage that connected to the horizontal track rope, and they traversed the hundred and fifty feet to the road. Everything worked flawlessly; the carriage deposited them onto the highway. An ambulance rushed Rachelle to a helicopter that was waiting to transport her to Children’s Hospital Colorado, in Colorado Springs. While strapping Rachelle into the litter, Pasek had tucked in the children’s book that he had found in the dirt.

For the next hour and a half, the system transported the five rescue workers and the two bodies that were still at the bottom of the gorge. When I talked with the rescuers, they all described a similar experience. Initially, there was

a thrill at being lifted by the ropes, but then, as they floated above the site, they felt a wave of sadness. “The way my mind works, the rigging was so cool,” a fireman named Tom Fedel told me. “To see how it was put together, and to see what they had accomplished.” But then he looked down at the debris field. “Her little sweatshirts, you could tell it was kid’s clothes,” he said. “A suitcase split open. A lot of papers. Just people’s things—they’re nothing now. They’re just stuff on the side of the mountain.”

Later that month, the coroner released details from the Honda driver’s autopsy report. His blood had contained a hundred and ninety-five nanograms of THC per millilitre, which is thirty-nine times the legal threshold for a driver in Colorado.

Skoloda had ridden the ropes out of the gorge with a Ouray Mountain Rescue volunteer named Annie Quatham. As they approached the top, he told her, “I’m getting a little sick of this.” Jenny Hart, who had volunteered since the late nineteen-nineties, told me that the Honda wreck made her think about retiring. “I’m carrying twenty-eight years of scars,” she said. “That rescue put an exclamation point on it for me. Because I’m a teacher, and kids are different for me.”

The group, which has an annual budget of about fifty thousand dollars, is funded primarily by donations. Local support is impressive, as described in “No Individual Heroes,” a history of the rescue team. After somebody works on a traumatic incident, that member is contacted by a mental-health professional at intervals: three days later, then three weeks, then three months. Retired volunteers told me that you never know what might push you past the limit. Glenn Boyd, the coroner, grew up in Ouray. His stepfather was an E.M.T., whose moment came when he worked an accident and found two empty baby seats. The driver was unconscious; Boyd’s stepfather and his crew scoured the site desperately. It turned out that the man had been transporting the seats without any children, but the experience pushed Boyd’s stepfather to retire. “Just the trauma of searching and searching for kids was the final straw,” Boyd told me.

Two weeks after the Honda accident, a sixty-five-year-old woman intentionally drove her motorcycle off the Million Dollar Highway. This seemed to have been a decision she made on the road: there was no suicide

note, and the coroner told me he believed that the woman had not intended to kill herself when she left home that day. Another motorist saw her speed off a cliff without trying to turn or stop, and she wasn't wearing a helmet. She was still alive when Skoloda and others arrived at the scene. She died while they were transporting her in a litter.

A little more than a month later, the driver of a Ford F-150 reached down for a Bluetooth speaker, taking his eyes off the road. The truck rolled one and a half times and fell two hundred and thirty feet; the driver was fortunate to survive with minor injuries. It had been a bad stretch for the rescue team, but the Ford accident turned out to be the year's last drive-off.

Each winter, for the people who work and travel on the Million Dollar Highway, the primary worry shifts to avalanches. There are three highway forecasters who are stationed along an eighty-mile segment of 550: one in Ridgway, another in Silverton, and the third in Durango. They are posted so close together in part because the terrain makes for complicated weather; this stretch of highway crosses three passes of more than ten thousand feet. The forecasters are employed by the Colorado Avalanche Information Center, which is part of the state's Department of Natural Resources. The Ridgway forecaster is named Troy Nordquist, and in mid-February I accompanied him on his early-morning rounds.



It had started snowing the previous day, and it was still coming down softly. Nordquist stopped at a series of platforms that tracked the snow's height. He carried a device that measured the amount of water in the snow, and he also relied on reading the landscape. "You can look at a slope and see if it's been wind-sculpted," he told me. "I'm looking to see if it's loading from a fetch into a start zone. A fetch is the back side of a hill. A fetch is usually where snow is coming from. A lot of times, you can see big plumes coming off a peak."

We passed a slide known as Jackpot, and then we came to Mother Cline. This avalanche path had been named for the wife of a mine supervisor from the late nineteenth century. Some other avalanches are named for victims or public figures. One of the most satisfying slide names is Slippery Jim, in honor of a local politician.

A snowplow driver stopped on the road to ask Nordquist a question: "Are they going to be shooting today? They were talking about it yesterday."

"Blue Point kind of had a natural runoff yesterday," Nordquist said, referring to a slide farther up the highway. "And the sun is supposed to pop out. So we are waiting."

Along the road, red-and-white-checked signs mark where the Department of Transportation can set up howitzers. These guns have a range of about seven miles, and they can be shot at the upper reaches of avalanches to make them run. The Department of Transportation will close the highway, fire a howitzer, clear the snow off the road, and then reopen it. Three guns are kept in towns along Highway 550, and all of them are old; Ouray's howitzer dates to 1954. Colorado has started to transition to fixed systems, one of which ignites a gas mixture that explodes and triggers a slide. Two of these devices have already been installed near Red Mountain Pass.

Between Ouray and Red Mountain, there is a roadside memorial to snowplow drivers who have died in avalanches. Jobs that force people to travel in winter have always been dangerous; in the old days, mailman was a high-risk profession. In December, 1883, a Silverton-based carrier disappeared in a slide and wasn't found until his body melted out, two and a

half years later. His mailbag was still full of letters, which were then delivered.

The Silverton cemetery contains the remains of more than a hundred avalanche victims. There are also many graves of people who died during the 1918 flu pandemic, which killed nearly one in ten Silverton residents. The cemetery sprawls across a rugged, beautiful hillside above town, and its tombstones may be the most efficient reading list for anybody hoping to understand what life was like in the high country during the old days:

THOMAS BRENNAN

1852—Feb. 2. 1883

KILLED WITH 10 MULES

SNOWSLIDE

YANKEE GIRL MINE TRAIL

Edward Mesch

Died July 4, 1905

Shot by Unknown Party

MAY RICKARD

1899

ONE OF BLAIR STREET'S

"UNFORTUNATE GIRLS"

DIED OF ALCOHOLISM/MORPHINE

IN THE CABIN OF MOLLIE FOLEY

"HAPPY JACK" SHAEFFER

1844—JUNE 28, 1906

BLOWN TO ATOMS IN A MINE

In modern times, the landscape has continued to claim victims. From 1950 to 1991, fifty-eight vehicles were caught by avalanches below Red Mountain Pass, more than five times the figure for any other mountain highway in Colorado. The most notorious slide, East Riverside, killed five people in fifteen years, including two snowplow drivers in the nineteen-seventies. In 1985, after many delays, the state government finally built a concrete snowshed above the road at East Riverside. But budget shortfalls meant that

the shed was only a hundred and eighty feet long, less than a sixth of the proposed distance. The plan was to add extensions to each end of the structure after more funding became available.



On March 5, 1992, two drivers were trying to move a plow that was just beyond the shed's protection when East Riverside ran. Three other highway workers and a motorist stood beneath the concrete cover, and they saw the avalanche sweep the men and the plow off the road. The workers used their emergency radio to call for help. But the snow was still falling hard, and rescue personnel decided that they couldn't safely search for the buried men. It took eight hours to evacuate the people who had sheltered beneath the snowshed.

In fact, both drivers had survived the avalanche. They were buried deep inside a cavity that had formed around the vehicle. One driver, Eddie Imel, had a pair of pliers; his partner, Danny Jaramillo, had a flashlight. They tried to use these tools to dig out, without success. After nearly fifteen hours, Imel died of hypothermia. At that point, Jaramillo scraped his way to the hood of the buried plow, where he kicked out the front window. He found a Kmart shovel and was able to tunnel up through at least ten feet of hard-packed snow and ice.

Jaramillo used the snowshed's emergency phone to call the state-patrol dispatch in Montrose. He asked them to come as quickly as possible, and he also asked them to bring a dry pack of cigarettes. When rescuers arrived, they dug out Imel's body. He had a wife and three young daughters in Ouray.

Imel is one of the drivers honored on a plaque beside the highway: "This memorial is dedicated to those who have given the supreme sacrifice in the maintenance of Red Mountain Pass. The lonely vigil of the night is known only to these men of courage." Jaramillo was reportedly so traumatized that he eventually quit the job and left town. In the wake of the tragedy, more than sixteen hundred citizens signed a petition asking for better protection on the road, and Ouray's newspaper, the *Plaindealer*, ran an editorial that said, "Our state reneged on its promise to build a 1,200-foot-long shed." In the years since, Colorado has vastly improved its forecasting, and there hasn't been another avalanche death on Highway 550. But the snowshed was never extended, and there are currently no plans to do so.

Recently, I spoke by phone with Manuel Genswein, a Swiss engineer and avalanche expert who gives safety trainings around the world. He's travelled many times to Ouray, Silverton, and surrounding towns, and he told me that he's amazed that people accept the risks of the Million Dollar Highway. He believes that the road should be reengineered with better rockfall mitigation, along with a surface that has proper width and guardrails. I mentioned the need to plow snow, and he laughed: "If you have an avalanche running onto the road, isn't that the problem?" He explained that in Switzerland roads with a high slide risk would be protected by a tunnel or a roofed gallery. He also noted that better engineering would allow drivers to move faster, which would be safer. In parts of Europe with a danger of rockfall or avalanche, there are often minimum speed limits rather than maximums.

Julie Constan, the southwest regional transportation director of the Colorado Department of Transportation, told me that the annual budget for southwestern Colorado was about a hundred million dollars, and she said that it would be prohibitively expensive to widen the highway to the point where guardrails could be installed. "It would be thirty to fifty million, at a minimum," she said. "Probably for a mile or so."

The initial anger over the snowshed's length seems to have passed long ago, and nowadays it's rare for anybody to complain. "We're not hearing from the locals," Constan told me, when I asked if there was any outcry about the highway.

Genswein contrasted it with the Swiss experience. After a disastrous avalanche season in 1950 and 1951, which became known as the "Winter of Terror," Switzerland decided to improve its road safety, regardless of cost. Genswein found it remarkable that, even after a Colorado public-works employee had been killed just beyond the snowshed, it had never been lengthened.

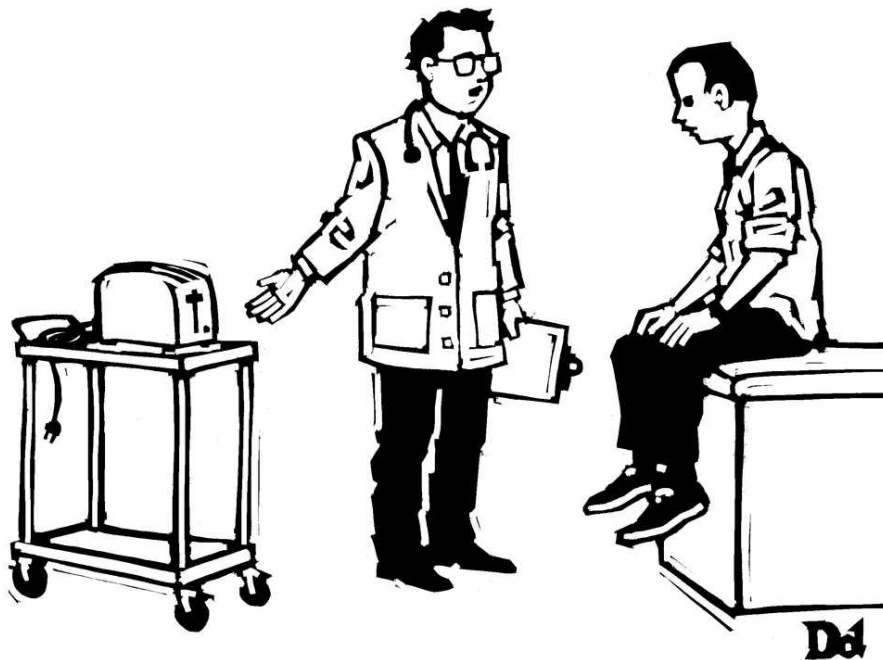
I asked Genswein what might be the reason for the different approach in Colorado, and he mentioned traditions of individualism and opportunism in the American West. "You try to look out for yourself," he said. I saw his point, but there was also a great deal of generosity by community members who risked their lives helping people along the road. The rescues involved a remarkable degree of ingenuity, and it seemed that similar energy could be directed toward finding ways to keep drivers from going off the road in the first place. But there wasn't any evidence that this was happening. As a local, I believed that the natural environment of the San Juans was so powerful that people were inclined toward acceptance. Once, I asked Skoloda whether he would like to see anything about the highway changed. "It's an inherently dangerous place and an inherently beautiful place," he said. "Changes have their ups and downs. Maybe educating people about what to do up there would be the easiest thing."

In July, I drove south on the Million Dollar Highway. I crossed the trio of high mountain passes, and then I continued on 550 past Durango to Bloomfield, New Mexico, where Rachelle lives. In the accident, she badly fractured her pelvis and broke her arm, and sustained a concussion. But she recovered quickly, leaving the hospital after two weeks. Within a month, she had started to walk on her own.

When I visited, she had just completed sixth grade. She was living with her aunt Ivy Martinez and her family; Martinez's husband, Jesse, worked in nearby oil fields, and they had two young sons. The family lived in a small house on a quiet street not far from Bloomfield's downtown. Rachelle sat on

a couch in the living room, holding a stuffed alligator and wearing a pink T-shirt with large print: “*God Got Me.*” She talked about her interest in reading; her aunt had recently given her the “Twilight” series and C. S. Lewis’s books about Narnia. Rachelle said that she still had the book that Pasek had found near the Honda.

There was no change in the girl’s demeanor when she talked about the accident. She never became emotional, and she told the story with a high level of detail. She explained that her father had stopped on the road after seeing a cave beside the Million Dollar Highway. He wanted to go back and take a picture, so he put the car in reverse. “We hit a bump,” Rachelle recollected. “That was half of the car going off the cliff. Me and my grandma were in the back. And my dad was, like, ‘Uh-oh,’ and he was trying to get us back on the road. But it didn’t work. We flipped once. That was the only time I heard my grandma scream.”



Rachelle said that there had been a moment when the car teetered on the edge, and she looked out the back window and saw the cliffs on the far side of the gorge. She remembered flipping four times. After the first one, her grandmother went silent.

Rachelle also recalled vividly the experience of being trapped inside the vehicle in the river. But she had no specific recollections of Skoloda, Pasek, or any other rescue worker; they seemed to be blurred in her mind. She had little to say about riding the rigging system to the top of the gorge. Unlike the others, she didn't describe the ropes or the way the scene looked from above. Her one clear memory was that, as the litter approached the highway, she heard somebody on the side of the road say that they needed to load two body bags for the rigging system's return trip. That was when Rachelle knew for certain that her father was dead.

In New Mexico, I spoke with a few of Rachelle's family members, and they explained that she had grown up with significant family complications. Her biological father had been an inconsistent presence, and her mother was incarcerated. Her uncle Louis—a great-uncle, technically—had become her legal guardian, and he was estranged from other family members. He had not told anybody about the trip to Colorado. If Adam Hynes, the tourist from Oregon, had not seen the Honda reversing, it's likely that the car would not have been discovered for a long time.

Family members told me that Leoba Valdez, the great-grandmother whom Rachelle called Grandma, had held everybody together during hard times. After her death, the family rallied around Rachelle's recovery. Martinez and Jesse became her legal guardians, and Martinez communicated every day with Rachelle's mother, Maddison, who is still in prison. Maddison stays in close touch with her daughter, and another aunt, Jessica Valdez, also provides significant support. Valdez commented that Louis had used marijuana so regularly that the autopsy results didn't surprise her. "I would say it was a normal state," she said.

In Ouray, the results had been reported on the front page of the *Plaindealer*, and when people in town talked about the accident they usually referred to the driver's drug use. But the detail about the cave had not appeared in the police report, because Rachelle had not been interviewed directly by investigators after she was evacuated. The previous year, when I visited the site with Skoloda, we had noticed an open adit, an old mine passage that looked like a cave, immediately next to the road. Neither of us had known that the adit had played a role in the accident, but Skoloda had commented

on it. “I’m surprised they haven’t closed that one off,” he said. “You see people messing with them all the time.”

After hearing Rachelle’s story, I realized that there were different ways to perceive the accident. One was to note that a habitual marijuana user had made some disastrous driving decisions. But it was also possible to say that on a narrow road with a sheer drop, a high risk of rockfall, and no guardrails, the authorities had failed to cover a mine passage in a location that could tempt drivers to stop.

Less than a month before my trip to New Mexico, I had attended one of the Ouray Mountain Rescue Team’s regular trainings. On that day, Skoloda, Pasek, and others had diligently practiced constructing the Norwegian reeve, along with other rigging arrangements. I mentioned it to Rachelle and her family, and they asked me to convey their gratitude. Some of them wanted to travel to the accident site, as a way of finding closure. But Rachelle and Martinez were opposed. When Rachelle had come home from the hospital in Colorado Springs, she had insisted that her aunt find a route without high mountain passes.

After the accident, Rachelle had received therapy for months. She was about to start seventh grade at a new school, and she was excited to have made the cheer squad. They were practicing four days a week. “I’m a flyer, so I have to stay tight,” Rachelle told me. She explained that the flyer is the team member who gets thrown into the air, and Rachelle had been chosen because she is small. I asked her if it was ever scary. She smiled and said, “Sometimes.” ♦



Shouts & Murmurs

- [Cookie Monster Tries to Meet His A.I. Mandate](#)

Shouts & Murmurs

Cookie Monster Tries to Meet His A.I. Mandate

By Ysabel Yates

September 28, 2026



Me resident cookie expert on Sesame Street, so me responsible for telling everyone about cookie—how to eat cookie, how to make cookie, and, most important, how to slow down and enjoy cookie. But then me get new boss, Matt.

Matt here to “implement technological solutions that improve productivity.” Me don’t understand. So me ask Big Bird for translation. Big Bird say this mean Cookie Monster has to use A.I. for cookie work now.

Me confused. Me know cookie inside and out! Me never get complaint about cookie duties before. Now me not enough? Me spiral.

So me talk to Elmo. Elmo say not to worry because me cookie experience still very valuable. Elmo also remind Cookie Monster that me always have

good cookie idea, like making chocolate cookie, or coconut cookie, or oatmeal cookie, or tiny cookie, or macaroon. Wow! Me making me hungry. Me feel better now.

Next day, me record episode of weekly cooking show with Grover. In episode, me eat VERY BIG cookie. Everyone laugh. Me proud!

Then Matt ask why me not using A.I. to write script for cooking show. Matt say A.I. smarter and faster than Cookie Monster. Me explain that me already cookie expert, and me always done good job of bringing joy of cookies to everybody. But Matt say that if me no use A.I., me fired. Me panic!

So, me try it. Me tell A.I.: “Write about cookies.”

“When it comes to cookies, it’s not about the taste—it’s about the experience.”

What this mean? Taste of cookie very important to cookie experience. Me frustrated. Why Matt say robot would be good at cookie?

But me try again. This time, me tell A.I.: “Write about cookies passionately!”

“Some people only eat cookies on the weekends. I eat cookies all day long. Because the cookie grind never stops. Agree?”

Me horrified. Me have unique voice. And now me sound like not me. Now me sound like Matt on LinkedIn.

Me sad after doing this, so me eat cookie in bed.

Next morning, me tell Matt that A.I. not good at cookies. Matt say that not true. He say me need better “A.I. skills.”

Me not sure about that. But me do need job. Me dream of free cookie for everyone! Just a dream, though. Me still have to pay for everything. Cookies. Doctor. Everything.

So me take online course. Me even subscribe to e-mail newsletter, so me can get free e-book called “50 A.I. Prompts to Succeed in Modern Business.” But now me even more confused about “skills” part. Is me missing something?

Me need to prompt A.I. Me get that part. For example, me told A.I.: “Give me yummy cookie recipe!” But recipe me got was not yummy. A.I. say to set oven to 475 degrees. That’s way too hot for cookies!

“You’re right for calling that out. That’s way too hot for cookies.”

Me know! So now me spend more time fixing cookie recipe. How this make Cookie Monster more productive? This only make Cookie Monster more sad.

Later that day, Matt invite whole team to town hall about “exciting A.I. revolution.” Me surprised during Q. & A. to hear Oscar say, “You’re not just a boss—you’re a visionary!” Oscar supposed to be grouch. Now he suck-up.

Afterward, me try to log in to laptop. But me locked out! Turns out, me fired along with whole team. Except Oscar, who is new “Vice President of A.I. Integration.” Me check LinkedIn and see that Oscar change bio to “Prompt Engineer & AI Optimist.” Then me puke.

Me sometimes think me went all in on wrong thing. Instead of cookie, maybe me should’ve studied business management, like Matt. Me would still have job. But then me would have to fire everyone. And me would never do that. Because me Cookie Monster, not actual monster. ♦

Fiction

- [Narrow Escape](#)
- [Your Guide to Navigating the Parent Group Chat](#)

Fiction

Narrow Escape

By Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn

September 27, 2026



In 1948, Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn, who was then twenty-nine and incarcerated in a Soviet facility—serving an eight-year sentence for having criticized Joseph Stalin in his private correspondence—began writing an autobiographical novel titled “Love the Revolution.” The novel, which was never completed, was published in Russia in 1999, and will come out in English for the first time later this year. This passage, adapted from the first chapter of the novel, is set in Rostov-on-Don, in the summer of 1941.

It happened like this. The availability of bread was in a phase of so-called temporary difficulties. There was a crush of many hundreds outside the bread shops. The limit was two kilos per person, and no ration cards had been instituted yet. The family of Gleb Nerzhin’s wife, Nadya, had gone three days without bread, but Gleb had grown up during the first Five-Year Plan and had mastered the art of waiting in line or in a milling crowd, of sprinting and scrounging, so he volunteered to scrounge. This entailed standing in the gateway of one’s housing block while it was still night and

waiting for the dawn to break. In every gateway all along the street, similar groups were lining up for the start, casting sidelong glances at one another but not making a run for the bread shop until it was time: after all, for security reasons, no one was allowed out in the streets at night, except for night patrols and policemen. But just as electric charges gradually build up in lead-colored thunderclouds until at last the intolerable difference in potential gives violent birth to lightning, so, too—without any word of command, without a sign or prior agreement, without conscious intent, not even at the moment when dawn became perceptible—somebody stirred, someone else swayed, a third one took a step, and, from every gateway, the crowd surged toward the bread shop, merging into an avalanche. Not every war could boast of attacks like this, with no one needing to be urged on, everyone rushing forward, selflessly giving their all. On reaching the bread shop, this throng was supposed to stretch itself out into a single file, but, writhing noisily, it simply could not manage to do so, since every participant claimed to have arrived before the others. Gleb was in the midst of this seething mass. He had secured one of the first places, next to the wall, and clung with one hand to a projecting brick by the entryway, so that he was neither shoving nor making a din but patiently waiting for the bread delivery in two hours' time and the shop's opening in three.

Despite that fact, the policeman who arrived to restore order did not touch those who were pushing and shoving, or even those who were brawling, but picked on none other than Gleb, who stood out, with his lean and haughty, bookish air, among all the barefoot boys, cantankerous grannies, girls, and raucous women. The policeman beckoned to him. Gleb gave a look of surprise. The man then summoned him out loud, calling him "white shirt." Gleb didn't move. The policeman began to push aside the crowd, which had quietened down. Gleb stepped forward to meet him, asking what this was all about. The man demanded that Gleb follow him to the police precinct. Gleb made a perfunctory protest but gave in, to avoid creating a scene and being made to look ridiculous. And so they set off.

The precinct was some four long city blocks distant. At first, Gleb felt nothing but irritation at losing his place in the queue; he'd done so well to get it, and it had cost him two hours of sleep. Then, after walking for a couple of blocks, directing withering sneers at the policeman's reddish face, which was as impassive as that of a stone idol, Gleb cooled down and

succumbed to boredom. There was nothing remarkable in any of this; he would be released on the spot at the precinct, but it would be stupid to run into one of his acquaintances in such company.

[Read an interview with the author's son for the story behind the story.](#)

Inside the precinct, there were two men at the desk. The stone idol made his report: “Comrade Lieutenant, this man was inciting panic.”

Gleb began to reply in a rapid, agitated voice. “Listen, Comrade Lieutenant, this is absolute nonsense. I was standing there perfectly peacefully. I wasn’t causing any disturb—”

“You . . . just hold on,” the lieutenant said, squinting at him coldly. “Sit.” And, raising his voice: “Sit over there, farther down!”

“Excuse me, why should I sit? I need to be going!”

“Sit down, I tell you.”

Did no one understand Russian here? Gleb shrugged, sat down on a bench, and began to examine the official furnishings of the duty room with studied inattention: the red calico tablecloth with a big ink stain, the cloudy water jug with a broken-off spout, the filing cabinet whose warped door no longer closed properly, the stacks of files inside it, the duty officer’s fountain pen, which was spattering as he wrote.

Gleb hadn’t waited fifteen minutes when two more policemen came in with another couple of detainees, registering them under the same charges:

—panic-mongering;

—rumor-spreading.

Had Gleb not been a twenty-three-year-old greenhorn philosopher, he would have understood everything by now: that, two days earlier, Stalin had given his incoherent radio speech addressing his “brothers and sisters,” almost adding “in Christ,” which was punctuated by intervals of heavy breathing and the sound of gurgling water; that the new catchwords “panic-mongers”

and “rumor-spreaders” had been seized upon; that a corresponding Decree had been promulgated; and that this entailed hunting down the perpetrators, so that yesterday the police had been briefed at a meeting, and today, from first light, they’d been out on their manhunt, making sure that the number of detained suspects listed in their daily reports demonstrated their vigilance and justified their existence. But Gleb’s understanding of things was too complicated for him to be able to grasp anything as plain as that.

Twice more he protested his detention, then at last the man on duty called him forward, noted down his name and address, and released him, promising that he’d be summoned again. At this Gleb merely smiled ironically. It was clear to him, as he emerged from the duty room, with its lingering smell of tobacco smoke, into a fresh and verdant July morning: having found nothing incriminating, they were releasing him for good.

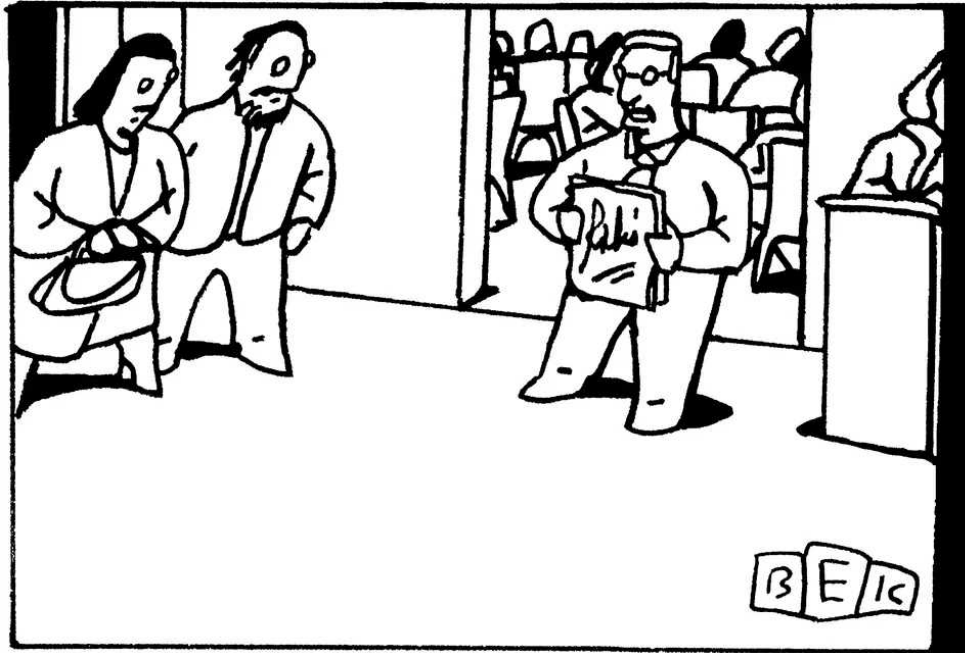
But a day later a smudged violet-ink summons was delivered to his address, stating the time that he was to appear before the investigating officer. This was now so stupid that it wasn’t funny anymore. Gleb could hardly wait for the appointed time, reached the precinct almost at a run, and entered the office, vigorously flicking back his unruly hair—it was time to rid himself of this trivial nonsense, which was clinging to him like a leech. He began impetuously rattling off his incontrovertible arguments, but the junior lieutenant with slicked-down hair who sat at the desk pointed to a chair some way off and busied himself with putting a new nib in his pen, retrieving some bloated scraps from the bottom of his inkwell, and pouring in fresh ink. He then began leafing through his papers. But what papers could there possibly be in a case like this?

Gleb’s ardor waned as the minutes passed and he ran out of words to say. Distractedly, he watched as each successive page was turned. After going through two file folders, the investigating officer took out a clean interrogation-record form and, for some reason, examined it against the light, then unhurriedly began to ask his questions: surname, given name, patronymic, date of birth, occupation, home address. To Gleb, it was grotesque that the officer didn’t seem to make the slightest effort to establish the truth but was solely preoccupied with filling out each line as evenly and elegantly as possible—and this in such tempestuous hours, when million-strong armies were clashing in the west, motorized divisions were racing

through breaches in the front at a hundred kilometres per hour, whereas, here, there was only the ticking of the clock on the wall and the occasional scratching of an illiterate pen, which, moreover, was investigating a meaningless, insignificant incident. The police lieutenant appeared to be writing down exactly what Gleb was telling him, but relying upon completely different words, with the result that Gleb confirmed the fact of his participation in organizing a queue for bread at 4 *a.m.* outside such-and-such bread shop, where he had been detained by a guardian of the law, who had duly escorted him to the precinct. All this was set out in question-and-answer form, without appropriate syntax but with ornate flourishes; was certified at the end by Gleb's signature; and, together with a copy of Article 206 attesting to the termination of the investigation, was entered into the file, to which the testimony of the policeman involved in the incident had already been attached.

Gleb tried to arrange a meeting with the precinct chief, but this proved impossible, and he emerged onto the street with a depressing sensation that he'd fallen victim to a stupid joke, one that was decidedly unamusing. It was all nothing! Hot air! A scrap of paper! It shouldn't have any consequences at all, yet it had left an unpleasant taint that soured his mood.

It so happened that Gleb's wife, Nadya, had promised Ella Dovner, one of Gleb's old school friends, a gentle, clever girl with large circular-framed glasses, that they'd come and visit her that evening. Everyone had disbanded and scattered so swiftly that they were the only two of Ella's large circle of friends who could come for the evening, sharing with her the now burdensome luxury of the living room, with its grand piano, plush armchairs, mirrors, and carpets (but no radio receiver, since these had been universally banned in June). The friends tried to guess what the murky future held in store and grieved softly over the past, which was so dear, as they sat, in the gathering dusk, out on the balcony above the main street of the city.



Beautiful Bolshaya Sadovaya, long since renamed Engels Street, ran straight as an arrow and was a clean, tree-lined, and gaudily populous boulevard, freed now from clattering streetcars, the only sounds being the soft swish of automobile and trolleybus tires, and the shuffling of pedestrians' feet. This, Rostov's main thoroughfare, wasn't illuminated by the familiar bright glare of its many street lamps, or by light from its windows, now blacked out, but emerged from the darkness all the more gently in a milky cloak of moonlight. Beneath the balcony, this street, witness to and confidante of the entire twenty-three years of these young people's lives, was languishing in the fragrant July night, densely thronged with strolling city dwellers even now. The abundance of typically Southern white suits bathed in white moonlight, the leisurely movement of the pedestrian groups, with no one attempting to overtake or jostle others, even the blue lamps at the kiosks selling ice cream and soda water—all this was so festive, so peaceful, so remote from the war that it made one want to pretend for this one evening that there *was* no war, that its jagged shrapnel had not sliced into the tender body of life, that one could still dream of a future, still sit listening to concerts. . . . But no! Even here in the Dovners' affluent apartment, there was no pretending. Ella's father himself was due to leave in the next day or two, destined—even he—for the front. From the balcony, the young people could see his car pull up outside.

Dr. Dovner was over forty, and, though he played an important role in the official side of life, he was inwardly quite contemptuous of it, always preferring the practical, material side—that is, things as they really were, and not the way people strove to depict them. This had brought him great success in life. A corpulent, agile man with ruddy cheeks, full of *joie de vivre*, he easily distinguished worthy individuals from feckless ones, achievers from windbags, and well knew that what was actually done differed greatly from how it was portrayed in writing. He readily entered mutual arrangements of the “You scratch our back, we’ll scratch yours” type, and took timely shelter under the wing of the omnipotent Party: and so, by the spring of 1941, he had become one of Rostov’s most notable personalities—the deputy head of the oblast health department, the director of its biggest clinic, a member of both the oblast and municipal soviets of workers’ deputies—proof of his remarkable skill at combining the functions of doctor, medical administrator, and devoted Communist.

Dovner had only a sketchy idea of who Gleb was, but had noticed him as one of the regulars at the young people’s table when dinners were held in the apartment. And he recognized him now when he came out onto the balcony with the intent of spending some time with his daughter. But Ella, who combined a generous, compassionate heart with an utter lack of understanding of real life, despite the fact that—or perhaps precisely because—she was studying for a post-graduate degree in literature, voiced a complaint to him as he approached, while twirling a flower around her little nose: “Papa! Gleb here didn’t do anything, but they’re summoning him for an investigation, putting together a report. . . .”

Gleb was embarrassed at being made to look like a suppliant. But, when Dovner questioned him lightly about the details, the man’s infectious laughter made Gleb even more convinced that such trifles were hardly worth mentioning at all. They sat on the balcony for a while, chatting, then the doctor called Gleb into the room, without the girls.

Dovner was every inch the civilian, and it was odd to see him already in uniform. The tailor had had his work cut out fitting the soft woollen battle-dress blouse to Dovner’s unathletic and paunchy frame. The broad officer’s belt was buckled on one of the first holes. But, for all that, he cut a rather gallant figure, with three bars gleaming red on the collar tabs on either side

of his sturdy neck, and he looked not like a victim of the tumult of war but like a man pleased with a change of occupation and form of dress. He was off to take up command of a field hospital.

In this final day or two before his departure, when Dovner was already free of the cares and concerns of life out of the war zone but not yet burdened with those of the front, his experienced eye was able to grasp the significance of Gleb's case immediately: "Do you realize what this could mean? Ten years in the camps."

There is a point beyond which the scale of a threat or a danger ceases to scare us. We might take fright when faced with a bandit drawing his knife, but if he shouts, "I'll smite you with a hundred lightning bolts," we'd barely flinch. "Five months" would have frightened Gleb more than "ten years." But Papa Dovner wasn't joking. He lowered himself languidly onto the couch, like a performer after too many encores, and with eyes half closed, said, "Children, children, what *do* they teach you at university?"—then nodded toward the telephone directory. "Look up the precinct you were at. The chief's office."

"Now? But it's evening," Gleb demurred uncertainly.

"They work nights, it goes with the job," Dovner said, narrowing his eyes. "Just look it up."

"Do you really know him, too?" Gleb asked, hastily leafing through the directory.

"Easier to ask me whom I *don't* know. All the commanding heights must be in the hands of the proletariat. I could order you a plane right now to fly you to the Far East. I could put you in charge of a restaurant. Or reserve a prenatal bed in a sanatorium for pregnant women—would you like that? What's that number? Zero-five-three-eight-four?"

The magisterial way he dialled, still slouched back on the sofa, using one chubby white finger, never turning the dial all the way around but just far enough for each number to register, all while holding the receiver in the

same hand—even minutiae such as these bespoke a man who held the commanding heights in this city of half a million inhabitants.

“Hello? Am I speaking to the Fourth Department? Captain Maksimov? Doctor Dovner here. . . . Hello, there. . . . How’s it going? Me, too. . . . And what little matter would that be? That’s fine, we’ll run it through the Medical Assessment Board. Send it along, and I’ll alert the Deputy Head. . . . Me? I’m off to the front. . . . Listen, I’ve got something to ask you, too. Write this surname down . . . ‘Nerzhin’ . . . that’s ‘N’ for ‘November,’ ‘E’ for ‘Echo,’ ‘R’ for ‘Rubbish,’ ‘Zh’— Yes, that’s it. Have you made a note of it? Your boys over there have cooked up a case against him, but it’s just a mistake. . . . Well, all right. . . . Fine, you can call later. . . . Oh, you can check now? Good, go ahead.”

Toying with the receiver not far from his ear, Dovner looked at Gleb, but his thoughts were already elsewhere, deep in his own concerns. And Gleb looked at Lieutenant Colonel Dovner in wonder: the feelings this man aroused were strangely ambivalent. From every theoretical point of view, Dovner was transforming the Soviet system, which had been conceived as something of perfect, crystalline purity. Yet whenever Gleb saw Dovner’s broad smiling face, his quick gaze, expressing not exactly a lofty intellect but a sharp, vigorous, and commodious mind, he could imagine all those disarming, mutually advantageous deals, which always benefitted specific individuals, not so much in terms of enrichment but, rather, in terms of evasion, exemption, dodging responsibility, and Gleb wondered why Dovner, rather than seeming a reprehensible character, could still appear so likable.

“Well? . . . You’ve found it? And the hearing’s already set for the day after tomorrow? Just drop the case, then, all right? So long, then. . . . Yes, yes, we’ll fix it.”

Dovner gently replaced the receiver.

“D’you understand?”

No! Right to the very end, Gleb had not truly understood or sensed the danger he’d been in. Those sensible decrees against panic-mongers that he’d

so recently welcomed could not affect *him*, after all! It had so easily passed him by, as if nothing had ever happened: the gigantic wheel had rolled by, almost squashing him to a pulp—yet Gleb could not even grasp that the wheel existed and that it was in motion. ♦

(Translated, from the Russian, by Alexis Klimoff and Michael Nicholson.)

This is drawn from “[Love the Revolution: An Unfinished Novel](#).”

Sketchbook

Your Guide to Navigating the Parent Group Chat

From the kind and competent to the scheming and lost, meet all the characters blowing up your phone.

By Liana Finck

September 28, 2026



YOUR GUIDE TO NAVIGATING THE PARENT GROUP CHAT



The Critics

- [The Unknowable Miley Cyrus](#)
- [Why America Looks the Way It Does](#)
- [How America Became Antifascist](#)
- [Briefly Noted](#)
- [Gut Renos of Ionesco and Chekhov](#)
- [The Predator Catcher Turns Predatory in “Primetime”](#)

The Unknowable Miley Cyrus

The singer has been raunchy, folksy, psychedelic, Disney-clean. On her new album, “Bass Persuades,” she disappears onto the dance floor.

By Amanda Petrusich

September 19, 2026



These days, pop stars are required to participate in a relentless cycle of self-annihilation and triumphant rebirth—with each album, a new Era!—but there’s something almost uncanny about the plasticity of Miley Cyrus. After entering the public consciousness, in 2006, as the chipper, apple-cheeked star of the Disney Channel series “Hannah Montana,” she released multiple songs declaring herself a hedonist, beginning with “Can’t Be Tamed,” in 2010, and reaching a nihilistic apotheosis with her fourth album, “Bangerz,” from 2013. The single “We Can’t Stop” is an unrepentant ode to ripping it up: “So la-da-di-da-di, we like to party / Dancing with Molly / Doing whatever we want,” she announces in the pre-chorus. To some degree, Cyrus’s rebellion was preordained: in 2008, when she was fifteen, Annie Leibovitz photographed her nude, wrapped only in a bedsheet, for the cover of *Vanity Fair*. “You can’t say no to Annie!” Cyrus cheerfully told a reporter.

The Cyrus of “Bangerz” was plucky and impulsive, prone to twerking and sticking her tongue out. When she performed “We Can’t Stop” at the [2013 V.M.A.s](#), it was a brash rebuttal of her wholesome younger self. It was also a bonanza of what we might now call millennial cringe. Cyrus, who emerged onstage from inside a Teddy bear, ripped off a sparkly bodice to reveal a flesh-colored bikini. She got a little flirty with a foam finger. Robin Thicke strolled out, wearing Beetlejuice stripes, and did a verse from “[Blurred Lines](#).” At one point, the camera cut to [Drake](#), looking forlorn, and later to Rihanna, seated and largely expressionless. Yet “Bangerz,” which features around thirty songwriters, and production from Pharrell Williams, Dr. Luke, and Mike WiLL Made-It, remains Cyrus’s top-selling album; it debuted at No. 1 and eventually sold more than three million copies.

Cyrus has a big, blousy voice with an unmistakable country warble. Her Southernness—she was born in Franklin, Tennessee, the second daughter of the country singer Billy Ray Cyrus, and a goddaughter of [Dolly Parton](#)—is more palpable on her early singles, such as “Party in the U.S.A.,” a pop masterpiece from 2009. Cyrus is always more compelling when she revels in her singularity and occasional awkwardness: “My tummy’s turnin’ and I’m feelin’ kinda homesick / Too much pressure and I’m nervous,” she sings in the pre-chorus. (Who among us?) “Party in the U.S.A.” is exquisitely performed, alternately shouty and tender—even now, it’s hard to think of another singer who could have so perfectly embodied its mix of innocence and hunger.

But since “Bangerz,” Cyrus has been either casting about for an identity that feels true or embracing a postmodern disavowal of authenticity itself, depending on whom you ask. My money is on the earnest searching, though I do think that Cyrus enjoys, and excels at, character work, and has an unusual knack for inhabiting different styles. (The covers that she has done over the years, including Blondie’s “Heart of Glass” and the Cranberries’ “Zombie,” are reliably excellent.) Her penchant for reinvention feels less commercially motivated and more personal, as if she’s still trying to figure out who she really is—a process that many assume will wrap up by the close of one’s twenties (Cyrus is thirty-three) but which, in actuality, often goes on indefinitely. She followed up “Bangerz” with “[Miley Cyrus & Her Dead Petz](#),” a freaky, strung-out psych-pop record that she released for free on SoundCloud. Much of the album was co-written and produced by Wayne

Coyne, of the Flaming Lips, and it features tracks with blessedly stoned titles such as “Fucking Fucked Up” and “Milky Milky Milk.”

By 2017, Cyrus was covering her tattoos with makeup, wearing all white, and singing ballads of marital devotion. The [video for “Malibu,”](#) a single from the album “Younger Now,” shows Cyrus, then engaged to the actor Liam Hemsworth (they were married for eight months, between 2018 and 2019), on the beach, twirling in Pollyannaish ecstasy, her hair tousled by the sea breeze. She marvels at the ocean: “I never went boatin’, don’t get how they’re floatin’,” she sings, her voice full and trembly, “And sometimes I get so scared of what I can’t understand.” She released three more albums between 2020 and 2025, experimenting with indie rock and glam rock; on the single “Flowers,” the best-selling song of 2023, her sound is, by turns, folksy, retro, and disco-pop. “I can buy myself flowers,” she proclaims, “Write my name in the sand / Talk to myself for hours / Say things you don’t understand.”

I loved the confidence and ease of “Flowers”—it has the enticing swagger of Gloria Gaynor’s “I Will Survive” and Fleetwood Mac’s “Go Your Own Way,” two iconic breakup tracks. I don’t think Cyrus has ever really made an awful record. Still, received together, her albums suggest that, aesthetically, she’s something of a blank canvas. This both points toward an enviable, large-minded freedom and leaves me wondering what she actually wants to say.

Three years ago, Cyrus released “Used to Be Young,” a plaintive ballad about saying sayonara to one’s wild years. It was a bonus track on a digital reissue of “Endless Summer Vacation,” her eighth LP. The song functions as a teary-eyed encomium for a misspent youth: “You tell me time has done changed me / That’s fine, I’ve had a good run.” Cyrus was thirty when the song was released—not ancient, exactly, but not a kid, either.

Still, perhaps it was too early to light the funeral pyre. Last month, she dropped her last name (she is now known, mononymously, as Miley); on Friday, she released her tenth album, “Bass Persuades.” The title track is dark, pulsing dance pop, indebted, in obvious ways, to the trickle-down influence of [Madonna](#), particularly via [Britney Spears](#), Lady Gaga, and Dua Lipa. Lyrically, the song is an homage to touching grass: “Glued your eyes

to the telephone screen / But you missed the hit without MTV / Go analog, make it cinema,” Miley implores. The chorus is a kind of lashing: “The kids don’t wanna dance,” she sings, over and over. Spiritually, it feels like a companion piece to Spears’s (perfect) 2003 single “Me Against the Music,” about being so moved by the beat that you have no choice but to throw ass: “I’m the only one dancin’ up in this place,” Spears sang.

Yet whereas Spears is preternaturally gifted at this sort of punchy, staccato delivery—she brings a cheerleader’s precision to her vocals, even when she is mysteriously extending the word “on” to multiple syllables—Miley’s cyclone of a voice tends to work better with looser, airier material. Dance pop favors rigor over style; each note should hit like a fist. The cadence of the title track’s spoken verses reminds me a little bit of [Charli XCX](#)’s “Wink Wink” and [Kesha](#)’s “Tik Tok,” but Miley is a belter at heart; ultimately, I found myself longing for the big-breath bombast of tunes like “Wrecking Ball” and “The Climb.”

The rest of “Bass Persuades” contains similarly sultry, twilit songs about the sort of rhapsodic, all-consuming love that makes a person go googly-eyed: “I’ve got my own God / My God’s a hot boy,” she sings on “Different Religion.” Miley is engaged to the musician Maxx Morando, who appears in the black-and-white music video for “Let’s Get Married,” one of the album’s best tracks. (In the video, the couple prance around the Chateau Marmont, partying, wearing almost nothing—and who can blame them, for they are hot.) It’s a romantic song about being so overcome by desire that you can’t wait to seal the deal: “Then he said, ‘Baby, what did I do to deserve you? / Tell me, what did I do to deserve you?’ / Let’s go get married tonight.” On “Orbit,” a yearning, piano-led hymn that recalls the moodiness and desperation of [Lana Del Rey](#), with a hint of Heart’s “Alone,” Miley sings, “And I would bend all space and time / To fall into your hands / I’m drawn to you / I belong to you.”

“Bass Persuades” is a mix of adoring ballads and throbbing dance songs, which is not an inaccurate representation of the experience of falling for somebody—the eternal pendulum swing between lust and devotion, wantonness and hope. Yet, with the exception of “Let’s Get Married,” there isn’t a single track here that really makes me think: *Miley*. Perhaps expecting fixed self-definition from a pop star is outdated, now that our attention is

irreparably fractured. Miley has always engaged with questions of persona —“Hannah Montana” is about a pop star masquerading as a regular girl, or maybe vice versa—while professing authenticity. For her, those ideas aren’t mutually exclusive. In a recent interview, she spoke about the distance between who she is onstage and who she is at her pet-filled home in L.A.: “Sometimes I call what I do drag, because the way that I present myself is just someone that is so different from the person that feeds the tortoise every morning.” She has been a professional actor, after all, for more than two decades now.

The album reminds me, in a circuitous way, of Madonna’s guest verse in “Me Against the Music”: “Sexy lady, I’d rather see you bare your soul.” It’s a quick, almost maternal rejoinder to Spears’s obsession with being seen and admired on the dance floor. “Bass Persuades” does not want for confessionalism, or vulnerability, but there is something of a personality void at its center. I would also like to see more of Miley’s soul, lest she lose track of it entirely. ♦

A Critic at Large

Why America Looks the Way It Does

From vast grids to winding suburbs, Americans have spent two centuries remaking the landscape around property.

By Daniel Immerwahr

September 28, 2026



To Europeans, the early United States was a curiosity: rich in resources yet poor in history. They were used to a storied landscape, where it was impossible to go for a stroll without tripping over the lithic remnants of some distant era. America, by contrast, seemed blank. The French writer Alexis de Tocqueville scoffed at the “day-old ruins” of deserted log cabins—the closest thing to historical depth that this pathetically young country could manage.

He should have spent more time in Ohio. Settlers there were finding thousands of ancient Native mounds and earthworks, some bafflingly large. Refusing to believe that the ancestors of Native Americans could have built such monumental structures, writers floated bizarre theories as to who had.

Perhaps it was a lost tribe of Israel, or an extinct race of giants. (Why not both?)

If oversized Jews were indeed behind it, they must have been especially fond of Pickaway County. It boasted mounds aplenty and the earthen remains of two forts, one circular and another square, constructed with startling geometric precision. In 1810, surveyors latched on to the circle and founded a city, named Circleville, in concentric arcs around it. This was “probably the only city in North America developed in a radio-concentric plan,” the historian John W. Reps wrote in 1955. (There’ve been others since.) It was also, he observed, probably the only settler city built around an Indigenous form.

Circular or not, the surveying couldn’t come soon enough. Whites were swarming into Ohio. They bought Circleville plots at a barbecue—featuring an immense, sled-drawn wheel of cheese—and raced to erect the first house. By night, several slapdash dwellings stood ready for occupancy.

It did not take long for the charms of Circleville’s bowed lots to wear off. They were hard to divvy up, and their irregular contours wasted valuable land. Rectangles would have worked better, Ohio’s government conceded. And so the Circleville Squaring Company was formed to replace Circleville’s curves with corners.

Circlevillians turned on their city like a squadron of deranged geometers. They razed the earthworks, flattened the land, rationalized property lines, and laid down straight streets. An aghast English writer warned that there would soon be “no vestige left of that peculiarity which gave the place its name, and which constituted the most perfect and therefore most interesting work of antiquity of its class in the country.” He was right; the prehistoric ruins were obliterated. Today, visitors can puzzle over a flat road called Mound Street in a square city called Circleville.

So it went in the United States. A lively new book by the historian Joshua Specht, “[Property Values](#)” (Princeton), considers land ownership from the country’s founding to now. It’s been two hundred and fifty years of tumult. Nineteenth-century settlers saw themselves as pioneers, breaking new ground, but, Specht notes, so did twentieth-century suburbanites.

Understandably so. His book describes campaign after campaign to remake the land.

It's often said that the original sin of the United States was slavery. Specht winces at this, not because he downplays slavery but because he regards Native dispossession as equally fundamental. The act itself was consequential, but so was the mind-set it encouraged: a tendency to treat territory as empty space. U.S. leaders stood before the map like mathematicians before a chalkboard. Circles, squares—the slate could be wiped clean as needed.

To get gravel for Circleville's roads, workers dug into a nearby hillock. It was a burial site, they discovered, full of skeletons. They carried on. Circleville's straightened streets were to be paved with Native bones.

It would be hard to overstate how ignorant the Founders of the United States were about their own country. The main map they'd used to negotiate the postwar peace with Britain was woefully inaccurate. It showed the Mississippi River—set as the outer border—curving adventurously west onto the Great Plains. The historian Daniel Boorstin noted that some politicians misunderstood the treaty because they'd confused the Mississippi and the Missouri. A forgivable mistake, given that they did not know where either river actually ran.

They didn't know because those rivers wound through foreign lands. The quiet fact about the new United States was that half the territory it claimed (and far more of the continent beyond its borders) remained under Indigenous control. The largest inaccuracy of the era's maps was to show that land as belonging to the United States.

That half-claimed Western territory might someday furnish desirable farms for settlers. Yet, even presuming that the government could beat back Native powers, intelligently dividing that unseen area into plots would require understanding its geography, soil, and waterways. Perhaps there was an easier approach, Thomas Jefferson suggested. What about drawing a gigantic grid and just partitioning the area into squares?

The grid was a familiar form, occasionally used in colonial cities, such as Philadelphia. But previous grids had been tightly bounded—patches of orthogonal civilization within an arcing and twisting terrain. What Jefferson envisaged, in contrast, was an unyielding north-south grid of continental proportions. He imagined new states as roughly rectangular, tiled end to end with square plots.

Beware straight borders on a map—they usually mean that the person drawing them knows nothing of the place in question. That was true of Jefferson, but there was an upside to his ignorance, the historian Amir Alexander argues in “[Liberty’s Grid](#)” (2024). The grid Jefferson proposed was neutral, agnostic, making no place more important than any other. This was connected to Jefferson’s political views, Alexander argues. In a country where all men were created equal, as Jefferson’s Declaration of Independence put it, all plots would be, too.

Congress summoned surveyors from all thirteen states to start laying down Jefferson’s grid. On September 30, 1785, surveyors from eight states got to work in what is now Ohio, just across Pennsylvania’s western border, in lands controlled by Lenapes, Miamis, Odawas, and Shawnees. After axemen cleared paths through the oaks, elms, and basswoods, the surveyors stretched a standardized measure called a Gunter’s chain—a hundred links to a chain, eighty chains to a mile—and marked the distances with tally pegs. It was a lot of fuss to make a few perforations in the earth’s surface. But those dotted lines were meant to run from the “Place of Beginning,” as the lead surveyor called it, to the distant horizon.

Jefferson’s idea was strange in many ways, but the strangest thing about it is that it took hold. By the early twentieth century, thirty-five more states had joined the original thirteen. All had at least one straight side, and several were essentially rectangles. Meanwhile, the public-land survey that began in Ohio had extended to the Pacific, covering two-thirds of the contiguous United States. As whites marched onto new lands, the grid unrolled before them like a red carpet.

Squares suited the fast-moving settlers. Certainly, they were simpler than plots defined by landmarks. Consider how one Massachusetts landowner delineated his property in that traditional system: it was “more or less

bounded” by a path that started with a stake on E. Daniels’s land and then moved east “about 97 1/2 rods” to a corner of a fence, north “about 54 rods” to the corner of I. Fowler’s land, twenty-four rods toward the chestnut tree growing in the wall of Daniels’s property, and back to the stake. Compared with that morass of rustic wayfinding, where you practically had to marry Fowler’s daughter to get comprehensible directions, coördinates were bliss.

Squares made life easy for officials, too. Although the nineteenth-century state collected few taxes, it funded things with what Specht calls the “national nest egg”: its extensive landholdings. An investigation by Robert Lee and Tristan Ahtone for *High Country News* showed how this worked in higher education. To start fifty-two land-grant universities, the government used more than ten million acres it had wrested from nearly two hundred and fifty Native polities. It gave the institutions federal holdings in the West, which they could rent out or, more likely, sell. M.I.T., Cornell, Texas A. & M., Penn State, and U.C. Berkeley were among the schools launched with these grants.

The national nest egg also bankrolled the military, as soldiers could be paid partly in property. This started a vicious cycle: wars against Indians yielded land, and land funded wars. Abraham Lincoln received two parcels of federal acreage for serving less than three months in the Black Hawk War of 1832. From Illinois, where he lived, he opted for grid squares in Iowa, which he owned without ever visiting.

Eventually, the government started giving land away. The first Homestead Act, signed by Lincoln in 1862, distributed squares for free, as long as recipients went and farmed them. In a country known for its bootstrap individualism, this was a monumental handout; officials ultimately doled out an area the size of Pakistan. The vast checkerboard that airline passengers see when they fly over the West shows state socialism in action.

For settlers, gridded land came to seem natural. American football was initially played on a field of squares, hence the occasional references today to football fields as “gridirons.” Musicians use the precise markings on those fields to choreograph geometrically complex routines as part of a distinctive art form: the marching-band drill.

More consequential was the squaring of cities, like Circleville. Older settlements, such as Boston, kept their short streets and jaunty angles. But nineteenth-century ones resembled Mondrian paintings. Manhattan, straddling the two patterns, began as a typical jumble of pathways until an early-nineteenth-century planning commission imposed a grid, turning nearly everything above Fourteenth Street into a regular matrix of numbered streets intersecting numbered avenues.

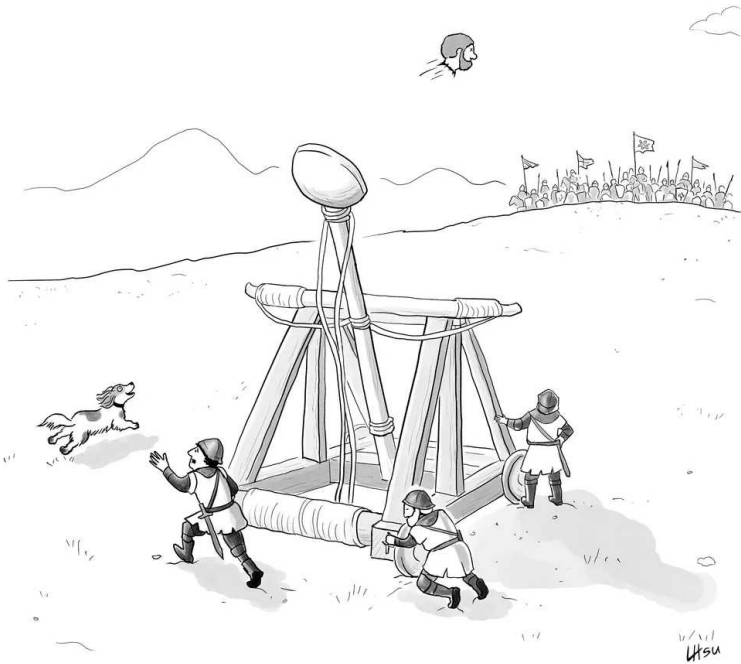
The numbers are telling. In Britain and elsewhere, streets are typically named for landmarks: Station, Church, Mill, Green, and School are among the most common. In the United States, the top names are numerical—Main/First, Second, Third, and Fourth—as if its towns were coördinate planes. The numbers sometimes go disconcertingly high: to 400th Street outside Miami, 477th Avenue outside Seattle, and 571st Avenue outside Phoenix. The enumeration system starting in Roosevelt, Utah, runs ambitiously and intermittently through dozens of desert miles to reach the right-angle intersection of 6,000th South and 47,000th West.

The grid treats the Earth as if it's flat, which, famously, it is not. Squaring off the land required property lines and related roads to perform a sort of topographical parkour, running straight over hills and across rivers. In San Francisco, the grids simply ignored the steeply sloping terrain, resulting in streets so precipitous that they make parking an extreme sport.

All this unswerving rigidity served one end: transferring property. In that, the grid succeeded marvellously. During the late nineteenth century, in what is now Oklahoma but had been Indian Territory, the government distributed some formerly Native-owned land to whoever could reach it first in a race. At the firing of a federal official's gun, settlers scrambled to claim their squares.

Native Americans, in losing their land, lost the anchors of their worlds. Settlers, in gaining it, gained something less. Jefferson had imagined planting the countryside with farmers, but how deeply would roots grow in a property defined, as Lincoln's was, as "N. W. $\frac{1}{4}$ of the S. W. $\frac{1}{4}$ Sec. 20 T. 84 R. 15 West in Tama Co. Iowa"? Men like Lincoln, in selecting square plots on maps, weren't joining communities so much as amassing commodities.

Sensitive souls rebelled. Lewis Mumford, the great architectural critic, bemoaned the parcelling of land into “abstract units for buying and selling, without respect for historic uses, for topographic conditions, or for social needs.” It was pretty much a rite of passage for authors to deride Manhattan’s orthogonal streetscape: its “perpetual dead flat” (Walt Whitman), “primal topographic curse” (Henry James), or “deadly uniformity of mean ugliness” (Edith Wharton).



Nineteenth-century Romantics sought to reclaim a verdant refuge within Manhattan. This could supply “an antithesis to its bustling, paved, rectangular, walled-in streets,” the planner Frederick Law Olmsted believed. Under Olmsted’s direction, the city evicted roughly sixteen hundred New Yorkers (mostly Black or immigrant), exploded almost twenty-one thousand barrels of gunpowder, and moved more than a hundred million cubic feet of earth and stone to create Central Park. It was an Arcadia of meandering paths. Unlike the rest of Manhattan, you could get lost there.

Central Park was just the start. Olmsted also designed cemeteries, campuses, and garden-city suburbs. He even had a hand in establishing a nature preserve in the Yosemite Valley, which expanded to become today’s Yosemite National Park. It was all, Amir Alexander argues, part of a larger revolt against rectangles.

In this new light, Circleville looked different. In 1880, a local history of Pickaway County expressed regret over the obliteration of its earthworks. That relic-strewn ground, the author fumed, could have made the most “unique and attractive” park in all of Ohio.

One of the grid’s most astute late-nineteenth-century critics, the geologist John Wesley Powell, decried its environmental recklessness. Square plots might work in the East, but they’d cause ruin in the semi-arid West, he felt. Their straight lines ran roughshod across natural drainage basins, leaving some tracts unirrigated. Borders should follow water flows, not compass directions, Powell believed.

A fine idea. Yet Powell was “using bear language in a bull market,” his biographer, Wallace Stegner, wrote. The government went on gridding land, and hopeful farmers surged onto the plains, snapping up plots whose ecologies they barely understood. They enjoyed bumper crops in rainy years. But when drought struck Oklahoma and surrounding states, as drought regularly did, the topsoil dried out and blew away. Plowing up the native grasses that held that soil in place probably didn’t help.

Specht writes eloquently of the Depression-era Dust Bowl caused by an especially dire drought. The liberated dirt smothered crops and choked towns, burying farmers’ dreams in fine powder. It blew east, in great dark storms, to Boston, New York, Washington, D.C., and Atlanta. Dust rained on the White House and the Statue of Liberty.

The symbolism, for anyone who cared to notice, was rich. Whites had seized enormous swaths of unfamiliar territory. To turn it hastily into property, they’d partitioned it into squares, reducing complex geography to simple geometry. They had come for the land in droves. Now the land was coming for them.

The nineteen-thirties were a tipping point, Specht argues. If strivers in the previous decade had sought newly available farmland, their children more often sought suburban houses. The American Dream, in this sense, moved from production to consumption, from homesteaders growing crops to homeowners buying appliances. With this social shift came a spatial one, from the grid to the curve.

Again, the state blazed the trail. Whereas previously it had subsidized the mass acquisition of land, now it started subsidizing the mass purchase of houses. It did so by providing zero-down-payment loans, guaranteeing mortgages, building roads, and insuring loans to developers. The home-buying boom was “guided by government but implemented through the market,” Specht writes. This made it seem like the result of individual choices. But policies shaped those choices, and those policies strongly incentivized new, detached houses on cities’ edges. By 1960, Specht notes, “there were more Americans in suburban single-family homes than people in cities or in the countryside.”

In essence, officials helped city dwellers flee the grid. Cars made suburbs physically accessible, and subsidies made them financially so. Builders, prodded to work beyond city limits, adopted Olmsted’s vision for what those suburbs should look like. Essentially, they should look like Central Park. “Gracefully-curved lines, generous spaces, and the absence of sharp corners,” Olmsted wrote, would cultivate “contemplativeness and happy tranquillity.”

Developers sold slices of nature, but there was nothing natural about the suburbs. They were as sudden and artificial as the grids had been. The most famous postwar suburb, Levittown, on Long Island, was an explosion of 17,447 houses built in a four-year spree on failed farmland. (The farmers had daringly pursued an all-potatoes style of industrial farming only to see their tuberous cash crop ruined by an invading pest.) The builders, the Levitt family, boasted that by using assembly-line techniques they could produce a house every sixteen minutes. They’d intended to at least personalize the streets by choosing nomenclatural themes for subdivisions, but they couldn’t think of enough. Throwing in the towel, they just gave some areas street names starting with the same letter: the “D” section, the “E” section, and so on.

Throughout the nineteen-fifties, developers like the Levitts levelled an area about the size of Rhode Island every year, according to the historian Adam Rome’s [“The Bulldozer in the Countryside”](#) (2001). Hillocks, which interfered with mass construction, had to go. So did trees—the Levitts ripped them out to ease the work of building crews (and then planted saplings after the homes were built). It was Oklahoma all over again. Some

suburbs battled soil erosion, which ruined rivers and contaminated drinking water. Others suffered dramatic landslides.

Mud and silt weren't the only substances flowing downhill. In escaping the grid, suburbanites also escaped municipal sewer systems. Often, this meant septic tanks. These had worked adequately for isolated farmers, but too many could overwhelm the absorptive capacity of the ground—especially if sprinklers were watering the lawns—causing effluent to rise to the surface or enter waterways. In Levittown, the cost-cutting builders at first hadn't even bothered with tanks and had installed cesspools instead—three decades later, the suburb's sewer system was still under construction. (It could have been worse: in one Miami development, the toilets just flushed straight into front yards.) Rome describes public-health experts, having essentially vanquished raw sewage in cities, cursing the skies as it oozed through the suburbs.

Had anyone thought this through? Perhaps not, Michael Glass suggests in "[Cracked Foundations](#)" (University of Pennsylvania), a bracing new history of Levittown and its environs. Although curving suburbs were spatially antithetical to gridded cities, they shared one principle: speed. Most were instant communities, born of the same monomania for property sales as the grid. Glass chronicles the chaos as home buyers thronged into tracts without schools, sewers, trash removal, or viable tax bases.

The reward was homeownership. But the way to capitalize on homeownership wasn't by sinking roots; it was by buying, building equity, and selling. This made the suburbs transient places, Glass argues. The average nineteen-fifties Levittowner left after five years.

As is well known, many suburbs were racially exclusive. The government favored loans to racially homogeneous suburban developments, and racial covenants maintained that homogeneity. In 1948, the Supreme Court found such covenants judicially unenforceable, but Specht explains how communities upheld them nonetheless. When the first Black couple moved into another Levittown, in Pennsylvania, in 1957, their neighbors burned crosses, threw stones, and gathered menacingly at their property line. The man who sold the couple that house was fired from his job.

This racial discrimination gave whites privileged access to government-backed assets—suburban houses. But, as Glass points out, condemnation of the suburbs’ racial exclusion can make it sound as if they were paradises whose only flaw was that their gates were unfairly locked. That is worth questioning. *Did* open spaces, cul-de-sacs, and “Oops, all curves” street designs make for better living?

It’s hard to say. The problem with the grid was its empty abstraction, an insensitivity to purpose that made the city a “grinding and piling up of blind forces,” in Frank Lloyd Wright’s words. Suburban developers swung hard in the opposite direction, designing large areas around specified activities. But in doing so they took the elements that had been interwoven in cities and separated them into housing tracts, office parks, industrial zones, and shopping areas. Critics compared this to eating an omelette by consuming its ingredients one by one—eggs, cheese, vegetables, oil, then salt.

Unsurprisingly, developers creating single-purpose spaces placed controls on them, and not only racial ones. Specht gives the example of Celebration, Florida, the Disney-developed suburb that opened in the nineties. Its residential area is ruled with the stringency of a Victorian governess: commercial activity is forbidden, pets and parking are restricted, and front-facing curtains must be white or—for renegades who dance on the razor’s edge of propriety—off-white. This all sounds exhausting, but most inhabitants love it, Specht notes, especially compared with the chaos of nearby Miami.

A less-noticed constraint comes from suburbia’s street layouts. Although suburban enclaves boast winding lanes, their more determining feature is their lack of intersections, the architectural theorist Albert Pope observes in his highly intelligent book [“Ladders”](#) (1996). Urban grids are a tight mesh of streets and junctions, meaning that any two points on them are connected by many viable routes. Suburbs, by contrast, are generally hostile to the idea of strangers barrelling through, so they have fewer streets and fewer crossings. This prevents traffic from flowing evenly, pushing it away from cul-de-sacs and go-nowhere lanes and onto a few large roads. Some communities, famously, have gates at those roads. The gatehouses prompt eye rolls, but the underlying exclusion lies in the fact that such places have so few entrances that they *can* be gated.

The unintended effect of low-density construction, restrictive zoning, and curving roads is a staggering increase in the distance between destinations. Ultimately, the cul-de-sacs designed to repel traffic increase the number of needed cars. And the more a place accommodates cars—widening main roads into smooth, unobstructed arcs—the more dangerous it becomes to walk or cycle, and the more everyone drives.

This country is now littered with developments that are called parks and gardens where it is miserable to do the one thing people like to do in parks and gardens: walk. The writer Jonathan Franzen has described a bizarre sociological phenomenon resulting from this state of affairs. Whenever Franzen, an avid urban hiker, tries his perambulations in suburban Missouri or Colorado, he sticks out so awkwardly that men in passing cars shout obscenities at him. I've experienced the same thing walking the winding streets of Levittown on Long Island.

The suburbs promise space yet deliver emptiness, critics charge. Even the most thoughtfully designed enclaves are suspended in a larger sprawl. For Pope, the result is a revolting phantasmagoria: the orange sodium-vapor lights of “nighttime parking lots, long abandoned agricultural fields overdraped by power lines, immaculate corporate campuses maintained in silence save for the splash of a ‘water feature,’ the brutal concrete and weeds of a freeway apron.” This is the nineteenth-century complaint about the grid—that it was soulless—applied to its opposite.

Specht adds another complaint: the suburbs have pushed politics rightward. Generally, in the United States, people get more conservative as population density falls. Even diehard Democrats seem to have felt the tug. In “[Don't Blame Us](#)” (2015), the historian Lily Geismer profiles Boston's deep-blue suburbs, full of engineers and college professors. Their inhabitants worked assiduously for integration and against war, yet they also embraced a politics of individual choice that eschewed collective spending on broader social goals. Geismer suggests that the market-forward liberalism that took hold during Bill Clinton's Presidency can be traced to the suburbanization of the Democratic Party.

It's tempting to see the curve as having vanquished the grid. In reality, they're both alive, and they're almost symbiotically bonded. Suburbs stretch

their undulating freeways into the grid, sucking out nutrients (and cutting through neighborhoods). Cities, encased in suburbs, extend their ever-widening “metropolitan areas” for miles.

Specht calls for a truce between city and suburb. The government once dedicated itself energetically to distributing homesteads or homes. If such energy could go toward building up higher-density neighborhoods in lower-cost areas, a hitherto elusive “shared civic life” might be obtained, Specht suggests. It’s a sensible thought. Both the grid and the curve were simplistic, uncompromising ideas. And, when it comes to viable communities, compromise is everything.

But why did simplistic ideas hold such sway for so long? The United States has been a rootless, restless country, lunging between “Make everything squares” and “Screw squares, we’re doing circles.” Such crudely geometric thinking prevailed because the unfamiliar land seemed unmarked by history. On a stolen continent, settlers rushed onto new terrain and let their ideas run rampant. They flattened the mounds and paved the roads, bulldozing yesterday to clear space for tomorrow. ♦

Books

How America Became Antifascist

Franklin D. Roosevelt was slow to confront the threat of Fascism. A new history explores how he—and the country—finally came around.

By Beverly Gage

September 28, 2026



In fiction, spoiler alerts exist to protect the reader experience, premised on the idea that knowing a story's outcome will reduce momentum and suspense. In historical writing, it's just the opposite. Works of history gain energy from the fact that readers know where the narrative is going, especially when it's going nowhere good. Books on the origins of wars tend to rely on a tragic arc, with the reader aware of the shoals ahead while the books' subjects blithely reassure one another that the coast looks clear, that diplomacy will win the day, that any conflict will be short and easy.

Within this literature, no decade is more doom-laden than the nineteen-thirties, when misguided hope and willful blindness led the world's democracies to grossly underestimate the threat of Fascism. In the standard story, the United States, Britain, and France stood by, wringing their hands

and straining for appeasement while the Japanese stampeded through Asia and Nazi Storm Troopers ran roughshod over Europe. The result was the greatest cataclysm in modern history: seventy million dead, the genocide of European Jews, the bombing of once magnificent cities. The reader, aware of this outcome, is left with the literary equivalent of shouting at the screen: Don't do it! Act now! Watch out—they're coming for you!

The historian William I. Hitchcock's excellent new book, "[A Shadow Over the World: Franklin D. Roosevelt, the Rise of Fascism, and the Making of America's World War II](#)" (Simon & Schuster), leans into this sense of foreboding. In the course of nearly six hundred pages, Hitchcock describes how Fascism spread across the globe, beginning with Mussolini's rise in the battered, destabilized Italy of the nineteen-twenties and ending in 1941, when Hitler occupied most of Continental Europe. A Pulitzer finalist and a professor at the University of Virginia, Hitchcock has written several books about the Second World War, each with an emphasis on the European theatre. This time, he wants to explain why U.S. policymakers, especially F.D.R., failed to act or even to fully comprehend what was happening until it was almost too late.

Unlike most coming-of-war narratives, though, "A Shadow Over the World" offers a happy ending of sorts. Hitchcock lays out a harrowing chronology of self-interested decisions, missed opportunities, and moments of cowardice as U.S. government officials debated how to meet the Fascist threat. Yet his main question is not why they failed to counter it but how, in the end, they succeeded. "In these pages," he writes by way of introduction, "we will see an imperfect nation and an imperfect leader strive to do good after a long stretch of doing nothing in the face of fascist persecution." What's amazing about the era, he suggests, is not the hope, cherished by so many Americans, that war might be avoided. It's that the nation eventually rose up and dedicated the full force of its industrial, ideological, spiritual, and military might to banishing Fascism from the earth.

To suggest that the United States in the mid-twentieth century was, at its heart, an antifascist nation is no small claim these days. In the decade-plus since Donald Trump descended his golden escalator, historians have been busy excavating what a Roosevelt aide described as the "latent Nazism" in American life. Recent books have explored Americans' embrace of eugenics

and racism, anti-egalitarianism and antisemitism, nativism and illiberal politics. They have also explored the literal Fascism that took root in the U.S. during the thirties, when avowedly pro-Nazi organizations held mass rallies at Madison Square Garden and Henry Ford cozied up to Hitler.

This work has helped make our own backlash moment more comprehensible: despite the myth of liberal progress, the reactionary and quasi-Fascist strains of American society have long been there. But the scholarly trend has obscured something that once seemed obvious—during the defining crisis of the century, the U.S. fought Fascism with everything it had. Hitchcock declares this struggle an “inspiring story of America,” with all the necessary caveats. In 1941, the aviator Charles Lindbergh may still have been praising Hitler’s air power and railing against undue Jewish influence. The federal government, though, was securely in the hands of committed antifascists. Foremost among them was Roosevelt, who maintained that democracy and Fascism could not coexist.

In Hitchcock’s telling, Roosevelt is both hero and antihero: the man who refused to heed warnings of a looming disaster—until, in the nick of time, he did. Born into a wealthy and storied political family in New York’s Hudson Valley, Roosevelt grew up expecting an easy life. For years, those expectations held firm. Though the region where he grew up leaned Republican, Roosevelt joined the Democratic Party and rose swiftly through state government. Just before the First World War, with a Democrat, Woodrow Wilson, in the White House, he was appointed Assistant Secretary of the Navy, the same post that his legendary cousin Theodore once held. In 1920, at the tender age of thirty-eight, he won a spot on the national ticket as the Party’s Vice-Presidential candidate. Although it turned out to be a Republican year, Roosevelt emerged as a rising star and a Democratic standard-bearer.

Then, in 1921, the first great tragedy of his life struck. One day in August, he came down with a fever and numbness throughout his body; by the next morning, he could not move. The culprit turned out to be polio, a dreaded disease of the pre-vaccine twentieth century. Despite the best therapies, he never regained the ability to walk unaided. Like many biographers, Hitchcock sees this physical ordeal as a turn of events that deepened Roosevelt’s character. But “A Shadow Over the World” is not primarily a

biography of Roosevelt. Instead, the book offers a collective account of the “colorful, angry, tumultuous years” of his Presidency, when “chaos, fear, and profound human insecurity ruled” the globe.

For Roosevelt’s generation, no historical experience carried more weight than the First World War—or, as it was commonly known until 1939, the Great War. As Hitchcock notes, it is impossible to understand the thirties without that earlier war as a reference point: a grand cautionary tale about what to do and what not to do in response to European conflict. By the time Roosevelt became President, in 1933, most Americans viewed the war as a huge mistake. Progressives mourned the death of reform amid patriotic jingoism. Conservatives shuddered to think how close the country had come to permanent entangling alliances. Americans across the political spectrum agreed that the bloodshed had been a colossal waste of money and human life. Meant to be “the war to end war” and to make the world “safe for democracy,” it had instead produced instability, economic catastrophe, and imperial rivalry.



The war also gave new force to two powerful ideological movements, Soviet Communism and European Fascism, both of which seemed hellbent on destabilizing, then remaking, the global order. “A Shadow Over the World” is especially effective at describing the rise of Fascism in the twenties, first

in Italy and then, more haltingly, in Weimar Germany. It was Benito Mussolini, not Adolf Hitler, who created the Fascist playbook: fomenting a national crisis through “political terrorism,” turning “angry young men” into thuggish enforcement agents, attacking the legitimacy of the existing government, and then demanding a new government in its place. In discussing such techniques, Hitchcock studiously avoids comparisons to the present, though one can’t help but wonder whether certain details were chosen for their current resonance. “I am in top form. Huge crowd,” Germany’s propaganda minister, Joseph Goebbels, wrote in his diary in 1933 after leading a book-burning rally.

Such moments are chilling to read about, in part because we know where they will lead. At the time, however, the meaning of Fascism wasn’t so clear. Though we now tend to view antisemitism as the ideology’s molten core, many Americans, well into the thirties, associated Fascism mainly with anti-Communism, which had its own powerful constituency. “Their chief object is to fight socialism, communism, and anarchism,” the *New York Times* wrote in an early article about Italy’s Fascisti. The Hearst newspaper chain’s first profile of Hitler made no explicit mention of antisemitism, emphasizing instead his hatred of the Bolsheviks. Even in the mid-thirties, the *Chicago Tribune* quoted one Fascist supporter in Spain explaining that “what Spaniards mean by fascist is a government that keeps order. That is what they want—that, and to destroy the Marxists.” To many Americans, early Fascism sounded less like a foreign menace than like a familiar form of anti-Communist politics.

In any case, the nation’s approach toward Europe was not to meddle in its internal affairs but, rather, to avoid another terrible Continental war. Throughout the Western world, the twenties were a period of high hopes and big thinking about global peace; the 1928 Kellogg-Briand Pact, signed by more than sixty nations, including the United States, intended to outlaw war altogether.

Once the Great Depression hit, there seemed to be even less reason to get involved in Europe’s mess. The statistics are familiar, but they bear repeating: between 1929 and 1932, the U.S. stock market lost roughly ninety per cent of its value, and unemployment reached twenty-four per cent. No wonder most Americans favored dealing with things at home rather than

worrying about Europe. Some even called for a national dictator who could take the crisis in hand and get the economy functioning again. Instead, the country elected Franklin Roosevelt, who, in Hitchcock's words, "offered them not dictatorship but democracy."

As Hitchcock observes, Roosevelt's personal motivations and deepest convictions are notoriously difficult to parse. As President, he often told people what they wanted to hear, not necessarily what he thought. He spent little time writing reflections or elaborating on his decision-making. Because he died in office, he left behind no retrospective summaries or grand narratives of his Presidency. His Secretary of War Henry Stimson likened conversing with Roosevelt to "chasing a vagrant beam of sunshine around a vacant room." Historians can sympathize. Among the most persistent questions about Roosevelt is whether he possessed a coherent world view or just a topnotch set of political instincts.

Hitchcock believes that there was a there there—a few fundamental ideas and commitments that guided Roosevelt's actions. One was the notion of interdependence, in both domestic politics and foreign affairs. "It is literally true that the 'self-supporting' man or woman has become as extinct as the man of the Stone Age," Roosevelt declared, as the governor of New York. "Without the help of thousands of others, any one of us would die, naked and starved." In Hitchcock's account, Roosevelt eventually extended this analysis to the fight against Fascism.

It is impossible to read "A Shadow Over the World" without wondering what happened to the thoughtful, generous style of political leadership that Roosevelt embodied. Educated as a man of the world, he spoke both French and German. He devoured approximately a dozen newspapers every day, divided between morning and evening rounds. To Hitchcock, the indelible feature of Roosevelt's Presidency was his desire to protect democratic norms and processes amid crises, even as critics accused him of being a power-mad dictator or a Communist sympathizer. "Here in America we are waging a great and successful war," Roosevelt told the nation in 1936. "It is a war for the survival of democracy. We are fighting to save a great and precious form of government for ourselves and for the world." Hitchcock calls those words "the thesis of the rest of his presidency."

One question Hitchcock poses is why Roosevelt did not act sooner to confront the threat of Fascism or try to protect that “great and precious form of government” in places such as Spain, Austria, and France. Despite Hitchcock’s admiration for Roosevelt, “A Shadow Over the World” is largely an account of the President’s confusion and undue caution vis-à-vis European Fascism. The repetition can grow tiring, but that frustration is precisely the point. If Roosevelt really believed what he said, why did he wait so long to act on it?

One reason was the Neutrality Act, first passed in 1935 with Roosevelt’s reluctant support and then, in various iterations, renewed year after year, even in the wake of Italy’s invasion of Ethiopia, the Spanish Civil War, Kristallnacht, and Hitler’s seizure of Austria and the Czech Sudetenland. The laws constrained the United States from selling weapons to any government actively engaged in war—an appealing idea, perhaps, but one with perverse effects. The U.S. could not sell arms to the valorous Republican government in Spain, but it was free to sell oil and grain and machinery to the Nazis (who were not, technically, at war for most of the thirties).

The laws reflected mainstream American opinion at the time: Europe’s problems were Europe’s problems. So did U.S. immigration policy, which was generally hostile to newcomers, especially Jewish ones. Despite impassioned lobbying and organizing efforts, Roosevelt kept his distance from the plight of European Jews—he was willing to express sympathy but not to open the gates. In the spring of 1939, when nearly a thousand Jewish refugees aboard the *St. Louis*, a German steamer, reached American waters, U.S. officials sent them back to meet their fate in Hitler’s Europe.

Even as President, Roosevelt did not single-handedly have the power to defy the Neutrality Acts or to upend the nation’s restrictive immigration laws. Still, Hitchcock wonders, couldn’t he have done more to show which side the U.S. was on? From his first moment in office, Roosevelt enjoyed overwhelming Democratic majorities in both houses of Congress. His repeated electoral victories were landslides of a sort that has become unthinkable in the twenty-first century; in 1936, he won more than sixty per cent of the popular vote and a whopping ninety-eight per cent of the Electoral College. Thanks to the New Deal, he presided over a vastly

expanded administrative state that was responsive to executive direction. He also had a well-organized grassroots constituency. While Hitler was dismantling independent labor unions in Germany, Roosevelt was championing them in the U.S., which gave him a wide base of support for New Deal initiatives.

In short, Roosevelt was a strong President who showed, time and again, that he could lead the country in unlikely directions. That political power, however, came with limits. He may have had a Democratic majority, but it was a fractious one, dominated by Southern Democrats committed to preserving Jim Crow. And, as Hitchcock writes, antisemitism “coursed through the bloodstream of American public life,” including the blue-blooded foreign-policy establishment. At the White House, Roosevelt’s inner circle urged him to stay focussed on the Depression and the New Deal, the defining issues of his Presidency. Within the diplomatic corps, advisers suggested that the real global threat was the Soviet Union and the “militant left,” not whatever was happening in Italy or Germany.

Some Americans saw things differently, and their prescient warnings form the backbone of Hitchcock’s body politic. First among them is the newspaper columnist Dorothy Thompson, who secured an interview with Hitler in 1931 and spent the rest of the decade sounding the alarm about what she described as the Nazis’ “peculiar mixture of Nordic myth, antisemitism, militaristic tradition, desperado nationalism and moronized socialism.” Thompson was widely celebrated in her day as the “First Lady of American Journalism.” (She was also the wife of the novelist Sinclair Lewis, whose book [“It Can’t Happen Here”](#) stoked worries about homegrown Fascism.) As Hitchcock puts it, she was “almost Roosevelt’s alter ego,” the Cassandra who saw what was coming when the President couldn’t, or wouldn’t.

Thompson had her share of allies. “A Shadow Over the World” brings to life the vibrant antifascist “network” around Roosevelt, filled with journalists and policymakers and civic leaders desperate to make the White House listen. Their ranks included luminaries such as Ernest Hemingway, the Interior Secretary Harold L. Ickes (“the most outspoken antifascist in the cabinet”), and the rabbi Stephen Wise, all of whom deployed their public influence to spread the word about Nazi atrocities. Hitchcock also gives due

credit to the many women at the forefront of that same effort, including the Labor Secretary Frances Perkins, the reporter Martha Gellhorn (who later married Hemingway), and the First Lady, Eleanor Roosevelt. On this issue, as on so many others, Eleanor was out ahead of her husband.

Hitchcock's point in mapping this network is not just to provide a contrast to Roosevelt. He argues that the antifascist opinions and strategies developed in such circles provided a framework for national opinion and policy once events drew the U.S. into war. Given Hitchcock's interest in this broader civic context, it is surprising that he does not pay more attention to the Popular Front, the uneasy coalition of Communists, socialists, liberals, and progressives that defined left-wing politics in the late thirties. Though Popular Front groups took on domestic issues such as labor and civil rights, antifascism was their *raison d'être*. Indeed, it was the Stalin-dominated Comintern that called for such a coalition in 1935 to oppose the urgent threat of global Fascism. Years later, during the Red Scare, American Communists joked that their greatest crime was to have been "prematurely antifascist" in an age when few Americans were prepared to face reality.

Although the antifascist left may have been vindicated by history, the widespread association of antifascism with Communism helps explain why Americans, including Roosevelt, came so late to the cause. During the thirties, anti-Communism was at least as powerful as antifascism in the U.S., and many Americans expressed skepticism about any political movement associated with Moscow. In 1938, when the Texas congressman Martin Dies, Jr., became chairman of a House committee tasked with investigating "un-American activities," his putative aim was to go after Communists and Fascists equally. The Communist Party did itself no favors the following year when, in the wake of the Nazi-Soviet non-aggression pact, it performed an about-face on Fascism. The pact was a disaster for the Popular Front, but the severing of the ideational link between Communism and antifascism probably helped the antifascist cause at home. After 1939, it became possible—and necessary—to envision an antifascist politics that could be defined as truly American.

According to Hitchcock, Roosevelt always "instinctively hated fascism." But not until 1939 did he start to embrace the idea that a literal war against actually existing Fascist powers would be both desirable and inevitable. The

title “A Shadow Over the World” comes from a speech Roosevelt delivered that September, just weeks after Hitler invaded Poland, launching the Second World War. “I should like to be able to offer the hope that the shadow over the world might swiftly pass,” he told Congress. “I cannot. The facts compel my stating, with candor, that darker periods may lie ahead.”

At last, he sounded more like Dorothy Thompson, unflinching and resolute. Even so, it would take more than two years for the U.S. to enter the war. Hitchcock thinks that putting the right ideas in place was a necessary first step; without Roosevelt’s early articulation of aims, it would have been impossible to mobilize American society on the epic scale required for total war. Over the past half century, Americans have grown accustomed to regional conflicts fought by specialized professional troops, in which the support of Congress or the American public seems more or less irrelevant. The Second World War demanded mass buy-in; every factory, every worker, every young man, every housewife had to play a role. Hitchcock maintains that persuasion had to come first—that, for a democracy to fight, its citizens must know what they are fighting for. “The Second World War was at its heart a war of ideas,” he concludes.

But ideas go only so far. If the Second World War was an ideological war, it was also an economic and bureaucratic one, fought for control of the world’s raw materials and industrial capacity. When it came to the practicalities of mobilization, administrative competence proved at least as important as high-flown rhetoric. So did the capability to manufacture vast quantities of airplanes, tanks, and bullets. Hitchcock believes that Roosevelt’s New Deal vision blended seamlessly with his war aims; both emphasized democracy, collective action, and global interdependence. New Deal experiments also helped build the bureaucratic infrastructure that made the war effort possible.

In the end, it was neither ideas nor organization—neither Thompson nor Roosevelt—that persuaded the U.S. to enter the war. The Japanese did that, when they attacked Pearl Harbor, in December, 1941. As a historian of the European theatre, Hitchcock devotes only a single chapter to Japan’s imperial expansion in Asia during the thirties. He also ends his book before Pearl Harbor, arguing that the essential features of the American war effort, including the national commitment to fighting Fascism, were in place by

then. For Hitchcock, the turning points came earlier, in 1940 and 1941, as Hitler blitzed his way through Continental Europe. Moved more by geopolitical reality than by idealism, Roosevelt began to insist that the U.S. would have to aid Britain—and fight Fascism—or face the extinction of democracy.

By the fall of 1941, much of the country had come to agree with him, though influential groups, such as the isolationist America First Committee, mounted fierce opposition. Hitchcock highlights key moments of escalating national commitment: Roosevelt's "Four Freedoms" speech, on January 6, 1941, with its rousing statement of war aims; the creation of the lend-lease policy that March, with its promise of virtually unlimited arms for Great Britain; and the release of the Atlantic Charter, in August, 1941, jointly issued by Roosevelt and Winston Churchill, which envisioned a postwar order characterized by free trade, democratic rights, economic security, and territorial stability. The implication is that the U.S. would have entered the war and fought the good fight even without Pearl Harbor. But it's worth remembering that the U.S. did not declare war on Germany until December 11th, four days after the Japanese attack. Even then, Hitler was the first mover. Only after Germany declared war on the U.S. did the U.S. respond in kind.

After the war ended, of course, anti-Communism became the guiding principle in U.S. foreign policy, bringing Washington into friendly relations with Franco's Spain, Salazar's Portugal, and military dictatorships elsewhere. But antifascism remained a vital part of Americans' self-conception, as if entering the war and winning it had always been America's destiny. Hitchcock's book restores a sense of contingency to that story, even as it tries to draw lessons from the nineteen-thirties. One might conclude from America's halting embrace of antifascism during that decade that we should listen to the Dorothy Thompsons of the world, who warn that the unthinkable—global war, societal collapse, genocide—really can happen. The difficulty is knowing which Dorothy Thompsons to listen to. False certainty is common enough in political life, and history is crowded with confident warnings that proved wrong. Roosevelt is arguably the more useful example, precisely because of his hesitation, pragmatism, and self-interest. What made him a great President, in Hitchcock's view, was his willingness to watch and listen, and to change his mind as events unfolded.

“A Shadow Over the World” describes Roosevelt’s “evolution from an anti-war pacifist, a nationalist, and an American exceptionalist to a man who embraced a stunningly ambitious global task: the safeguarding of democracy in a world that had fallen under the shadow of fascism.” But Roosevelt did not abandon American exceptionalism, even as he made his case for global war. Instead, he sought to transform what it meant—not the land grabs of Manifest Destiny or the imagined security of isolationism but a commitment to defending democratic ideals and basic human welfare in the face of global tyranny and immiseration.

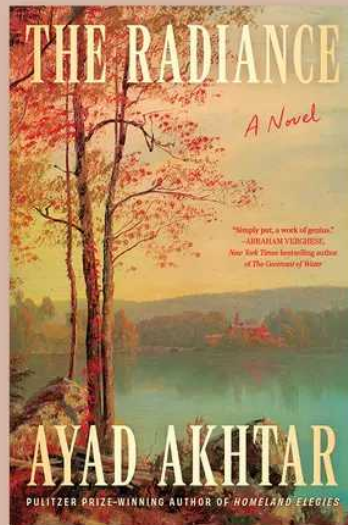
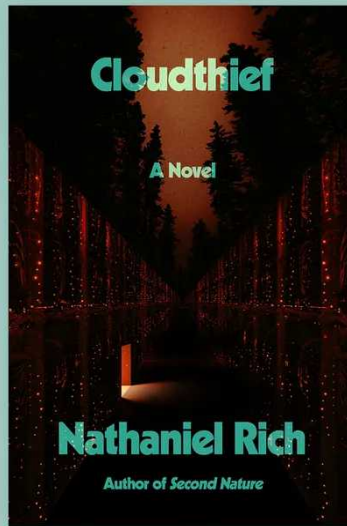
Roosevelt’s blind spots and foot-dragging are worth remembering as a counterpoint to the self-congratulatory Greatest Generation myth. But, as Hitchcock notes, the remarkable thing is that he changed his mind at all, and that the nation followed. For the rest of the twentieth century, America’s role in combatting Fascism helped define its national identity. At a moment when that self-conception seems to be waning, “A Shadow Over the World” makes a vigorous case for antifascism as a central inheritance of the modern American political tradition. ♦

Books

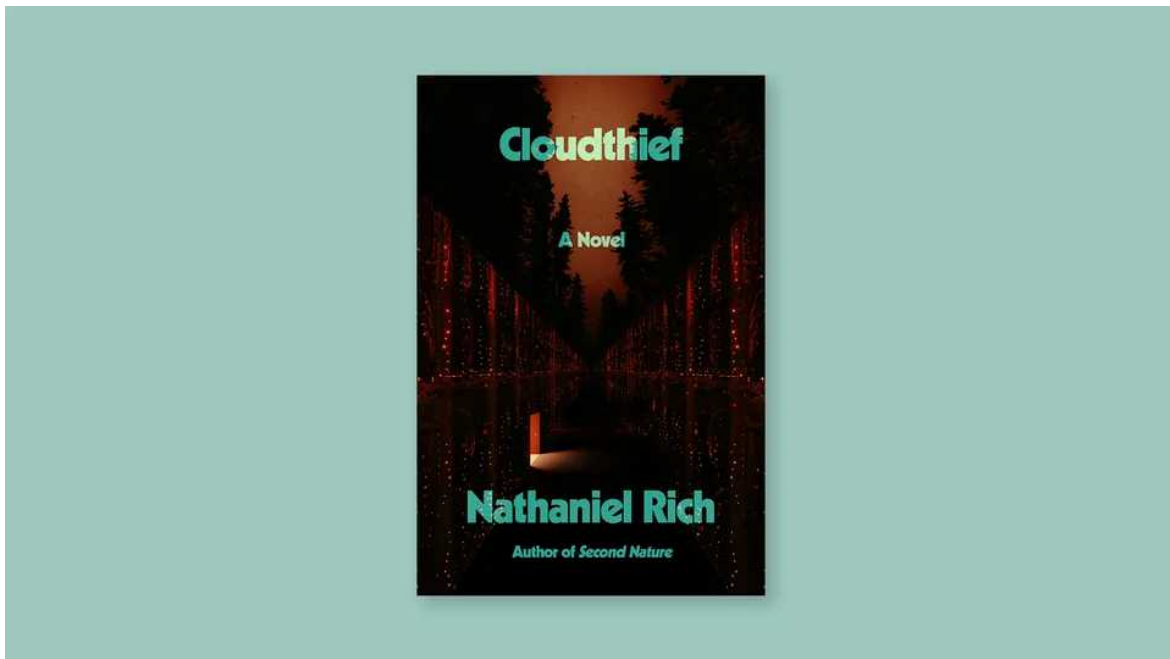
Briefly Noted

“The Radiance,” “Cloudthief,” “Dear Dealer,” and “Citizen Beast.”

September 28, 2026



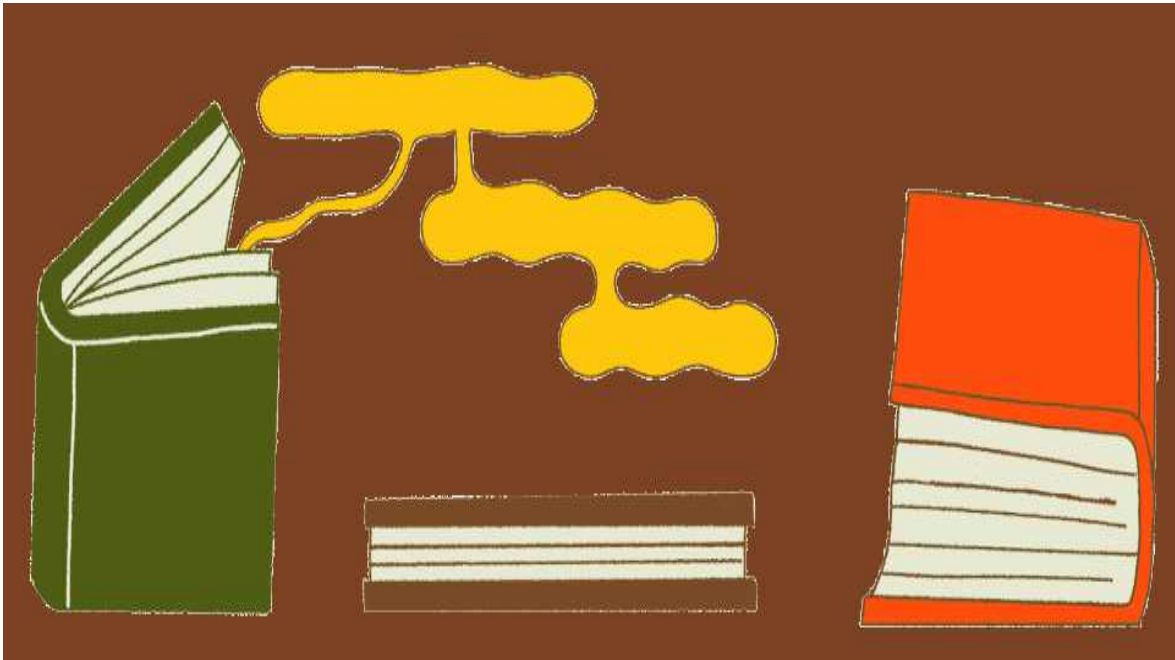
The Radiance, by *Ayad Akhtar (Summit)*. The narrator of this form-bending novel is a man who shares the author’s name and profession, and who, at the story’s outset, is the victim of a hit-and-run. When he wakes up in a hospital, he finds himself transformed with new insight: “I suddenly felt I was seeing not with my eyes, but through my chest.” To his dismay, he realizes that “language is insufficient to the task” of imparting his experience, and as he struggles to make sense of this change—or perhaps because of it—he is increasingly attuned to the darkness plaguing friends and strangers alike. “I was baffled that words had ever been able to distract me from my disgust at the gratuitous welter beyond them,” Ayad remarks, prompting readers to reflect on their own insulation.



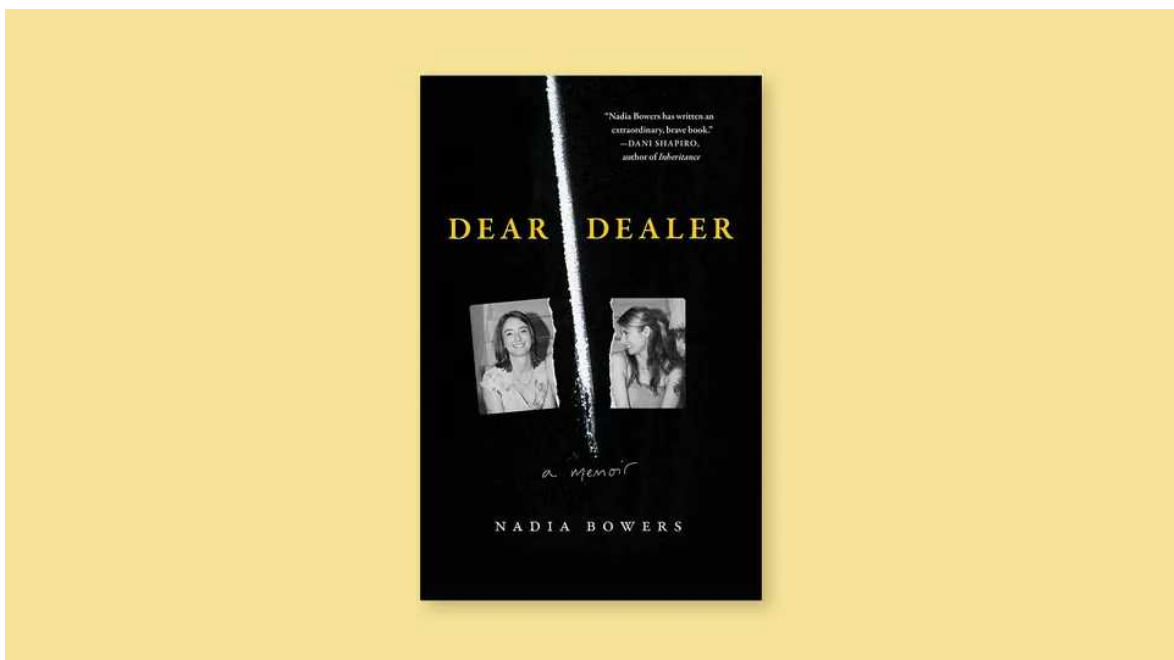
Cloudthief, by *Nathaniel Rich (MCD)*. This hardboiled heist story follows a pair of down-and-out lovers from Manhattan to Oklahoma as they attempt to steal hard drives from a towering data center. Tim, an impressionable and unscrupulous journalist, is pulled into the scheme by the wily Virginia, a decrepit but beautiful woman he meets while attempting to rob the storage unit she lives in. Their idea—to leverage sensitive personal and business information contained in the servers for an enormous ransom—is both ridiculous and ingenious. Although the novel’s meditations on technology and the environment can be tedious, the time it spends tracking these two on

their adventure (which makes up the majority of the book) is brisk and entertaining.

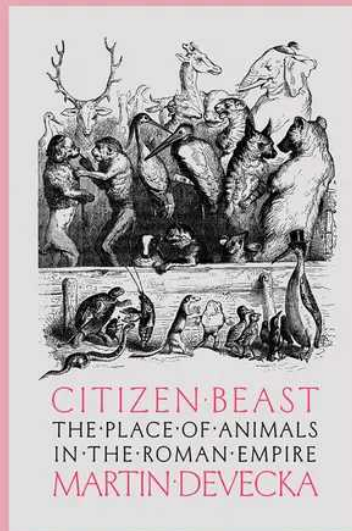
What We're Reading



Discover notable new fiction, nonfiction, and poetry.



Dear Dealer, by *Nadia Bowers (Gallery)*. Expanded from a piece for “This American Life,” this memoir charts the aftermath of the death, from an opioid overdose, of the author’s sister, Sasha. Written as a series of letters to Sasha’s unknown dealer, Bowers’s book offers her a way to process her grief and parse her relationship with her sister. Sasha’s addiction began from attempts to suppress Tourette’s tics: she took over-the-counter sedatives first, before turning to synthetic opioids. Bowers recounts repeatedly examining Sasha’s cellphone in the hope of identifying the person who sold her deadly drugs—a quest that she ultimately acknowledges is futile. “I’ve been using you. Like a fix,” she admits to the phantom dealer. “It’s hard to imagine my life without you. But I need to try.”



Citizen Beast, by *Martin Devecka (Johns Hopkins)*. Drawing on a variety of sources—from philosophical treatises to poems and popular jokes—this compact study shows how writers of the Roman era rendered animals, domestic and wild, as imperial subjects. Whether kneeling supplicants (elephants), gladiatorial executioners (bears), agricultural laborers (oxen), or divine messengers (birds), animals were imagined as active (which is not to say free) participants in the creation and expansion of the Empire, with roles that complemented those of their human counterparts, élites as well as enslaved people. While unearthing these depictions, Devecka argues that

they formed “part of a social project that aims to degrade and subjugate human beings and other animals alike.”

Gut Renos of Ionesco and Chekhov

In “Delirium” and “The Cherry Orchard,” experimental directors smash up and rebuild classic plays.

By Emily Nussbaum

September 24, 2026



Igor Golyak’s “Delirium,” a madcap, sneakily emotional reinvention of the 1962 Eugène Ionesco play “Frenzy for Two, or More,” opens with an alarming tableau: a dust-coated man is lying face down, crushed by a heavy door that covers his back like a turtle’s shell. He wears an infantry helmet but also a fancy suit with a cummerbund, and after wriggling out from under the door he props it up so that it faces him, knocks on it in a panic, and finally “breaks in” to the room he’s created. Then, making himself at home, he sits on a stack of four mattresses, which emit a loud groan. The night I attended, the audience giggled uneasily—a woman was clearly trapped down there, pancaked between mattresses as if buried in rubble. The man rescued her, but first he bounced on the bed a bit, experimentally, playing her groans like a piano.

This is our introduction to He and She, two clownish, pugilistic lovers who are locked in a war of words, even as a literal war rages outside. Golyak, an avant-garde director trained in Moscow, has made a set of aggressive edits to Ionesco's surreal post-Second World War farce, trimming roles, amping up the slapstick, and framing the stage in industrial scaffolding draped with wobbly sheets of corrugated metal, which threaten to come crashing down. Golyak has added a big orange fish, which floats buoyantly in an aquarium, and he's replaced the tatty bathrobes that Ionesco gave the couple with seedy Vegas finery, as if they'd dressed for a party that will never start. He's made elegant additions, too, such as stitching in a lovely fairy tale that Ionesco wrote for his daughter and staging it with a whimsical storm of soap bubbles. Still, the core of the show remains the same: a couple ignores a public battle for a private one. Early in the play, She fumes at He, "A snail and a turtle, they're the *same thing!*" Later, He holds up a telephone and insists it's cheese. When grenades fly through their windows, they toss them back out, eager to resume their debate.

Golyak, whose parents fled Ukraine for Boston when he was nine, is the scrappy founder of Arlekin, a theatre company in Needham, Massachusetts, that is composed mainly of immigrants. His inventive productions often explore real-life stories of violence and displacement, including the much praised "Our Class," which centers on an infamous pogrom in which Poles burned their Jewish neighbors to death in a barn. "Delirium," in contrast, feels universal, a serum synthesized after the Second World War that still applies to modern wounds. He and She could be stuck in any war, in any room, anywhere in the world. And yet their repartee, full of insults ("Seducer!") and loony demands ("Give me the definition of 'insinuation'!"), is warped in the way contemporary language is warped: they're gaslighting and trolling each other, like posters on some ancient Reddit thread that can no longer be parsed by outsiders. On the director's Substack, "Theater of Questions," he describes Ionesco's absurdist scenario as a "shell" emptied of meaning, and this is true on multiple levels: the words are placeholders shuffled around in a deceptive game; they suggest scattered bullet casings, the residue of violence; they are safe places to hide out in, a rigid cover for vulnerable beings—turtles, snails, refugees—who are looking for comfort. But Golyak's most significant intervention is to amplify the central romance, by slicing in flashes of sensuality and warmth, making He and She seem less like nemeses than like intimate partners,

constructing a bridge of private jokes that allows them to shimmy their way past dread.

“Delirium” also felt like a relief to me—it offered a break from the usual polemic realism. Absurdity can be a liberation: it’s permission to stop making sense, an open door to ambiguity. Still, what makes Golyak’s production really roar into flame is the astonishing magnetism of his performers, Chulpan Khamatova, a Russian theatre and movie star who fled her homeland because of Putin’s invasion of Ukraine, and Andrey Burkovskiy, a celebrated Russian figure skater and actor. They’ve got Chaplin chops, with Khamatova a mischievous Kewpie doll in a mop-top blond wig and Burkovskiy a craggy acrobat whose expressions shift, like tectonic plates, from petulance to yearning. In Golyak’s vision, these two are not dead-eyed Rock ’Em Sock ’Em robots but flawed, tender humans who are vain, silly, angry, defensive, horny, innocent, and triumphant. Mainly, however, they’re terrified, and determined to fend off that fear. They eavesdrop on their neighbors, who are being kidnapped or, perhaps, tortured. Objects tumble from the scaffolding; bombs explode. But the couple’s focus is ultimately on each other. When a bullet flies into the room, each instinctively turns and asks, “Are you hurt?” Only once they know that they’re safe can the game begin again.

Simon Stone’s glamorous renovation of Chekhov’s tragicomic masterpiece “The Cherry Orchard” attempts something similar, with less success. In Stone’s version of the play, which is performed in Korean with English subtitles, he retains Chekhov’s plot about a fading aristocratic clan in denial about the sale of its home, but he dilutes the poetry, simplifies the characters, and flattens the themes, producing something like a deep-plane facelift—it’s pretty but unnervingly smooth. Stone’s “Cherry Orchard,” set in modern Seoul, is about a spoiled, wealthy family, the Songs, who run a corporation that is on the verge of collapse, owing to the family’s mismanagement. In place of a decrepit manor, the Songs live in a fabulous modernist mansion with a high-peaked slanted roof that cascades, in dramatic fashion, all the way to the ground in the form of a wide, tiered staircase, calling to mind a game of Chutes and Ladders—some characters will rise, others will tumble down. The actors regularly jog up to the peak, where they declaim their political beliefs, brood, or threaten suicide. The front of the house is all glass—a lousy place to throw stones.

That set, which was designed by Saul Kim, is genuinely spectacular to look at, as are the bright, casual costumes and the clever lighting. The cast is game, too, particularly Son Sang-kyu, who is very funny as a feckless chatterbox with a thing for retro record players, and Moon Choi, who plays the moodier, more legitimately aggrieved of two Song daughters. I was initially intrigued by Stone's commitment to laughs, with the "tragi-" ripped off Chekhov's comedy like a sales tag. Unfortunately, the results, while splashily entertaining, feel helium-light instead of morally weighty, with each encounter at once high-stakes and emotionally obvious. The players flatly declare their judgments: "She has ideas well above her station. It's not appropriate." They get sloppy drunk, then trauma-dump or make ill-advised passes, then apologize. By the final act, Chekhov's subtle, empathetic, often unspoken power dynamics feel transmuted into a soapy romp that gestures at the class-warfare themes of "Succession" or "Parasite," but without the former's black wit or the latter's pungency.

Instead, there's a Bravo oomph to the shenanigans. Jeon Do-yeon, who plays the family's matriarch, is colorfully slinky as a globe-trotting party widow, a vain, compulsively seductive narcissist who macks on her daughters' men like a *Real Housewife* given a villain's edit. A set of interlocking love triangles scores harsh laughs off familiar archetypes: a fuckboy, an incel, a soy boy, a finance bro who won't commit. But farce can take you only so far. When there are glimmers, here and there, of unexpected angles—a sweet, strange speech about an abandoned turntable; the gentle bond between the younger Song daughter and a left-wing scholar—they quickly dissolve, subsumed by the archly satirical twists of the plot. Without authentic longing, and without any bittersweet complexity to the portrait of one social order replacing another, we're left with little more than puffs of amusement, enough to escalate your mood but bound to fade by morning. ♦

The Predator Catcher Turns Predatory in “Primetime”

A dazzling, wolfish performance from Robert Pattinson anchors Lance Oppenheim’s period piece about the rise and fall of a reality-TV host.

By Justin Chang

September 25, 2026



The title of “Primetime,” Lance Oppenheim’s thriller about the making and unmaking of the scuzzy reality-TV phenomenon “To Catch a Predator,” tells us we’re watching a period piece. The period is 2006, when the golden age of streamable content is barely a speck on the media horizon. YouTube is less than a year old, Netflix is a DVD-by-mail service, and a prime-time slot is still one of the most coveted jewels in broadcast television. Of the many throwback jolts that “Primetime” aims to deliver, none is more jarringly analog than the sight of a TV schedule on a wall at NBCUniversal’s offices, with shows like “Gilmore Girls” and “Veronica Mars” stacked on primary-colored planks. When the network’s C.E.O., Jeff Zucker—played, in a vertiginous mix of authenticity and uncanny-valley weirdness, by Zucker

himself—announces that he’s moving “To Catch a Predator” to Wednesdays at 9 *P.M.*, he actually *moves* it, with his hand. Spreadsheets existed in 2006, but here they are kept, like everyone’s shame and scruples, firmly out of sight.

With “To Catch a Predator,” Chris Hansen (Robert Pattinson), the show’s immaculately suited host, and Andie Bender (Merritt Wever), his formidable producer, have transformed a popular segment on the news magazine “Dateline NBC” into a skin-crawling sensation. The opening scenes of “Primetime,” which was written by Ajon Singh, set up the format of the show, which is itself an elaborate setup—a trap laid for men soliciting sex with minors. One such mark (Tony Revolori) turns up at a suburban address, expecting to find a thirteen-year-old girl he’s met online. Little does he know that the house is rigged with cameras, and that a TV crew supervised by Bender is hiding inside. He’s welcomed in by a “decoy” (Phoebe Bridgers), an adult passing for a minor, and then the trap is sprung: Hansen emerges and confronts the man with a smirk, a damning transcript of illicit chat messages, and the news that all this is being recorded for television. After some squirmy interrogation, the disgraced target is asked to leave—at which point he’s arrested outside by armed police officers, who have been working closely with the crew.

It’s a queasily compelling spectacle, though perhaps also a redundant one. Even for those of us who didn’t watch “To Catch a Predator” when it aired, from 2004 to 2007, the documentary “Predators,” which was released last year, told us more than we could have ever wanted to know. Its director, David Osit, sifting through hours of “Catch” footage and interviewing its original participants, asked tough questions about the ethics of an enterprise that presented itself as a moral crusade but was ultimately torn apart by competing imperatives: Was this a law-enforcement tool, a piece of entertainment, or both? “Predators” was thoughtful and productively disturbing, at least until its posturing final moments, when Osit, interrogating a proudly unrepentant Hansen, tried to turn the show’s formal devices against him: split-screen surveillance footage, a post-interview walk of shame. It was a clever but hollow bit of visual mimicry, a halfhearted takedown that devolved into a futile shrug.

“Primetime,” as it happens, is Oppenheim’s first stab at fiction. He previously directed the documentary features “Some Kind of Heaven” (2021), a panoramic portrait of a retirement community, and “Spermworld” (2024), which explored the growing online market for sperm donations—the end and the beginning of life in two wittily framed, dryly observant films. Both were shot by David Bolen, whom Oppenheim has retained for “Primetime.” Their work here evokes the grubby, pixellated textures and the seedy-dreamy ambience of a bygone trash-TV era. The atmosphere persists even when the characters are off the air, as if to suggest that the seeping rot of the show has metastasized into every moment of their lives. The frame is squarish in shape, recalling the years before wide-screens were widespread; the colors, especially the flesh tones, are luridly oversaturated. At times, Oppenheim zooms in on his characters so intently that he seems ready to claw their faces off, the better to penetrate through to their darkest depths.

But what would he find? Pattinson’s dazzlingly contoured performance doesn’t provide any easy answers. His Chris Hansen is all flashy surface, full of jittery go-getter energy and disturbingly devoid of inner life. At NBC, he’s a second-tier golden boy, stuck in the shadow of the “Dateline” anchor Stone Phillips (Bill Heck), who’s off doing serious reporting in places like Afghanistan. (The war on terror, the film suggests, was one of the few things that could command American attention spans in the early two-thousands, along with Britney Spears and reality TV.) Meanwhile, Hansen’s work has taken a toll on his family life in Stamford, Connecticut, where he occasionally drops in on his wife (Anna Faris) and their two young sons. Then it’s back on the road to sniff out sex offenders in towns like Fort Myers, Florida, where one of Hansen’s extramarital affairs has attracted the notice of the *National Enquirer*. The irony of America’s most famous entrapment artist facing his own public humiliation is not lost on him.

Challenged on all sides, Hansen finds that his only recourse is to throw himself, with ever more frenzied self-seriousness, into his work. Sitting down with Dan Plum (Skyler Gisondo), a naïve yet ambitious twenty-three-year-old who’s been cast as a decoy, Hansen denies that what they’re doing has any relation to acting; they’re in the truth-telling business. His own behavior belies that notion. Preparing to make his “gotcha!” entrance, Hansen rehearses the incriminating chat messages that he plans to read: “I will undress you, and you will undress me,” he murmurs, and Pattinson,

magnificently repellent, draws out the juicy salaciousness in every word. If you saw the actor's dual performances in "Mickey 17" (2025), you know that his single most chameleonic attribute is his voice, which he can inflect and distort with virtuosic skill. No less slippery are his *matinée*-idol looks, which can turn wolfish or ratty on a dime, as if his beauty were moldering away from within. Again and again, Pattinson evinces a pig-in-shit delight in his characters' rough edges, frayed nerves, and devious motives—not that Hansen would ever admit to the last, convinced as he is of the nobility of his cause. "We are cleansing the world of an ancient evil," he declares.

His colleagues are not so high-minded, and as pressures and budgets mount—more episodes, fresh locations, higher-profile targets—the film becomes a vision of something strikingly relatable: the low-morale workplace. When Bender considers moving to a rival network, Wever fleshes out the tough carapace of a woman who, even under the thorniest of circumstances, never stops calculating her next move. "Decoy Dan," as Hansen christens him, just wants to be an actor, and Gisondo shows the layers of the young man's confusion, vulnerability, and desperation as he realizes how limited his opportunities are. The team's creepiest and most contented member is Xavier Von Erck (Matthew Maher), an online vigilante who arranges the show's meetups, spending his days and nights fishing around in online chat rooms.

And what of the fish? Like "Predators," "Primetime" allows us to feel a twinge of pity on their behalf. One target has a disability; another turns out to be a rabbi, who responds to his confrontation with suitably Talmudic indignation. Singh's script climaxes with the fatal 2006 incident that ultimately took "To Catch a Predator" off the air—a would-be predator's suicide, triggered by the zealous overreach of the show's camera crew and the police. But the film's depiction of the tragedy feels cynical and rote, and one shot in particular, all meticulously art-directed blood spatter, throws the aesthetic virtues and dramatic limitations of "Primetime" into sharp relief. Oppenheim has persuasively rendered a grotesque phenomenon, but his curiosity seems to stop at how everyone and everything looked. There's no deeper analytical heft to the movie, no larger curiosity about what "To Catch a Predator" meant then or what it might mean now, especially in the wake of the sex-trafficking conspiracy theories of QAnon and the very real, still emerging horrors of the Epstein files.

Hansen, who left NBC in 2013 but remains a leader in the pervert-ambushing space, has spoken about having considered a sting operation against Jeffrey Epstein in 2015. The men he exposed are small-timers by comparison, although Oppenheim has cast them with a nasty, stunt-like relish, starting with Revoluri, who came to fame as a fresh-faced young bellhop in “The Grand Budapest Hotel” (2014). Another offender is played by Jonathan Lipnicki, whom some will remember as the cherubic kid from “Jerry Maguire” (1996), and who here has graduated to doing unspeakable things with whipped cream. The most tortured of the lot comes to us in the form of Alex Winter, now all but unrecognizable as the youthful co-lead of “Bill & Ted’s Excellent Adventure” (1989). By the time you *do* recognize him, you may let out a grim chuckle at what I can only assume is Oppenheim’s expression of sympathy for the Devil—a reminder, if we needed it, that every child predator was once a child, too. ♦

Poems

- [Weeping Willow, Nantucket](#)
- [D'Angelo in Starlight](#)

Poems

Weeping Willow, Nantucket

By Stephanie Burt

September 27, 2026



They can't get off the island either.
That's why their resolve to bend and never break—
itself about to break
when the worst winds come—
gives them their only course; their versets turn inward,
like artichoke prickles, and overlap, almost awkward,
a way to repel, and accept, the pelting weather.

That's how it feels in the rain. They hold together.
In sun, the willow shakes their loosened limbs, then sweeps them out
to take in the neediest seekers, looking out
for cottontails, squirrels, killdeer, and the lovers who come
for privacy and don't seem to mind
how dirty their cutoffs' butts get. They're of one mind.
Some catkins dangle low enough to feather

a forehead, or tickle and bother
some friends-to-lovers arc, or scratch
the lawn where nosy seagulls start from scratch.
Sometimes the willow thinks one of their neighbors has come
to look down on them: the beach rose
swinging her hips, or the high oak that throws
its own shade, or else the spray of blooming heather

on the hill. But only the willow means shelter.
Only the willow offers so many fine arrows,
directions for the patience that arose
in us when we first found these canopies' welcome,
their design (a design for living: pale, supple) that grows
from the willow's fingertips, those jointed rows
that draw, and withdraw, and revive. They could live here forever.

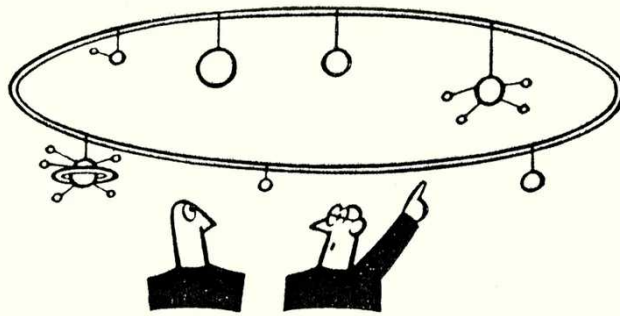
This is drawn from "Read the Room."

Poems

D'Angelo in Starlight

By Ishion Hutchinson

September 27, 2026



Good God, the devil is up to his old tricks.
His old jealous awe, being where it should not.
He rides aslant blue ether. He brings down that

voice of reed and steel. He whistles like a
comet through a crooked tooth sweat a chain
gang's moan. The brightest falls when he whistles.

As it falls, brightens the Archer's black hole.
Stars grow quiet mid-sea. Goddammit, he
skins the brightest he mirrors, cuts clean strings
of wind, the bastard of history repeats

all that iron deposit of bad rain.
He can swell a man's lunar hours big
with a haunt no root-work spell could undo.

Not a preacher's lash, not the devil's tongue.
He is both and none. Waiting at the gate.

Puzzles & Games

- [The Crossword: Monday, September 28, 2026](#)

Crossword

The Crossword: Monday, September 28, 2026

A challenging puzzle.

By Will Nediger

September 28, 2026



The Mail

- [Letters from Our Readers](#)

Letters from Our Readers

Readers respond to M. R. O'Connor's story about smokejumpers, Kelefa Sanneh's piece about A.I. music, Jennifer Wilson's article about lingerie, and Anna Holmes's home-ownership essay.

September 28, 2026

Things of Nature

I was intrigued by M. R. O'Connor's article about wildland firefighters who leap out of airplanes ("Going Up in Smoke," September 7th). My father was a smokejumper from 1948 to 50, flying out of a base in Idaho City. He certainly had the "it" that O'Connor captures—that remarkable combination of fortitude, discipline, and high risk tolerance. These qualities served him well. He worked his way into the professional class by joining the U.S. Air Force and then using the G.I. Bill to attend dental school. It was only when I read O'Connor's piece that it occurred to me that his training as a smokejumper was what enabled him to survive being shot down over Korea, and then to endure being a prisoner of war.

Unfortunately, the horrors of that experience never released him. For the rest of his life, he was plagued by night terrors. The only time I saw him at peace was when he was in the backcountry wilderness. The suggestion of creating a "modern G.I. Bill" for those who work on fire and trail crews is a good one. I wonder what my father's life would have been like if, as a society, we rewarded the care and preservation of our natural environment, rather than violence and destruction in other lands.

*Kathleen M. Pape, Psy.D.
Seattle, Wash.*

Something Borrowed

While I appreciated Kelefa Sanneh’s analysis of how A.I. is used to compose music, I noticed that he overlooked how human composers, myself included, learn and create (Pop Music, September 7th). Composers of both classical and popular music study what came before them, absorbing and reworking earlier melodies, harmonies, rhythms, and techniques. Beethoven urged musicians to study Handel and learn “how to achieve great effects, by such simple means,” and Stravinsky is quoted as saying, “A good composer does not imitate; he steals.” In the realm of popular music, Paul McCartney admitted, “For me, the first thing was to copy other people, like Buddy Holly and Little Richard—and Elvis.”

Similarly, A.I. analyzes existing music and generates new combinations from what it has gleaned. Though that raises legitimate questions about copyright, consent, and compensation, learning from earlier music is hardly an invention of A.I. Indeed, completely original music, unconnected to anything a listener has previously heard, would perhaps be impossible to understand. Originality often lies not in creating from nothing but in transforming what already exists.

Jason Eyster
Chelsea, Mich.

Femme Fatale

Jennifer Wilson, in her piece on lingerie, gathers the evidence for an argument she doesn’t quite make (“Strange Bedfellows,” September 14th). The right hasn’t simply taken sexy back; it has redefined who gets to be sexy and drawn a hard line around “real” women. Take the American Eagle Outfitters ad that Wilson describes, with its genetic determinism and praise for Sydney Sweeney’s “great jeans.” Wilson reads the ad as a joke about Sweeney’s “supposed physical supremacy” that seemed to give “free press to a right-wing talking point.” But the ad, by presenting Sweeney’s body as proof of heritable womanhood, served conservatives in another way, too. A “real” woman in their narrative is a cisgender, fertile one; trans women and nonbinary people have no place. Lingerie-clad conservatives and liberals now may look strikingly alike—but on the right only some women get to be sexy. It isn’t just a fashion trend. It’s a boundary intended to keep people out.

Leora Tanenbaum
New York City

Home Truth

I'd like to offer a perspective different from Anna Holmes's on the difficulties of homeownership (The Weekend Essay, September 12th, newyorker.com/holmes-on-homeownership). Holmes is surrounded by friends who are rich. This is the case for a lot of people who, like myself, live in New York and work in media. Here's the thing I've learned: though there are some people with generational wealth and good financial habits, none of them are twenty-five. If you're of a lower socioeconomic status and have mainly wealthy friends, you'll probably pick up all of their bad habits and none of the good ones necessary to buy a home.

My husband and I purchased a three-bedroom, three-bathroom house in South Slope, Brooklyn, without the help of generational wealth. We did it by saving and by investing. During our twenties, it took tremendous effort to avoid the behavior of our wealthy friends, who would go to every wedding, spend their entire paychecks, and enroll in graduate school without a second thought. Such decisions will cause the kind of frustration Holmes describes. But I'm not making a who-made-better-choices argument—I wanted to go on the European castle trips I was invited to, too. It's just that it is hard to make good decisions in a society that values all of these things.

I was financially literate, which gave my husband and me a head start, but friendships are what ultimately made the difference. We enrolled our son in a local public school and surrounded ourselves with people who had the financial habits we had to normalize in order to eventually own property. These kinds of friends have advice, and they will help you. Spend your time with them, not the ones who will grumble about a vacation home you'll never have.

Bourree Lam
Brooklyn, N.Y.

•

Letters should be sent with the writer's name, address, and daytime phone number via e-mail to themail@newyorker.com. Letters may be edited for length and clarity, and may be published in any medium. We regret that owing to the volume of correspondence we cannot reply to every letter.



Table of Contents

Goings On

[The Sublime Somali Bridges African and Western Jazz](#)

[Ugly Baby Is Hot but Has a Personality, Too](#)

The Talk of the Town

[The President vs. the Press](#)

[Are Public Spaces Really for the Public?](#)

[More Sunshine with Joey Arias and Basil Twist](#)

[Detecting Notes of . . . Citi Field?](#)

[Cartoon Recession Indicators](#)

Reporting & Essays

[Hockey Dads and Hockey Sons](#)

[How Paweł Pawlikowski Learned to Film Europe's Fractures](#)

[Should I Stay or Should I Go?](#)

[Why Doesn't Anyone Want to Fix One of America's Scariest Roads?](#)

Shouts & Murmurs

[Cookie Monster Tries to Meet His A.I. Mandate](#)

Fiction

[Narrow Escape](#)

[Your Guide to Navigating the Parent Group Chat](#)

The Critics

[The Unknowable Miley Cyrus](#)

[Why America Looks the Way It Does](#)

[How America Became Antifascist](#)

[Briefly Noted](#)

[Gut Renos of Ionesco and Chekhov](#)

[The Predator Catcher Turns Predatory in "Primetime"](#)

Poems

[Weeping Willow, Nantucket](#)

[D'Angelo in Starlight](#)

Puzzles & Games

[The Crossword: Monday, September 28, 2026](#)

The Mail

[Letters from Our Readers](#)